Heroes of Halfmoon

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Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, F/M, Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)/Kesi (Defiance), Cyrus/Lyra (Defiance), Catra (She-Ra) & Kesi (Defiance), Catra (She-Ra) & Lyra (Defiance) & Cyrus (Defiance) & Caspin (Raised in Halfmoon), Catra (She-Ra)/Kesi (Defiance), Kittrina (Defiance) & Caspin (Raised in Halfmoon)

Characters:
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Additional Tags:
Fluff and Angst, Hurt/Comfort, Blood and Injury, Action & Romance, Soulmates, Soul Bond, Politics, Recursive Fanfiction, Kesi Cult, Kesi is the Besti, Scent Marking, Polyamory, Canon Lesbian Relationship, Canon Lesbian Character, Flipping Defiance Off as We Walk Backwards into Hell, Halfmoon (She-Ra), Magicats (She-Ra), Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Therapy Cat Melog (She-Ra), Cuddling & Snuggling, Dreams vs. Reality, Childhood Trauma, Graphic Depictions of Smooching, Canon-Typical Violence, Nightmares, Everyone Needs A Hug

Language:
English

Series:
Part 13 of Defiance - Raised in Halfmoon AU

Collections:
Of Wing & Claw - Apocrypha

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Heroes of Halfmoon

by tp9829, Zelenal

Summary

The second coup attempt has been thwarted but all is not well in Halfmoon. As our heroes recover, they try to piece together their forever-changed lives.

- Inspired by Defiance by TheNotebookWizard

Chapter 1: Convalescence & Revelations

Chapter Summary

> With the second coup attempt now over, Cyrus tries to hold everything together and figure out what, exactly, happened.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Outside the Infirmary

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

One Hour After the Second Coup Attempt

Cyrus would admit it: he was pacing. Could you blame him? Barely an hour ago, his city was assaulted from within and without in yet another coup attempt. As if *that* wasn't bad enough, now his daughter and his wife were unconscious in the infirmary while Adora and Kesi were both still MIA. At least Caspin was safe, curled up in Percival's arms in a nearby chair.

The damage done to the city was *staggering* and they likely wouldn't have a full casualty count for a few more hours at best. All Cyrus knew on that front at the moment was that, once again, the Royal Guard had been whittled down to just a small handful of people and the palace guard wasn't in the best shape, either.

(The palace guard had also mobilized *way* too slowly and that was something that Cyrus fully planned on fixing in the near future. A month or three of the most intense drills that any of them had ever seen should whip them into shape.)

"Your Majesty, you should try to relax. The Queen and Princess are both in perfectly stable conditions," Percival said placatingly.

"I know, I know," Cyrus replied gruffly as he stilled his tail. "It's just that—"

"Make way!" came a voice from the other direction. "Her Highness' Seneschal needs treatment!"

Cyrus spun around, his eyes wide with shock as he saw two medics carefully rush in their direction carrying a stretcher. On said stretcher laid an unconscious Kesi, her white fur stained red with blood. Her stomach was bound by a compression bandage but, startlingly, she appeared to be bleeding through it.

Cyrus quickly threw the doors to the infirmary open and ushered the medics inside.

"Kesi? What happened to her?" Lenio asked as he shot up from where he had been sitting at his desk before quickly making his way over to where the medics laid Kesi down on the nearest available bed. A diagnostic spell was already starting to flare to life over his hand.

"She was found in an alleyway near the Waxing Market. She was unconscious and had a knife in her stomach. Not all of the blood is hers; the corpse of one of the traitors was found nearby with his throat slashed open. We applied first aid but she was bleeding through the bandages so we rushed her here," one of the medics reported.

"Damn good thing you did, too," Lenio said with the kind of calm that can only be gained through countless years of experience. He had run his diagnostic spell as the medic had talked. "He missed her bowels—thank the Stars Above—but the wound is deep and a major artery was hit. It's frankly a miracle that she's still alive."

"It's not a miracle; it's Adora," Cyrus said with absolute certainty. At Lenio's raised brow, he continued. "She made sure

that Kesi and C'yara both knew military first aid. She would have known not to remove the knife until the bleeding could be stopped somehow."

Lenio nodded and held out his free hand as his other glowed with arcane power. "Cyrus, give me one of your Tears of Fire. I've already started casting and I don't have the energy needed to complete the spell."

Cyrus all but ripped off one of his armbands and gave it to the doctor. As the Tear of Fire lit up, Lenio ever so slightly sighed with relief.

"We should give the doctor his space," Cyrus began as he gently pulled the medics back. "You two did good work and I know you must be exhausted but I need you to get back out there and help anyone you can."

"Yes, sir!" the two medics said with salutes before running off to resume their duties.

Cyrus looked at where Lenio was steadily casting away in between giving orders to his nurses and orderlies and then to the private room where Lyra and C'yara were currently resting. With a sigh, Cyrus stepped out and shut the door to the infirmary.

Today was going to be a *long* day.

A Private Room in the Infirmary

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Hours After the Second Coup Attempt

Cyrus was pacing again but he still couldn't be blamed. After all, he was currently roughly seventy percent worry by volume at this point.

Since he had still needed to act as both the King Regent while Lyra was laid up and the top general of their military, he had been forced to start working again to try and settle affairs as much as possible. He wasn't going to be more than thirty feet from his family at that moment if he could help it, however, so he had commandeered Lenio's office. While he worked at Lenio's desk, Percival had grabbed an unused medical stand to use as one while Caspin slept fitfully in the chair next to him.

Casualty and damage reports kept pouring in and the numbers were more than a little upsetting. He had already sent a message to Haverisk informing him that the Crown would be providing emergency relief funds for the reconstruction effort that should begin as soon as possible. He had also received a message from Imoh suggesting that a memorial service be held for the deceased, something that Cyrus had fully agreed with.

Later still, Cloudfoot had arrived with some food and tisane as well as a message: the surviving traitors that hadn't absconded had all been rounded up and that interrogation via truth spells will begin at his command. Naturally, Cyrus had given the go ahead for that immediately. There were a number of burning questions that he *needed* the answer to, questions that he had passed along to Cloudfoot.

Then he had been given his first bit of good news since breakfast when a haggard Lenio came in to inform them that Lyra was awake.

Cyrus had scooped up Caspin, startling a *mrrp* out of him, and probably set a new speed recording rushing to her room.

"LY—" Cyrus almost shouted his wife's name as he all but burst through the door only to catch himself when he remembered both

his daughter sleeping in the other bed and the rest of the wounded in the infirmary.

His youngest child, however, had no such restraint.

"MAMA!" Caspin yelled as they wiggled out of Cyrus' arms. He then rushed over to Lyra's bed where they all but pounced on her. He immediately set to work vigorously nuzzling her.

The private room where Lyra and C'yara were staying wasn't any different than any other two-person private room in the infirmary in terms of amenities. However, given the fact that it was specifically set aside for the Royal Family, it *was* regularly swept for things like listening devices or the like.

"Caspin!" Lyra replied at a much more reasonable volume as she threw her arms around them and held him close. The head of her bed was currently raised so that she could sit up.

Cyrus walked over to the side of her bed and leaned down so he could first kiss her temple before rubbing his cheek against hers, letting their scents intertwine. He didn't even try to stop the purr rising up in his chest which triggered Lyra's which, in turn, triggered Caspin's.

"How are you feeling, darling?" he asked after a moment when he had finally gathered enough willpower to pull away. He felt a *lot* calmer now that his wife was awake—he was only about fifty percent worry by volume now.

"I've been better," Lyra admitted. She then chuckled slightly. "I would say that you should see the other guy but…"

"Yeah, I read the reports." Cyrus shot his wife a lopsided grin. "Do I need to say that I'm proud of you?"

Lyra smiled back and it was quite possibly the most beautiful thing that Cyrus had ever seen. "You don't but I like hearing it anyway."

"Ew. You two are being gross," Caspin complained, their nose scrunching up in disgust.

Cyrus and Lyra chuckled at that before falling into a relatively comfortable silence as Cyrus sat down in the chair next to Lyra's bed. Caspin seemed to finally be finished nuzzling as they squirmed a little more to get comfortable before settling down.

At length, Cyrus spoke again. "So, what do you know about what's happened?" he asked.

"Only what Lenio has told me," Lyra replied as she continued to pet down Caspin's back, her eyes flickering over to C'yara's sleeping form.

"Well, things aren't great but they could have been worse. We managed to repel the invaders with relatively few casualties on our end and the people of the city rallied quickly. We don't have the full count yet but it's not looking to be as bad as the last one," he reported.

Lyra nodded and opened her mouth to speak only to be cut off by Caspin.

"Hey, where's 'Dora?" he asked as he sat up and began looking around as though she were hiding in a corner somewhere.

Cyrus shared a significant look with Lyra before saying, "Oh, you know how she gets. She probably started helping someone and then lost track of the time." In truth, Cyrus was more than a little worried. He had sent messages to every hospital in Halfmoon but she wasn't at any of them (not that she would have *stayed* in one given her ties to the Royal Family). He had then alerted the military and guard to keep an eye out for her and that had been over an hour ago.

Caspin scowled at Cyrus. "That's not very nice! She's C'y's *khai'tel!* She should be here with her, not out there with someone else!"

Cyrus and Lyra both startled at that. "You know that?" Lyra asked. Cyrus was surprised, too. Sure, it was *painfully* obvious but Caspin was also only *ten.*

Caspin actually *scoffed* at that and rolled his eyes. "Of *course* I do! *Everyone* knows that!"

Cyrus chuckled. "Fair enough."

"So, where *is* 'Dora? Why hasn't someone gotten her?"

Lyra and Cyrus shared another look but were thankfully spared from having to answer by a knock at the door.

"Enter," Lyra said clearly.

The door opened to reveal a pleasant surprise: Percival pushing a wheelchair-bound Kesi. Her fur had been cleaned of all of the blood and was back to its usual white but she seemed paler than usual and her eyes looked sunken. Her clothes had also been replaced with a hospital gown meaning that she was currently more covered up than Cyrus had ever seen her.

"Kesi! You're awake!" Caspin said as they shimmied off of the bed and raced over to her. Kesi smiled and leaned forward to hug them.

"Stupid question but how are you feeling, Kesi?" Cyrus asked as Caspin gave her one last squeeze before letting go and stepping back. Percival wheeled her all the way into the room and shut the door before positioning her between Lyra and C'yara. He then took the remaining seat in the room for himself.

As he was doing this, Kesi took a deep breath and answered, "I'll be alright."

While Cyrus didn't know Kesi *nearly* as well as C'yara and *especially* Adora, he was pretty certain that that was code for "I feel absolutely terrible but I'm not going to complain."

"What do you know about everything that's happened?" Lyra asked.

"And what happened to you?" Caspin added.

"Percival brought me up to speed," Kesi answered. "As for what happened to me, I was in the Waxing Market picking up a gift for Adora when the bombs went off. They—" Her ears pinned back for a moment as she grabbed her tail to stop it from thrashing. "I started helping people using the medical supplies I keep on me only to be attacked. I managed to," she swallowed thickly as her ears pinned back again, "to get him but not before he… well…" She glanced down at her stomach. "I remember stumbling into an alley, smelling Adora's scent, and then that's about it."

Cyrus perked up slightly at that last bit. He pulled out his tablet and quickly sent a couple messages before putting it away.

"I received some reports about that, actually," Cyrus said. "You did good work; saved a lot of lives. You should be proud."

Kesi smiled bashfully, a pleased purr springing to life only for a brief moment as her tail twitched in her hands. "I just did what I could. I wish I could have done more."

"Enough of that," Lyra gently reprimanded her. "You did more than any sane person could have expected or asked of you. You are a hero, Kesi. Just like everyone else who helped out."

"Thank you, Your Majesty," Kesi said softly. Her blush was visible through her fur and her pleased purr lasted longer this time —a few seconds. Was she tamping it down for some reason? Cyrus wasn't certain but he felt like he was missing something.

"How's Catra doing?" Kesi asked, sending C'yara's sleeping form a worried look.

"She's fine; she's just resting," Cyrus answered. "She was pretty nicked up from her fight with Bloodclaw but it wasn't

anything *too* serious. The worst part—and the reason why she's still sleeping—was the severe magical exhaustion. Apparently, the way she chose to deal with him is with the judicious use of explosions. His armor was warded against magic by what we're pretty sure is a shard of a RuneStone—probably the Black Garnet—so she had to put a *lot* of power into each one."

"All without causing much in the way of damage to the area," Lyra added with a nod. "She should be *very* proud of her performance; the level of control needed to do what she did is no mean feat. I saw the fight from Caspin's bedroom window."

"But *I* didn't because Mama wouldn't let me," Caspin said with a pout.

"I'm sure that C'yara will be *more* than happy to show us both how she defeated Bloodclaw," Cyrus said placatingly.

Kesi smiled fondly at her Princess. "While she should be proud, knowing her, she'll be upset by the fact that she passed out and is going to be *furious* about the bed rest that Lenio's going to no doubt order."

Cyrus, Lyra, and Percival all chuckled at that, silently agreeing. While C'yara was a *more* than capable warrior *and* sorceress, she tended to be hard on herself. While she had never said as much, Cyrus knew that she was holding herself to the standards of both him and Lyra (and, ever since the assassination attempt two years ago, Adora). While they were admirable and understandable goals for her to work towards, it tended to blind her to her own progress and achievements.

"Hey, where's Adora?" Kesi asked after a moment of silence. "She should be here but she hasn't been in the infirmary for a *long* time."

Cyrus wasn't entirely sure how she knew that but she was right. He opened his mouth to answer when his tablet went off, notifying him of a new message. "One moment," he requested as

he pulled it out and read it. He hummed and frowned as he did so.

"Well," he began slowly. He glanced at Caspin and debated lying or maybe trying to get them out of the room but eventually decided against it. He'd learn eventually so it might as well be now. "Adora's missing."

"WHAT⁉" Kesi shouted as she learned forward in her wheelchair, her eyes wide and ears pinned back. "What do you mean she's missing⁉" she demanded. Lyra and Percival both grimaced at the news, having expected as much, while Caspin simply *froze.*

Cyrus licked his lips as he debated how to word this. This was worrying him just as much as it was the others but he needed to keep a level head.

"She hasn't been in any of the hospitals or other medical facilities, no one's found her, and no one's reported seeing her. When you told us that bit about having smelled her scent in that alleyway, I sent some people to investigate. The message I got was from them. They didn't find anything."

"No. No," Kesi said as she shook her head. Tears were gathering in the corners of her eyes. "She's *not* missing, no one's just *found* her yet. I need to—" She started to get up from her wheelchair only to be gently pushed back down by Percival.

"You *need* to stay here and rest. You lost a *lot* of blood and it took quite a bit of persuading just to get Lenio to let you come here in that wheelchair," he said. "I know that you're worried—we *all* are—but one more person searching for her isn't going to make a difference."

"No, you don't understand!" Kesi insisted with another shake of her head. At least she didn't try to get up again. "Catra or I can easily find her! Since Catra's unconscious and might not be strong

enough to walk right away, *I'm* the one who has to find her and the longer we wait, the harder it's going to be!"

"C'yara, I understand, but why—" Lyra's eyes widened as she put the pieces together just a fraction of a second before Cyrus and Percival did. "You've imprinted on her?" she asked.

Kesi squeezed her eyes shut and wiped her tears away before they could fall. "I have," she answered in a small voice. "It happened a bit over a month ago. We haven't told anyone yet because Caspin's birthday was coming up and we didn't want to create any distractions from it. It's not like our relationship status could change right away anyway."

"That… certainly changes things," Cyrus said after a moment. After another moment, he then nodded resolutely and stood up. "I'll talk to Lenio and then I'll take you there. The little lion needs us—needs *you*—and nothing's going to stop us."

An Alleyway Near the Waxing Market

Lower Residential District

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Three Hours After the Second Coup Attempt

Though it had taken a bit of talking, Cyrus eventually managed to convince Lenio to let him take Kesi out under the condition that she remained in her wheelchair at all times. This was a condition that both of them agreed to even though both of them knew that she'd need to get out and walk on her own for a bit eventually. Of course, Lenio knew exactly *why* Kesi needed to leave the infirmary early—and thus knew that she was also Adora's *khai'tel*—so he no doubt knew this as well.

It took longer still to finally wheel Kesi to the alleyway where she had been stabbed. Thanks to all of the bombs that had gone off, a lot of pathways were blocked off and others still weren't passable with a wheelchair. On more than one occasion, Kesi had become frustrated and suggested that Cyrus simply carry her over the rubble but he had turned her down every time. He understood her frustration and desire but the fact of the matter was that Kesi wasn't in the greatest of conditions. Though she tried to hide it, Cyrus could tell that even simply sitting up for this long was taxing on her.

Eventually, however, they made it to their destination.

"Alright, Kesi," Cyrus began as he locked the wheels of her wheelchair, "let your magic imprint bullshit do its thing and find our Little Lion."

With a grunt of effort, Kesi pushed herself to her feet. She staggered as she stood up and Cyrus almost reached out to catch her but she got her balance before he needed to. She took a few deep breaths before closing her eyes and slowly walking forward.

Cyrus watched with rapt attention, ready to dash to her side and catch her at any moment or follow her wherever she went. It turned out that he had to do neither of those things, however, as, once she got to the end of the alleyway, Kesi turned around and meandered back. Her eyes were still closed and this didn't appear to be a conscious action on her part which worried Cyrus more than a little.

After three repetitions of this, once Kesi's steps started to become unsteady, Cyrus spoke up. "Kesi, that's enough."

Kesi turned to face him again, her open eyes brimming with tears. "I-I don't get it," she said, her voice breaking in the middle. "Everything in me is telling me that this is where she's s-supposed to be b-but sh-she's not here." Her tears started to flow freely. "H-Her scent is th-the strongest here b-but it doesn't *go* a-anywhere it just— it just *e-ends* here and I don't know why."

Cyrus frowned as he slowly walked towards Kesi, his hands held out in a placating gesture as he tried his best to not agitate her clearly fragile state any more than he was about to.

"Kesi, if your imprint isn't leading you to her and her scent doesn't go anywhere then there's only one possible answer: she was teleported somewhere," he said in as gentle of a voice as he could.

Kesi slowly shook her head as her tears fell faster even as her ears pinned back and despair started to fill her eyes. She weakly tried to grab her lashing tail but gave up after a few attempts.

"N-No, th-that can't be— No. N-No. Sh-she h-has to be a-around h-here *s-somewhere* and I-I just—" Kesi's words were cut off by a sob, her hands shooting up to cover her mouth.

Cyrus gingerly pulled her into a hug and started softly purring to try and soothe her, even as he squeezed his own eyes shut tight to try and stop his own tears. "Let it out, Kesi. Let it out," he said softly, using his iron self-control to keep his voice calm and steady.

Those words seemed to break what little restraint that Kesi had left. She threw her arms around Cyrus and buried her face into his shoulder as she started wailing. Her entire body was trembling so fiercely that Cyrus was having to hold her up and her heartbroken sobs tore through his own heart like jagged claws. Kesi was always such a bright, happy person. To see her *bereft* like this was just… *wrong* on a level that Cyrus had difficulty explaining.

And he was going to have to do this again with C'yara.

Cyrus held Kesi close as he kept up his purring while gently stroking her mane. He wasn't the most qualified person to do this —Lyra would have been better given her experience with this exact same situation—but he was the only one here. He just

hoped that his experience comforting crying children would be good enough.

Cyrus wasn't sure how long he held Kesi as she sobbed into his shoulder, her tears soaking through his shirt and into his fur, but he didn't *care.* He would stand right there all day if he had to.

Eventually, Kesi's sobs turns into whimpering and heartbroken mewling as her own purr started up in an effort to self-soothe. It was then that Cyrus' tablet went off with a call. He was going to ignore it but he saw that it was Cloudfoot calling.

He pulled away from Kesi but kept one hand gripped on her upper arm for emotional support as he answered the call.

"You better have a—" Cyrus cut his words off when he saw the older man and how he also showed signs of crying. "Cloudfoot, what is it?" he asked, even as dread started to fill every fiber of his being.

Cloudfoot cleared his throat a few times before saying, "Your Majesty, I'm afraid I have bad news from the interrogations. Adora has been abducted and taken to the Fright Zone."

Hearing that, Kesi fainted, collapsing into Cyrus' arms.

Five Hours After Adora's Abduction

Chapter End Notes

To those of you reading this after the first chapter of *Knights of the Fright Zone*, the reason why we played coy with Adora's abduction in the timestamps is to keep the surprise for any future readers who decide to read this first.

Chapter 2: Bleeding from a Broken Heart

Chapter Summary

Catra awakens shortly after the coup to find out the terrible truth.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A Private Room in the Infirmary

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

The Night After Adora's Abduction

C'yara's eyes cracked open and her ears twitched rhythmically to the sound of a medical device beeping every few seconds. Every one of her joints ached and her head pounded, the room stank of antiseptic and blood—some of it her own. Her eyes slowly adjusted to the piercing light of the infirmary. *Well, that was good*, she reasoned, *I would be dead if things went wrong, not bundled up in the infirmary.*

She tried to move and groaned through the pain. Suddenly, there was a hand on her arm—the comforting smell of Mamma. She looked over and there was Lyra, also in a hospital bed, close enough that she could reach over. Her stomach and face both had large bandages. Caspin was curled up against her, still snoring away.

"You did it, my heart. You won." Her mother beamed at her, pride so evident on her face that C'yara couldn't help but smile

herself through the absolutely pounding headache that had formed in her skull. Magical exhaustion was the worst feeling in the world.

"We won?" Her mouth felt like sandpaper. She definitely didn't feel like she'd won: her mother had two nasty-looking bandages, and Papa wasn't around. "Is everyone okay?"

"Yes, everyone is safe. The Baron is imprisoned, and the traitors have been rounded up. All thanks to you." She was smiling over at her daughter despite the injuries marring her face.

In spite of the ache in her muscles, she clambered upwards out the bed, dragging the IV stand along and disconnecting the other devices so the horrible beeping would stop. The pain almost caused her to topple but, instead, she reached out and Mamma's hands pulled her up against her. Caspin was curled up against Lyra's chest, safe… She had managed to keep them safe; she was safe.

"Mama… I was so— I was so scared. I… I thought that Caspin would be hurt, an-and you weren't there at breakfast, and Papa was away." She couldn't stop the tears that were building up. Fear had gripped her all day; she hadn't let it show. Not once, not while leading, but here in the quiet of the infirmary with only her mother and the sleeping form of her younger sibling, she could afford to show some weakness. "I was scared you were going to go like Grandpa, or Auntie, or Papa would get captured again, and I'd be left in charge. I don't want to be in charge yet."

"Shh, it's alright, my heart. You were strong, we're not going anywhere. You can rest." The scent of her mamma was overpowering. She was stroking gently through her hair with her one working hand as she fell against her chest and back into a dreamless sleep, a purr rising from her chest echoed by her mother and her younger sibling.

It was a few more hours when the sound of shouting caused her to wake again. Her head wasn't pounding quiet as much, and

her tail was wrapped around herself where she had curled into a ball; Caspin was curled up against her chest, and her against Mama's. The shouting was muffled by the doorway but was loud enough that her ears twitched.

"—Reckless. She will be out for days because you—" The voice behind the door was Lenio. She could only catch snippets of the conversation but it must be loud in the other room. "—Don't have the space in the infirmary; we'll be taking her to her rooms. If anything happens to her, it's your tail—" The door opened and Cyrus walked in with the voice of Lenio following him, his ears pinned back and his tail drooping. He looked exhausted, and miserable. He leaned over the bed and kissed her right between her ears, which twitched at him.

"Hey there, kitten." His voice was small, full of hurt and pride. "I heard you beat the Baron all by yourself. Good job, kit; you really proved yourself, and I am so, so proud of you." She trilled at that. Her father was always proud of her, but in this time she had earned it. Without backup, she had done what he would have done and taken the foe head on despite being terrified. "Go back to sleep; you need the rest. We'll talk in the morning." He stroked one hand down her face and began to purr. Her family was safe and, despite sleeping most of the day away, she still felt tired down to her bones.

When she properly awoke, the lights were on, indicating it was around midday, and her stomach growled at her. Lyra was up and reading through some documents while Percival sat on a small folding chair in the corner of the room with Caspin on his lap, reading something of importance to the Queen.

"—Most of the damage has been minimized; the guard and fire departments were quick to get to work. Despite the traitors intentions, most of the Crescent Market will be restored by the end of the week. Final casualty reports put us at around 140 dead and maybe three times that injured. A terrible tragedy but one that was thankfully put down swiftly." His voice made even this

painful, nightmarish day sound boring. “Ah, Her Highness is awake.”

She rolled over to stare at him, glaring through the fluorescent lights of the infirmary. “So, how bad was it?” she croaked out. “Am I going to regret asking that?” She felt a sudden pit in her stomach as the two adults looked at each other with one of those looks that happens between people who know each other well enough to have a whole silent conversation. Her and Adora were like that, able to hold entire conversations in just a few gestures, and she doesn’t even have ears and a tail to read and communicate with.

Eventually, Percival cleared his throat and said, “It could have been a lot worse. Less destructive overall than the previous attempt and we managed to capture rather than kill a majority of the traitors. The loss of life was terrible, and the property damage may leave us needing to find shelter for hundreds of families but, well, the traitors had specific goals and they failed to achieve *most* of them.”

“Most but not all?” She had a bad feeling about this. “What didn’t they do first? Then tell me what they did?” Always start with what was good first, then you could swallow the bad latter. It was true of tea, it was true of bad news.

“Well,” he cleared his throat, “firstly, all of the Royal Family survived the attack despite the well-equipped assassins sent to kill all of you. They also failed to incite significant revolutionary sentiment amongst the populace, and their leader was summarily beaten by you and failed to install himself as a monarch—not that it would have worked for him even if he did. That's the good news. The bad news is that the traitors were confirmed to be working for the Horde, and they managed to achieve some of the Horde’s goals, notably getting the Goblin tribes between us and the Fright Zone into a frenzy against us.”

The door opened again and Cyrus came back in, trailed by Askar. He looked somehow more haggard than a few hours ago.

Before Percival could continue, he interjected, “They also managed to kidnap Adora.” It was a leaden weight dropped in the room, a hammerblow against C’yara’s carefully created optimism that things went well. “We don’t know how, except that they used a teleportation spell, and we don’t know why, but I swear to you, C’yara, I’m going to do everything I can to get her back.”

“You’re lying.” She knew the words weren't true as she said them—Papa had never lied to her before, not when it mattered, not about something like this. “Or you're wrong. She probably just got caught up in the fighting or she’s helping someone who’s injured, healing people at the hospital or… or…” She stood up, ripping the IV from her arm. Lyra tried to grab her but she shrugged her off.

She rushed out of the room, the others trying to stop her but she was too quick. This mattered too much. She was moving through the castle, passing by piles of rubble and even some bodies of traitors that had yet to be properly moved. Engineers assessed the damage and priests of the three religions gave blessings over bodies. Servants milled about the corridors in shock. She leaped over them, often digging into the wall and chipping her claws.

She had to find her…

Adora’s Room

The High Temple

Halfmoon

Subtheria

The Morning After Adora’s Abduction

C’yara collapsed in front of the door to Adora’s room. Her legs had nearly given out two floors back, but she was the Princess,

stars dammit. If she wanted to see Adora then she was going to, and her own body wouldn't stop her. Still, she could only move her tired muscles so far, and she didn't have the strength to even push open the door. Or maybe she didn't want to, terrified of what was on the other side.

Her ears twitched as she heard muffled sobbing on the other side of the door and, for a moment, her heart leaped. Throwing her full weight against it, the door slammed open, and there was a shriek. She found Adora's room as she had left it the previous day except the bed was made, and sitting upright on it, holding Adora's cave leather jacket, was Kesi. She was sobbing into it; tears ran down her face and her tail was puffed up.

"What are you doing here?!" C'yara snarled. This was Adora's space. It was her heart's—the woman she loved—and Kesi was here. Kesi was holding Adora's things and Adora wasn't. Adora should be here. With her. Kesi was looking at her with her sad blue eyes, so much like Adora's but just slightly wrong.

"I… I…" her side was bandaged; it was clear she has just been out of surgery and she came here to Adora's room for comfort. "I… just need to see her." Her voice was chocked, broken like Catra's heart was beginning to become.

"Yeah, well, she's obviously not here." *She's not here, she's not here, she's not here!* "Just go!" Catra turned away from Kesi as she shouted the words at her. Kesi was a friend, but what was one more wound on a broken heart? She walked a few steps towards Adora's closet. Kesi barely moved except to stand from the bed.

The room was small enough that even from there she could reach out and place a hand on Catra's shoulder with a soft "Catra"—Catra had always asked to give Adora more and she had always balked at that. She flinched away and turned on her with a snarl, her claws coming out instinctively and nicking the hand that was touching her. Only to stare into the face of a terrified and still crying Kesi. Her hand had recoiled, trailing tiny droplets of blood.

Her friend, her Seneschal. Adora's friend, Adora's guide to cave culture.

It had always been the three of them. But Adora wasn't here, Adora was gone, back to the Horde, back to the nightmares she was always terrified of. She should be with her; with her magic, she could protect her! Bring her back home. Instead, she was stuck here, too tired to even try. She was useless.

"I said go!" she snarled at her friend. "Adora isn't yours, Kesi, she's mine!" The words were another knife driven into Kesi, this one directly into her heart. She regretted them the moment they left her mouth. Kesi's face contorted into one of pain and grief, but not rage. Catra would be furious but Kesi was far too kind to feel that kind of anger.

Kesi's mouth opened and closed a few times; she finally said in a tiny voice, "I'm sorry." Her ears pinned back and she fled the room as quickly as her injuries would allow, still clutching Adora's jacket in her hands.

Catra fell forwards against the bed, and wept. She clutched the sheets Adora slept in, pulling them tight against herself. There was some other scent there, and it took her only a second to identify it: Kesi's scent clinging to Adora's sheets. She wanted to throw them away, to burn them with a snap of her magically exhausted fingers. She wanted to hold them close and never let go. She pulled close the old and worn stuffed dragon that had been made for her and had her scent clinging to it. On a hook nearby was ceremonial clothes that she had shown Catra she was going to wear to Caspin's birthday. She had never even made it back here to change. Tears flowed freely and she couldn't stop them even if she wanted to.

She wasn't sure how long she lay there sobbing into the blankets that still held some of Adora's scent, but it must have been late. She didn't even notice his scent at first, only after strong hands lifted her up with a muttered "It's okay, it's okay

C’yara” that she realized her papa had come to find her. She was being carried back by gentle calloused hands.

C’yara, the girl who had failed, C’yara, who lost her mate, C’yara, who hurt her friends. She couldn’t keep doing this, couldn’t hold herself together as the weak Princess terrified of the Horde. She needed to be someone else. She needed to be strong like Papa, like Mama, like… like Adora. Catra, that’s what Adora had called her, an in-joke that never went away, the little jest between her, Adora, and Cyrus. It was Catra that had helped save Adora from the Horde the first time, and it was Catra who would do it again.

Princess C’yara was dead; she died in the coup, killed by the Baron. Princess Catra was born at that moment. She felt her resolve harden. Princess Catra who would save Adora, would beat the Horde, and if she had to do it with her own blood, save her people from destruction.

Kesi’s Old Room

The High Temple

Halfmoon

Subtheria

The Morning After Adora’s Abduction

Kesi fled Adora's room. Catra was right. Adora wasn’t hers, she was always Catra’s first: Catra’s first imprint, Catra’s bodyguard, they almost certainly would be married and not in the cave culture fashion, not for the Princess and her Knight.

She had let her feet carry her back to the comfort of her old room, maintained as it was, only a thin layer of dust showed any sign of disuse. She didn’t care as she crashed onto the bed,

clutching the jacket to her chest and weeping. Curling up in a tight ball, her tail completely engulfing the smaller jacket.

She trembled; the pain in her side was agony, but the cutting words from the Princess hurt even more. She wanted to fall down and never climb back up. Adora, the shining light from above as if the very Stars Above had made themselves known in one dorky girl with twigs in her hair and a gaped-toothed smile, was gone. A light extinguished by the Horde and the traitors and the Cult.

They were real, the very thing she had nightmares about. Twice they had attacked and hurt the people she loved: friends, family, and now her *khai'tel.* They wanted to end the world, but her world had just ended, snuffed out in a heartbeat.

She let out a pitiful mewling noise mixed with her tears. The pillow she had fallen on was quickly becoming a damp mess, the dust thrown up from it clung to her fur and she couldn’t bring herself to care. She held the jacket close to her heart and tried to take a deep lungful of Adora’s scent. The deep breath shot pain through her stomach and side where the blade of a cultist had slipped between her ribs. She couldn’t even truly appreciate Adora’s scent because of them.

She knew the spells to weave the scent into the fabric. Leather like this was usually hard to work with, but she had time, and determination. She would do this for her, for Catra, for Adora. She reached out with what little magic she had and touched it to the tough material.

It was like she was suddenly bathed in warm moonlight; the feeling was like being held aloft by fire and gliding across a desert. She could barely cling onto the spell for that moment. She could feel the spell tugging through the fabric with impossible ease. Leather shouldn’t work like that, and the magic, Adora’s infinite well of celestial magic, brushed against her own and pulled her. It took her only a moment, doing it off of muscle memory as the sensations almost overwhelmed her and, as she finished, she felt something: some of that heat, some trail of golden light flicker

into her, trailing along her magic. Some part of Adora’s magic remained in her.

She could feel a purr rising in her chest as she clutched the jacket to her; a purr to soothe her wounds, the pain in her flesh and in her heart. Adora was gone but some part of her would be with her forever.

Tomorrow, she would find the Princess and apologize. Tomorrow, she would start to come up with a plan, organized to the minutest detail, a plan to get Adora out.

She was an Acolyte of the Celestial Promise, and even now lying here in pain, still bleeding slightly from a wound left by her closest friend, and broken in heart, she wouldn’t let them win. She wouldn't let the Whispered Promise or the Horde break her. She would hold on to hope.

Chapter End Notes

I am really putting the girls in the torment nexus.

Chapter 3: Heartbeat, Heartbreak

Chapter by Zelenal

Chapter Summary

> Fresh off of the revelation that Adora's been kidnapped by the Horde, everyone struggles to come up with a solution as to how to get her back.

Chapter Notes

▶ Content Warning:

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Royal Parlor

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

One Day After Adora's Abduction

Lyra cradled a cup of tea in her hands as she sat in her favorite chair in the private part of the parlor. Around her, Cyrus, Percival, Cloudfoot, and Askar all sat in silence nursing their own drinks. She stared vacantly at her reflection in the cooling liquid as she let the emotions of the day and the conversation wash through her like a maelstrom.

"We can't just do *nothing,"* Cyrus said more to himself than anyone else. Almost absently, Lyra reached out with her tail and twined it with his, causing him to send a small smile her way.

"There isn't really anything we *can* do," Percival pointed out anyway. Cloudfoot was holding one of his hands and was curled up against his side.

It was a familiar exchange, one that they had had several times by this point. Around and around in circles, just like Lyra's cooling tea as she gently swirled it.

Losing a daughter wasn't an easy thing and Lyra's had to live through it twice now, even if Adora was never officially adopted by them. She tried to console herself by reminding herself that at least everyone else was physically fine this time but it was a cold comfort. Cold just like her tea.

Lyra used a bit of her magic to heat her tea back up and took a drink. It was her favorite blend but she couldn't taste anything.

Askar took a deep breath before saying, "We need to focus on what we *can* do in the meantime. We—"

He was cut off by the sound of the door opening, the sound loud enough to be startling. They all looked toward the door to see C'yara walk in, her ears pinned back and her tail hanging lifelessly behind her. She had a white, silken shirt clutched to her chest, one that Lyra recognized as one of Adora's formal shirts.

Lyra wanted to rush out of her chair, to hold her daughter close and promise her that everything would be okay, that they'd get Adora back in no time. She wanted to comfort her through one of the worst experiences a Magicat could have but she didn't. She *couldn't.* For all of her talents as an orator, she simply hadn't the words to comfort her daughter. No one did.

Everyone watched as C'yara made her way over to one of the vacant chairs and all but collapsed into it. She pressed Adora's shirt to her nose and closed her eyes.

The silence in the room was deafening.

"Do we have a plan to get Adora back?" C'yara asked after a long moment. Her borderline lifeless voice made everyone else in the room flinch.

"We do but you aren't going to like it, my heart," Lyra said slowly.

"Well? What is it?" C'yara asked as she opened her eyes to look at her mother.

Lyra took a deep breath to steel herself before saying, "We wait for—"

"We can't wait!" C'yara interrupted with a low growl in her chest, suddenly jumping to her feet as her tail lashed angrily behind her. "Waking up only to be back in the Horde has been Adora's greatest fear for the entire time she's been here! We can't just sit around and wait while she's living that fear!"

C'yara rounded on Cyrus and leveled a look at him that was simultaneously accusatory and pleading. "Why aren't you going to save her, Papa? You did it before!"

Cyrus winced, his ears briefly flicking back. "You *know* that I would if I could but I can't. They weren't expecting me last time and I was teleported directly into the heart of their main compound. Neither of those things would be true this time. Trust me, I proposed that very idea and got shot down."

"But you wouldn't be alone this time!" C'yara rebutted. She slipped Adora's shirt on, seemingly to stop herself from damaging it with her unsheathed claws and wild gesticulations. "I'd go with you! I'm not some mewling kitten like last time! And we can bring Askar and some of our best soldiers! We can get her back!"

"Your Highness," Askar interjected, "a full military assault on the Fright Zone isn't feasible. The logistics of such a thing are simply impossible."

"We don't *need* a full military assault!" C'yara said as she turned to face Askar. "We just need a small unit to get in there and extract her!"

"We don't even know where, exactly, she *is,* Your Highness," Percival said, his tone placating. "We simply know that she's somewhere in the Fright Zone but that covers a large swathe of land."

C'yara seemed to deflate for a moment before she perked back up as an idea came to her. "The Spirit Ember! I can commune with it and it'll show me where she is!"

"My heart, are you certain that it'll show what you want?" Lyra asked. RuneStones were fickle things at the best of times.

"I'll *make it* show me her!" C'yara replied with absolute conviction.

Everyone was silent for a long moment after that, the only sound being C'yara's heavy breathing. Eventually, she collapsed back into her chair and held her head in her hands.

At length, Cyrus spoke up again, apparently wanting to change the subject. "Hey, C'yara, have you—"

"Catra," C'yara interrupted. At Cyrus' confused noise, she picked up her head to look at him and said, "Catra. I want to just go by Catra now with everyone."

Everyone else in the room shared glances before Cyrus said, "Alright, then. Catra, have you gotten Kesi to—" This time, it was Cyrus who cut himself off at the stricken look on C'ya— *Catra's* face. He shared a look with Lyra before saying, "We'll need Kesi to be there with us."

"Why does she have to be there?" C'y— Catra asked somewhat tersely. Lyra didn't know what had transpired between Catra and Kesi but it worried her more than a little. Back before the imprints, the two of them plus Adora were the greatest of

friends—the Super Pal Trio, as Adora had dubbed them. For something to have gotten in the way of their friendship and now of all times…

Cyrus looked at Lyra yet again, this look lingering to turn into a full-blown silent conversation. Eventually, Cyrus sighed and answered with, "It's not my place to say."

Catra was silent for a long moment as she let her head droop before eventually sighing and saying, "Fine. I'll… message her and talk to her." She then looked up at Lyra and asked, "What was your plan for getting Adora back? I'm sorry I interrupted."

Lyra smiled at her daughter. "It's alright; you're allowed to be upset. Our plan is frustratingly simple on our part: we wait and rebuild while our spies on the surface track her down and extract her. If your plan with the Spirit Ember works, that'll make getting her back that much faster."

Catra's brow furrowed in confusion. "Can our spies really do that?"

Percival was the one to answer. "I have been assured that it is within the realm of possibility and that no resource will be spared in getting your *khai'tel* back."

Catra leaned back in her chair with a sigh. "I still don't like it but I guess that's better than nothing. I'll… message Kesi and… talk to her, I guess."

Lyra nodded. "I'll see to the preparations for a trip to the Spirit Ember. We'll set out this evening. And Catra," Catra looked up and Lyra saw not the strong, independent young woman that she had raised but rather the sad, lost young girl that she was, "we'll get Adora back."

"You promise?" Catra asked, her voice impossibly small and fragile. It broke Lyra's heart.

"I promise."

Catra's Rooms

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

One Day After Adora's Abduction

Catra prowled about her room as she clenched and unclenched her fists, trying her best to calm down. Kesi was on her way and, if Catra was being honest, she didn't really want to talk to her ~~best friend~~ Seneschal. She knew that Kesi and Adora were super close—almost as close as Catra was with her—but Adora wasn't *hers.* She had no right to be in Adora's room in order to try and find some comfort from her scent when she *knew* that Catra and Adora were imprinted. She had even had the gall to take Adora's jacket, forcing Catra to take one of her shirts.

If Catra was being even *more* honest, this was just the natural result of her continued jealousy of Kesi. The amount of time that she got to spend with Adora was *far* greater than the amount of time that Catra had gotten thanks in no small part to having lived in the High Temple alongside her before moving into the castle upon becoming a seneschal. Even after that, Kesi could have more sleepovers with Adora than Catra could.

Then there was the problem of scent marks. While Catra quite liked Kesi's scent—Catra couldn't pin it down but it was something floral and fruity—her scent was *all over* Adora and her things. While this hadn't been an issue back when they were just the Super Pal Trio (a name that she complained about despite secretly loving it), after the imprint, it just served to make Catra mad. Adora was *her khai'tel.* The only scent marks that should have been on her were *Catra's* and yet Adora almost always had Kesi's scent on her as well. In fact, there were times where Adora smelled more like Kesi than she did Catra.

Catra knew that she was being unfair to Kesi. Her Seneschal was a very physically affectionate person and there was absolutely nothing wrong with that. Furthermore, Kesi and Adora were basically like family to each other and it was normal to smell a bit like your family—stars knew that Catra had Caspin's scent on her more often than not. Adora didn't technically *have* a family and she more than deserved to have something like one.

Even so, despite all that, Catra just couldn't silence the jealous beast in her chest. It brought her more than a little shame which led to frustration which her jealousy then weaponized by making her lash out at someone who didn't deserve it.

A knock on her door tore Catra from her thoughts. "Catra? It's me, Kesi. May I come in?" she heard Kesi ask. The fact that she felt that she had to *ask* was just a sign of badly Catra had fucked up; Kesi had *never* had to ask before.

"Yeah, come in," Catra replied as she collapsed onto one of the chairs in her living room.

Kesi cautiously opened the door and peeked her head in before nervously shuffling in and shutting the door. Her ears were pinned back and she had her tail in one hand and Adora's jacket in the other. The sight of Adora's jacket nearly made a growl rip out of Catra's throat but she managed to push it down.

"Y-you wanted to speak with me?" Kesi asked as she stayed by the door. The stammer and slight quaver in her voice nearly made Catra wince.

"We're going down to the Spirit Ember so that way I can make it show me where Adora is. For whatever reason, my parents think that you should come with," Catra informed her. "You wanna tell me why they think that?"

Kesi had perked up somewhat at the first part of that only to slightly flinch at Catra's tone for the second part and then fully

flinch for the question. She raised Adora's jacket up as though to smell it only to stop partway and lower her hand again.

"U-um… Yeah, there's something that happened a little while ago—a bit over a month now—that y-you should know about. W-we were going to tell you after Caspin's birthday since you were so focused on that and w-we didn't want to take away from—"

"Out with it, Kesi," Catra interrupted with a slight growl. "What are you hiding from me?"

Kesi's shoulders were drawn in, her arms were crossed in front of her, and her head was ducked down to make herself as small as possible while still standing. "U-um, s-so, I…" Kesi took a deep breath to steel herself, "I imprinted on Adora."

Catra froze solid as the jealous monster inside her *roared.* "What." Her voice was perfectly neutral which only seemed to scare Kesi more.

Kesi apparently couldn't stop herself from burying her nose in the collar of Adora's jacket as she squeezed her eyes shut. "I-it happened on that day she confronted my family." Her head snapped up to look at Catra, her eyes wide and pleading. "We were going to tell you! We just didn't want to distract from Caspin's birthday!"

Catra took a deep breath through her nose, counted to ten in her head, and then slowly let it out through her mouth. She couldn't go with her gut reaction this time, she *couldn't.* Kesi deserved better than that. And so did Adora.

Kesi had no control over who she imprinted on—no Magicat did, as far as Catra knew. What's more, hiding it like that wasn't *just* Kesi's idea, it was Kesi's *and* Adora's. Actually, knowing Adora and Kesi, it had probably been *Adora's* idea in the first place.

Could Catra be mad at Adora for keeping it a secret so as to not distract from Caspin's birthday? She could a little, she found, but not a lot. Adora always put others first and that was a habit

that Kesi shared. It was only natural for the two of them to do this.

Catra tried to take a step further back and examine a hypothetical scenario where the second coup attempt never happened and the two of them had carried out their plan. She would still feel a flare of jealousy but would she be angry?

… Not really, no. She probably would have scoffed, rolled her eyes, pushed down her jealousy, and been legitimately excited for the two of them. Catra only wanted good things for Adora and Kesi and there wasn't much that could be better than them imprinting. They both deserved love and Adora deserved more love than Catra—or Kesi, for that matter—could give her on her own.

Catra's current anger stemmed not from the imprint but was just misplaced anger over Adora's fate. Her jealousy was using that anger to lash out at one of the people who would never deserve it in a million years. So, Catra took her anger and shoved it down alongside her jealousy. It'd get its time to burn hot and wild one day and it'd be against people who actually deserved it.

"Alright," Catra said at length. "I'm… happy for you. And also sorry."

"W-what?" Kesi asked, clearly confused by Catra's sudden one-eighty.

"I'm a little upset that you hid it from me but… if Adora was still here," Catra had to pause to swallow the sudden lump in her throat, "I wouldn't be that mad. So, I'm happy for you but I'm also sorry that you didn't get to spend that much time with her as your *khai'tel."*

Tears gathered in the corners of Kesi's eyes as Catra stood up from her chair. She took a few steps closer before holding out her hand with the gentlest smile that she could muster. "Put on her jacket and come here," she requested.

Kesi sniffled before doing as she was asked, sliding on the slightly-too-small jacket before closing the distance between them and grabbing Catra's outstretched hand. The moment that she did, Catra pulled her into a tight hug and buried her nose in the crook of Kesi's neck. The smell of Adora and Kesi's scents mingling was almost enough to make Catra purr.

Kesi returned the hug, holding her Princess and best friend close as she buried her face in Catra's mane and let herself cry again. This, in turn, caused Catra's own tears to start flowing as she let herself properly feel for the first time since she heard the worst news of her life.

Adora was gone, locked away somewhere in the Fright Zone without a friendly face in sight. No matter how much Catra wanted to abandon everything to go running off to save her, she knew that she couldn't. She was the Crown Princess of Halfmoon and her people must always come first no matter how much it hurt.

The two of them stayed that way for a long time, letting their emotions rip through them like the most violent of storms. They had lost the brightest light in their lives, the one that they loved above all others. They lost someone so unbelievably precious and irreplaceable and they had no idea when they would get her back.

(They *would* get her back; Catra wouldn't even *begin* to entertain any other outcome.)

As Catra breathed in the honey-and-floral scent of Adora and Kesi, she felt words bubble up in her chest. They were special words overflowing with meaning and were words that Catra never said lightly. In fact, that were words that Catra never said to anyone outside of her family or Adora. However, in that moment, Catra realized that she still had a light left in her life, one that she hadn't been able to see before due to being blinded by the light of Adora.

"I love you, Kesi," Catra said at length in a whisper so quiet that Kesi could barely hear it. Her voice was choked with emotion as the weight of her words both freed her and drug her down into a place unknown.

"I love you, too, Catra," Kesi replied, her voice every bit as laden with emotion as Catra's own as she started purring.

In that moment, Catra desperately wished that she could purr in return but she couldn't. She knew that she could never purr again until Adora was back with them in Halfmoon where she belonged.

Eventually, Catra pulled away slightly, letting her hands rest on Kesi's upper arms as she smiled up at her ~~Seneschal~~ *khai'tel.* "C'mon, Kesi. Let's go find out where our girl is."

The Lost Temple

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

One Day After Adora's Abduction

Catra, Kesi, Lyra, and Kelara all stood before the Spirit Ember, the heat of the RuneStone baring down on them in a way that was simultaneously oppressive and comforting. Catra, Lyra, and Kelara all wore ceremonial robes while Kesi was dressed in an "outfit" that had caused Catra's brain to short circuit upon seeing it. Even now, she had to use a decent amount of willpower to keep her focus on the Spirit Ember and not let her eyes wander to her barely-dressed *khai'tel.*

No words were spoken as Catra and Kesi approached the Spirit Ember. Catra stared deeply into it, mesmerized as always by its

ever-shifting colors of fire. It always left her with a bone-deep feeling of awe whenever she stood before it and realized that she was bonded to it. It was an ancient thing of unimaginable power and yet it had deemed Catra worthy of using it.

It was an honor above all honors and Catra briefly wondered if the other Elemental Princesses felt the same about their RuneStones.

As the two of them came to a stop, the Spirit Ember pulsed with power and Catra felt as though a question hung in the air.

"Show us Adora," Catra intoned. "Show us where our heart is so that we may rescue her from those that would turn her against Etheria."

The Spirit Ember pulsed once, twice, thrice as arcs of flame whirled around it. Eventually, tendrils of gold-red flame reached out and entwined themselves around Catra and Kesi.

Fire flashed around her and—

Catra was in a room she had never seen before. It was clearly the workshop of a sorcerer based on the various tools and reagents scattered about on the shelves and tables. The shadows in the room were unnaturally sharp and Catra could feel through the Spirit Ember the pain and corruption *that filled the space.*

In the center of the room was a large stone that shown with a magenta light. Much like the Spirit Ember, it, too, radiated a power that was ancient and unknowable but its power seemed to scream. *It was as if its magic was being abused, being tortured.*

It was a RuneStone—likely the Black Garnet—and it had somehow been corrupted.

Catra's attention was drawn from the RuneStone as she spied an intimately familiar figure lying strapped to a table near one side of the room. Her usually well-maintained hair was disheveled and

her clothing had seen better days. Tear tracks ran down her face as her breaths came hard and heavy.

Adora.

Catra wanted to run to her, to free her, to comfort her, to tell her that everything was going to be alright, that she would be there soon and this whole nightmare will be just a bad memory. But she could do none of that for she no legs with which to run, no mouth with which to form words, no hands with which to comfort, no lungs with which to draw air. She could only see and hear and feel.

Then a living shadow walked into the room.

It was a person dressed in flowing magenta robes, her long, black hair billowing around her in an impossible breeze. Her face was obscured by a red mask with glowing, white eyes; a shard of the RuneStone was embedded in the forehead. As she moved into the room, the shadows were drawn in around her and became sharper still.

Catra knew this person. She had seen her nearly eleven years ago back during the first coup attempt and had heard about her from Adora. She was Adora's greatest nightmare made manifest.

Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver said something to Adora but Catra couldn't make out her words. She wasn't sure if it was due to the nature of the vision or something else but Catra felt like she could roughly guess what was being said.

Taunting. Insults. Gloating. Condemnation.

Adora struggled futilely against her bindings, fresh tears pouring down her cheeks as magenta lightning crackled in Shadow Weaver's hands. Shadow Weaver raised those hands to Adora's temples and the lightning lashed out, arcing into Adora and scarring her face.

Adora screamed. *Catra wasn't sure if she was feeling it or hearing it but, either way, she knew that it was happening. Adora screamed and screamed and* screamed *until her throat was raw.*

Catra couldn't breathe—not in this vision but in the real world. Or maybe she could *breathe but she couldn't draw in enough air. Her vision tunneled on the sight of Adora being tortured, her skin felt too tight as her fur stood on end, Adora's screams were drowned out by a loud ringing in her ears, she—*

The vision cut off as Catra felt something cold press against her cheek and a weight settle against her thighs. That made her faintly aware of the fact that she had, at some point, fallen to her knees. She also became aware of something soft and warm in her right hand; she gently squeezed it on instinct and felt it squeeze back.

As her vision slowly returned to her, Catra saw that the weight that was draped across her lap was a large, cat-like creature with sleek, black fur and a spectral, blue mane. She could *feel* them almost like she could feel the Spirit Ember. They were gently guiding her thoughts and emotions away from her panic and she got the sense that they were doing the same for Kesi, too.

Melog. The name entered into her mind like a voiceless whisper. She got a sense of who and what they were, where they were from, how they got here, their entire history. It was a lot to take in but it was successful in calming Catra down.

"My heart, are you alright? What did you see?" Catra jumped as she heard Lyra speak from right behind her.

Now more fully aware of herself and her surroundings, Catra saw that Lyra was on her knees beside and slightly behind her (likely due to having moved out of Melog's way). Kelara was in a similar position opposite Kesi and that warm, soft thing that she had felt in her hand turned out to be Kesi's hand.

Catra didn't bother to let go.

Looking at Kesi, she could see that her *khai'tel* was a mess with her fur ruffled from where it was raised and her tail still somewhat bristled. The fur on her cheeks was also matted from her tears.

If Catra had a mirror, she'd no doubt find herself in a similar state.

"I'm— I'll be fine," Catra said, her voice somewhat hoarse. She cleared her throat before squeezing Kesi's hand again. The two of them looked at each other for a long moment before Kesi nodded.

She'd be alright, too.

Catra turned to face her mother as he free hand came up to scratch behind Melog's ears. Their spectral purr filled the room and helped take the edge off of any lingering panic that Catra felt.

"I know where Adora is," Catra said. "She's in the Horde's main compound. Mama, they— Shadow Weaver's doing something to her head and they— I don't—" Catra felt her panic start to rise again but Melog reached out into her thoughts and helped to calm her down even as Lyra wrapped her arms around her.

"It'll be okay, my heart; everything will be okay. Whatever they do to her, we can undo it. Adora's strong. She'll make it through this just like you will," Lyra said softly in a comforting voice.

"Adora's strong and brave," Kesi spoke up. "She'll— Whatever it is that Shadow Weaver is trying to do, she'll fight it with everything she's got. They *can't* take her from us or us from her."

"Precisely," Kelara agreed with a nod. "I didn't raise Adora for over ten years just for her to be bested by a witch. If all is as I suspect, no force on Etheria will be a true match for her."

"What do you mean?" Kesi asked.

Kelara gently shook her head. "That is for later. For now, we should get you back to your rooms so that you can rest. And also

explain why a statue burst to life and started to comfort Her Highness."

Catra couldn't help but giggle, feeling a little lightheaded. "Yeah, that… that sounds like a great idea. I could use a nap."

Chapter End Notes

On the off chance that anyone is curious, Caspin was with Kittrina and their therapist during the first scene and was with Cyrus for the rest.

Chapter 4: Cuddling through the Politics

Chapter by Zelenal

Chapter Summary

A month after Adora's abduction, Catra must fast her greatest enemy yet: politics.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Royal Council Chamber

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

One Month After Adora's Abduction

The Royal Council chamber was packed full. While Halfmoon's citizenry were more politically engaged than most other kingdom's, today saw a particularly large turnout. Every single seat set aside for spectators was filled and the viewership for those watching at home was high, too. The reason for such a turnout was simple:

Princess Catra was going to be speaking before the Council.

Ever since the second coup attempt, Catra's popularity among the people had skyrocketed. Many people had been present to watch her fight with Baron Bloodclaw and word of the fight had spread like wildfire, no doubt growing wilder with each retelling. That alone would have garnered her a fair bit of extra popularity

(and she was already fairly popular to start with) but there was more.

Catra had been at the forefront of the rebuilding efforts: she was constantly overseeing them when possible and even frequently assisted with the manual labor. She led the memorial service for those lost in the attack and even assisted those who had lost their homes or livelihoods.

While the people adored their valiant Warrior Princess, those close to Catra were worried. Between all of the extra work she was doing on top of her studies as well as magic and martial training, she was working herself to the bone. Kesi tried her best as both her Seneschal and her *khai'tel* to get her to slow down and rest but there was only so much that she could do. It had gotten to the point where she had to use her status as Catra's *khai'tel* and all but demand cuddle time in order to get her to take breaks.

Another reason for Catra's increased popularity had nothing to do with what she had done but instead with what she had lost. It was now known to the populace writ large that Adora was classified as missing in action—she was even a large part of the memorial made in the Waxing Market to the cave culture people who had lost their lives that day—and everyone knew that Adora had been incredibly close to Catra (even if few people knew *how* close). Simply put, the fact that their Princess was maintaining an upbeat façade and putting her people first despite her own grief was inspiring.

Catra actually had Melog, Kesi, Caspin, and her parents to thank for that. While her bond with Kesi brought her a level of comfort and joy, there was still an Adora-shaped hole in their lives that absolutely nothing could fill. Catra and Kesi loved each other, yes, and that love helped to ease the pain somewhat but neither of them were *Adora.*

Adora was like a planet with her very own gravity: she drew people in and made them orbit her simply by *existing.* And no one

had been orbiting her closer than Catra and Kesi. Without Adora there, the two of them were sent spiraling off into the darkness, orbiting each other but without their anchor point.

That was where the others came in. Catra's family and Melog (and Kelara for Kesi) helped hold them in place. They stopped them from spiraling into oblivion and kept them grounded until the day came that they could start orbiting their planet again.

This was the danger of imprints; the ugly, dark side that no one wanted to so much as *think* about. They amplified existing emotions a thousand fold, bonding two or three souls together forever. While this usually lead to unimaginable joy, the pain that it could bring was equally unfathomable.

There was a reason Magicats had a word specifically for those who lost their *khai'tel.*

It was in the name of getting Adora back that led to Catra standing before the Council in her finest regalia. Her parents—also dressed in their regal finery—sat in the center of the u-shaped table where all of the various Councilors sat. Catra glanced around at all of them from where she stood in the center.

Catra took in a deep breath as she drew herself up to her full height and began. "Good people of the Council, I am here to present for your consideration this entreatment: It is time that Halfmoon considered opening itself back up to the other kingdoms and nations of Etheria."

Catra's words caused a low murmur to break out in the audience as most of the Councilors shared furtive glances. She knew that Lenio, Askar, a few others, and likely Haverisk would vote in favor of her but she needed a three-fourths majority in order for a resolution to pass.

"I am aware that Halfmoon has survived as long as it has due to remaining hidden but times are changing and we must change with them! What happened a month ago showed an increase in

hostilities and expenditure of resources from both the Horde and the neighboring tribes. We had to repel an invasion on top of dealing with the coup attempt!

"Halfmoon managed to stand this time but what about the next? Or the one after that? We don't have the resources or military might to maintain a forever war. We *need* to start reaching out to those who could be our allies and start forming diplomatic relations with them. I want Halfmoon to stand strong now and forever but we *cannot* stand alone! Not anymore!"

Low whispering rang out between the various Councilors as Catra concluded her speech. They were too quiet for her to fully hear but, judging by the looks she was getting, her prospects were grim.

That was fine. She didn't expect to win this fight in one go, anyway.

"You speak as though it were an inevitability, Your Highness," one of the Councilors said. "What, pray tell, makes you assume such?"

"Simple logic," Catra rebutted. "This assault by the Horde was *much* larger in scope and scale than the previous one. We know that the Horde has *far* more military resources at its disposal than what was used here. Even now, we still have troops fighting Horde encampments in the tunnels to keep Halfmoon safe."

"And they have done a valiant job," the Councilor said. "However, we were successful in repelling them, were we not? King Cyrus himself was present on the front lines to fend off the invaders. While our losses were unfortunate, the fact of the matter remains that we were not so hard pressed as to require aid."

Catra's tail lashed as she fought to keep her temper under control. "And you suggest that we wait until we *do* need aid? That we maintain the status quo until the Horde shatters it and us

along with it? I would much rather protect Halfmoon, Councilor, than avenge it."

At this point, Minister Imoh leaned forward in his seat and said, "Your Highness, while you have provided a number of potentially valid points, I think you are hiding the true reason behind your desire." Catra went very, *very* still. "We understand that Adora meant a lot to the Royal Family and you in particular but opening ourselves up just to try and find a dear friend of your __"

"She's *not* just a dear friend!" Catra interrupted with a low growl, her expression the perfect picture of rage as fire burned behind her eyes. "She's my *khai'tel! Yes,* I want to get her back more than anything but that doesn't change the truth of my other points! If the Horde is going to continue to increase the intensity of assaults against us, we *need* allies like those we could find on the surface! I don't want to get rid of all that Halfmoon stands for, I want to *preserve* it!"

Imoh sat back in his chair with a look of shock on his face that was mirrored by a few other Councilors. "Adora is your *khai'tel?"* he asked.

Catra schooled her features as she answered, "Yes. She has been for the past two years."

Imoh hummed as a thoughtful look crossed his face. "Well, that certainly does change a few things. If she is your *khai'tel* then that practically makes her a member of the Royal Family."

Catra fought back a sign of relief. Thus far, things had all gone according to plan. The imprint was one of the most sacred things to Magicats and thus was not something to be casually ignored. It was also something that one simply didn't lie about—that was why people were accepting Catra's words as the truth without any sort of evidence.

With the knowledge that Catra had imprinted with Adora now public, a *lot* more people would be more open to the idea Catra was presenting. Catra's desire to get her *khai'tel* back was something that damn near every Magicat could understand and support. By bundling that up with other things, it made the whole package sound that much more appealing.

As for why Catra hadn't *led* with that information, it was a rather simple matter of pragmatism. By pleading her case from a more rational standpoint from the start, it would sway those who care more about such things because the emotional aspect swayed others. If it had been the other way around, it would have simply seemed like logic being used to justify an emotional response.

"How do you propose we go about doing this?" Minister Haverisk asked.

"We need to create a new path; none of the existing ones will work. We already have a number of smugglers that we use to procure certain supplies so I propose that we create a new path from Halfmoon to a cape or cove. From there, we can acquire the services of one of our smugglers to transport a delegation consisting of myself, Kesi, another diplomat, and a few guards to wherever we wish. Our most valuable smuggler—one Captain Sea Hawk—apparently has ties with Salineas so that is who I recommend that we reach out to first. It would also make the most sense seeing as how our main contact point with the surface would be via the sea."

Catra paused to gather her thoughts as well as take in the general vibe of the place. The audience hadn't fully ceased murmuring since the moment Catra's imprint was revealed and getting a read on them was impossible from Catra's angle. As for the Councilors, the vast majority of them were looking contemplative.

Time for the coup de grâce.

"Halfmoon has *so much* that we can offer the world and the world has much that they can offer us in return. We are a wonderful, proud people with a rich tradition and that doesn't have to change just because we'll be making contact with the surface again! Even for those of us with no desire to go the surface can surely see the benefits of trade deals. We wouldn't have to worry about water anymore and we'd have a greater variety of foods to choose from! To say nothing about all of the other markets!

"And to the crafters: your products would be able to be appreciated and enjoyed by more people! You would have new methods and techniques to study and learn from and improve upon! You could show the whole *world* why goods crafted in Halfmoon were once highly sought-after!

"Halfmoon stands strong now and forever but we could be *so* much stronger if we reached our hand out to those who would aid us. It would make us stronger as a people and I—" Catra swallowed thickly, "I would have an easier time getting Adora, my *khai'tel,* back. Please, esteemed Councilors, consider my words and grant me my request."

With her piece said, Catra folded her hands in front of her and started her hardest task: waiting.

Catra waited and watched as the Councilors whispered amongst themselves for what felt like an eon. Eventually, the talking began to settle and Lyra spoke up.

"Well, Councilors, if there are no further questions or objections then I say it is time to put the proposal to a vote. Does Halfmoon stay the course and remained closed off or do we start to open ourselves up to the wider world?"

Catra held her breath as the vote started to be tallied. One by one, each Councilor submitted their vote and Catra's nerves became more unsettled with each one. She felt Melog—invisible—brush against her leg and reach out into her mind, reminding her

to breathe and that, even if the petition failed to pass, they would get another chance.

Eventually, the final vote was cast and Catra stilled as her mother read out the results.

"The Royal Council of Halfmoon hereby decrees that Princess Catra Dr'iluth's petition passes. Further details regarding the project shall be discussed at a later date. This Council is adjourned and dismissed."

Catra's Rooms

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

One Month After Adora's Abduction

Catra let out an explosive sigh that she had been holding in since the end of the meeting as Kesi closed the door to her rooms. They had just gotten back from an impromptu celebration of sorts and Catra was *exhausted.* Politicking wasn't her favorite thing in the world to do on her *good* days and she hadn't had one of those in about a month. As it was, she was fighting a slight headache building behind her eyes.

"So, Catra, what's next on the docket?" Kesi asked lightly. It was an absurd question on the surface since she was the one in charge of Catra's schedule but Catra knew what she was *really* asking.

Catra thought about all of the work she still had to do. While her petition may have passed, there was still the matter of the logistics of the project. On top of that was all of the work that still needed to be done with the rebuilding effort before work on

Catra's project could even begin. Then there were the public appearances that Catra was going to make that she needed to prepare for. The list of things to do went on, really.

With all that in mind, Catra turned to Kesi, took a deep breath, and said, "I think right now I could do with some cuddles."

Kesi's face lit up as her ears perked up and her tail swayed happily as pride sparkled in her eyes. "Sounds good to me!" she said brightly. "The loveseat or the bed?"

"The loveseat. If I lay down on the bed, I might not get up for the rest of the day," Catra answered as she made her way to her bedroom to strip out of her formalwear and into something more comfortable. Kesi followed behind her and helped her with the process, as usual.

(Catra *used* to have a lady-in-waiting to help her with this but, these days, she only ever wanted Kesi's help. Her lady-in-waiting got reassigned elsewhere.)

Kesi giggled, the sound causing Catra's heart to do funny things in her chest. "You say that as if it's a bad thing."

Catra sighed wearily as they got her out of her outermost layer of clothing after a couple of minutes of silence. The underlayers wouldn't take nearly as long, thankfully. Not for the first time, Catra envied Kesi's ability to wear less clothing than she had to. Stupid politics.

As Catra started to strip down to her underwear while Kesi picked out a simple outfit for her, Catra replied, "That's because it is—you know as well as I do how much work there is to be done. I'm willing to take a break but I can't afford to take an entire day off. Not yet." *Not until Adora's back home.*

With Catra now in more casual clothes, the duo exited the Princess' closet and made their way back to her living room. "I understand but please don't push yourself *too* hard. You have

plenty of people who can and *will* help you, you know," Kesi said as they went.

"Yeah, I know," Catra returned with a rueful smile.

"So, how do you want to do this?" Kesi asked as they came to a stop in front of Catra's loveseat.

Instead of answering with words, Catra gently pushed Kesi until she was sitting down and paused just long enough to let her get comfortable before climbing into her lap. Catra tucked her face into Kesi's neck and grabbed a hold of the front of her top with one hand while the other wound its way across her back to grab the opposite shoulder.

Kesi, meanwhile, started purring as she wrapped her arms around her *khai'tel* and nuzzled into her mane before planting a gentle kiss there. Kesi couldn't kiss Catra properly—not for another year, at least—but this much was more than fine for the time being. (Catra was grateful for the fact that she and Adora had already kissed, meaning that Kesi wouldn't have misplaced guilt holding her back.)

While Kesi got to work stroking up and down Catra's spine, Catra gently rubbed her cheek against Kesi's shoulder, scent marking her, before starting to slowly groom her neck with little licks. Kesi's purr grew louder in response as she pulled Catra closer to her and nuzzled further into her mane, no doubt fighting off the urge to scent mark her in return.

Not for the first time, Catra loathed the fact that she was unable to purr ever since Adora had been taken away. She'd give just about everything to let Kesi hear just how happy and content she was.

Also not for the first time, Catra cursed the fact that they had to keep their imprint a secret from just about everyone. While there was nothing wrong with it in theory, in practice, politics got in the way. If it was known that Catra and Kesi were imprinted,

fewer people would be willing to vote in favor of Catra's petition. After all, certain parties were no doubt only willing to agree for the sake of continuing the royal lineage since Caspin couldn't bond with the Spirit Ember. Catra having another imprint would all but insure that.

The pair stayed that way for a long while with Catra stopping her grooming once she ran out of fur she could reach without moving. Catra slowly but surely relaxed and started to feel the siren's song of sleep calling out to her, begging her to rest in the comfort and safety of Kesi's arms. In order to not succumb to it, Catra sat up enough to look into Kesi's eyes.

There was little that Catra wanted more in that moment than to be able to properly kiss her *khai'tel.* However, as Adora would say, stupid magic number theory got in the way. So, instead, Catra made do with placing a featherlight kiss on her cheek before giving herself this one indulgence and placing the smallest scent mark that she could there.

Kesi gasp and stiffened at the action for a moment before practically melting, curling around Catra and holding her as close as she could while tucking her back into the crook of her neck. Her purr became louder than it had ever been before, the vibrations spreading into Catra and turning her into a bit of a puddle as she got to work grooming the other side of Kesi's neck.

"I love you," Kesi said after a moment, her voice cutely distorted by the strength of her purr.

Catra paused in her grooming and focused long enough to force herself purr for just the briefest of moments before answering, "I love you, too."

As the pair relaxed in their love for each other, Catra couldn't help but think how they no doubt had many more trials and tribulations ahead of them but, despite not having Adora, they would have each other. They would stand together against

everything the world threw at them and they would come out the other side with their missing piece back where she belonged.

They would make sure of it.

Chapter End Notes

What's this? Another Zelenal chapter breaking the pattern? Yeah, I didn't have any ideas for Chapter 4 of KotFZ so tp and I ended up switching.

I had actually considered ending the previous chapter with some good, old Ketra cuddling but I'm glad that I didn't because I had absolutely nothing else for this chapter. I'm not entirely satisfied with the politicking here but I have zero experience writing it so what'cha gonna do? It is what it is.

As a reminder, Catra is currently seventeen and we're only about a month out from eleven years after the first coup attempt.

Chapter 5: Caspin's Day

Chapter Summary

It's both the one year anniversary of Adora's capture, and Caspin's eleventh birthday. Surely nothing will go wrong.

Caspin’s Rooms

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

One Year After Adora’s Abduction

Caspin awoke before the early hours of the morning. He could never sleep long, always worried about the faceless monsters from their dreams. They looked like people but they served the dark Horde and the terrible Lord Hordak. Everyone knew that he had gotten his claws into Halfmoon; people who wanted to see them and their family dead. They had tried, a year ago. They had broken into this very room. If he sniffed hard enough, he could still smell their blood mixed with the blood of Auntie Kittrina.

Worst of all, they had hurt the family by taking away Adora. He had lost a sister that day, and Catra had never recovered from it. Once, she had been so happy, and friendly. Now, she stalked like a beast through the corridors. If it wasn’t for Melog prowling behind her, Caspin would have become terrified of her and her glares.

One year from the worst day in Halfmoon, and nearly twelve years since they had tried before. They would come back, and hurt them all over again. Training wasn’t going fast enough. He would have to ask Dad to give them more to do. They were

getting big now, nearly as tall as Catra, and she had been learning to fight when she was only a little bit older than him and Adora had already been a warrior before coming to Halfmoon when she was five!

The door cracked open, and Auntie Kittrina peered in. She wasn't actually his aunt, but had been their personal bodyguard since they were a tiny kitten. Seeing he was awake, she entered the room.

"Happy Birthday, Kit," she said, smiling down at them. She had an almost maternal look about her; she was certainly protective enough of them. She had often asked her grandfather for permission to teach them how to fight properly but such a task was down to Cyrus and Lyra.

Caspin buried their face in the blankets, not wanting to face today. Auntie Kittrina laughed and went to turn them by their shoulder. "Now, none of that. Gotta get up and face the day, or I'll have to deal with Perci and he'll be mean, maybe even irate."

He laughed at that; she could always get a laugh out of them. Sitting up, she reached over to grab a comb, running it through their unruly red hair. He had refused to have it styled like Catra had done and it was becoming a full mane of hair. It required fairly constant maintenance or it would become knotted and matted. This became a routine for them: every morning: Auntie Kittrina would come from training to wake them and then brush their fur out. Sometimes Mama would come if Auntie Kittrina was busy.

She kept brushing through their hair and going through the day's itinerary as Percival had given it to them until the first alarm rang, at which point they got dressed and headed off to breakfast, Kittrina never more than a half-step behind.

As they entered, Cyrus scooped him up into a hug. "There's my little tiger cub." He had got used to scooping up his children into tight hugs, as if reassuring themselves they were still here

and safe. Caspin laughed and held him close, burying his nose into his dad's shoulder. The two took a seat at the small table. Several rich breakfast foods had been laid out, as well as a small collection of teas. The supply was running low so they would need to acquire more soon; Caspin noticed and made a mental note of that. It was one thing that they were very good at, keeping mental lists and tallies.

Catra stalked into the room, her eyes rimmed red and her ears drooped. Today marked one year since she had last seen Adora, since anyone had last seen Adora. It was supposed to be a day of celebration for their birthday and the fact that Adora had proved herself a blademaster by beating up General Askar. But, instead, the worst happened and Adora was gone, a prisoner in the Horde being tortured with magic, and every attempt to find her had failed leaving Catra and Kesi both miserable. She still tried to smile at him, even if it never reached her eyes. She would keep herself busy today.

Today was the grand opening of the tunnel to the outside world to coincide with what celebrations were to happen, the first true contact with the outside world. Caspin almost couldn't imagine it, seeing the daymoons, and it started here.

Lyra joined them soon after and ruffled his hair. She pulled Catra in for a tight hug and squeezed her gently, muttering something even Caspin's sharp hearing couldn't catch. They ate in relatively comfortable silence.

Training today would wait for both of them. Cyrus took them all out to a skiff where Kesi was sitting already. She smiled at him as they all got aboard but it faded quickly as they set off, a servant piloting the vehicle out towards the tunnel.

Caspin hadn't seen it yet, the vast tunnel built near the Dark Lake and heading out into the twisting dark. A series of carts all connected to a complicated magical line was in the designs. The great indorium portcullis lay closed and the connecting tracks cut off from the outside world until royal assent was given.

As they approached, the crowd of workers parted for the royal vehicle. Catra was going to give a speech—Cyrus had stepped off the vehicle and made his way over speaking to the foreman in charge of the project. Ferrus was a growing voice in the city for the expansionists. The work on this project was huge and, as the first Magicat to see the sky since Cyrus and not in a life or death scenario, he had been emboldened to finish this project.

Catra stood before a large group of construction workers, a small collection of journalists, and even a class full of students from a school near the Dark Lake; all of whom had come out to hear the Princess speak. Caspin took a place near the pedestal alongside their dad while Catra gave Kesi a quick hug, and stepped up onto the stage. Suddenly, she was entirely different. Caspin had seen her do this before, hide her emotions behind a mask. Mama did it sometimes, and Catra could only manage it when dealing with politics. She cleared her throat and the speech begun.

"Thank you all for coming. I cannot overstate how pleased I am that this project has come to fruition in such record time. It is thanks to the hard work of you all," she gestured to the work crews who gave a half-hearted applause of acknowledgement, "that we can begin our first steps on the long road to return the Magicats to our former glory.

"I cannot say if it will be in our lifetimes, I cannot say if it will be easy, but I promise on the honour of House Dr'iluth one day our children will walk in the trees again under the daymoons' light.

"That promise starts here with this tunnel, through which we will bring trade. One day, we shall have a dock and ships from the seas of Salineas to the bays of Bright Moon coming to buy and sell goods made by craftspeople of the Crescent Market. We will rebuild not just to how we stood before the Horde fell, but brighter, with connections all over Etheria rather than just subservient to the Empire of the Nest. We will rise stronger from our defeats; now and always Halfmoon stands."

Catra threw back a switch and the portcullis raised open for the first time. While it would remain closed for the majority of the time, this ceremonial opening felt like something had shifted, even to Caspin's senses. He knew this wasn't just about connecting Halfmoon back to the surface, though that was definitely present in his sister's mind, instead, it was about finding Adora, giving her a safe path back to Halfmoon. No one knew all the routes down through the dark of Subtheria, not even their best scouts, but if she heard about this hidden cove—The Princess' Path, it was nicknamed—then she could find her way back home.

A cheer went up through the crowd, and people began to move around. One of the journalists tried to grab Catra's attention and she kept up her mask of being the Princess rather than his sister. She was every bit the regal princess she was born to be.

Caspin noticed some of the other children around their age were gathered close, and they darted off towards them, Kittrina looming close behind. Some of them he knew, others he didn't, but Caspin was friendly with everyone and the other kids deserved to know that the royals were just like them. For a while they just talked away, soon would come celebrations for their birthday, everyone knew that today was their birthday and the grand opening. Two momentous days for Halfmoon.

The lingering dread in Caspin's stomach began to uncoil only to come back when a dreadful alarm sounded and out across the lake there were shouts and screams and the smell of char from a burning building.

Cove Gateway

The Dark Lake

Halfmoon

Subtheria

One Year After Adora's Abduction

Catra's fur stood on end. All through the speech, there was the gnawing sense of dread. Something was going to go wrong, she could feel it. She managed to get through the speech without faltering and without breaking down. Even now, a year later, she would look over her shoulder expecting to see pale skin and golden hair watching her back. Instead, she had just empty space.

She went through the motions, speaking to each person in turn. She really wanted to be back in her bedroom in that little crawlspace under her bed weeping that Adora wasn't here, clinging to her shirt, breathing deeply in that scent she hadn't held the source of in a year. Instead, she was here talking to some representative of the Council about the importance of speed for the line, how they had to get themselves set up quickly. Without Melog there offering her comfort, she would have screamed, but the Kryten offered her comfort and reminded her to be calm. She was so lost in her own head and in talking with Melog, she almost missed the sound.

Screaming from across the Dark Lake, its echoing sound reverberating and carried across the water. Most heads turned towards it. A great fire burning on the plantation house, and the distinctive sound of blaster fire as if from Horde weaponry. She looked across at Caspin whose ears were pinned back in fear, all the children of around his age, all gathered for a trip to the Dark Lake. Some would be on that far side, she realized at the same time as her father, and with nothing more than a look, they both sprinted to the skiff.

Caspin leapt on behind them, and Kittrina barely a second before the skiff pulled away. She took control of the vehicle from Cyrus who, by his own admission, wasn't a very good pilot, and Catra had crashed the last three skiffs she had tried to learn. But Kittrina was a damn good skiff pilot and, with her at the helm, they were racing towards the scene of the battle.

Cyrus looked over at her and then down at them. “Stay in the skiff. I don’t want you getting hurt,” he said to both his children. Kittrina nodded and leaned towards Caspin, but Catra just glared. He sighed once, muttering something about *“Lyra’s going to skin me alive.”*

They swung down towards an ongoing firefight. The few armed citizens of Halfmoon this far out to the Dark Lake would be the guards for the small farms and fisheries and a handful of scouts, all of whom were engaging a group of Fishfolk. As they got close, one of the guards wearing the pins of a captain broke off, slinging a long, modified Horde rifle on her back. She gave a sharp salute.

“Your Majesty, Your Highnesses,” she started off, ducking as a shot whizzed overhead. Returning to her normal posture, she continued, “The Fishfolk blew a hole into a nearby cave system connected to the water. There’s less than a dozen of them we think, but…” Catra’s enhanced senses attuned to the ley lines spotted them. A group of school children no older than Caspin, three of them being held in rough, webbed fingers digging into their fur. “They’ve got kids.”

Cyrus hissed, he stepped out blades drawn.

He trusted Catra to start working on something, some spell to get the kids to safety when he struck. If the Fishfolk had allied with the Horde then they would break or die, but they wouldn’t get to take any children back to the Fright Zone to live in that nightmarish place. It was not a place for Magicats, not for Adora.

They wouldn’t know anything, those fools who had made a deal beyond their understanding of what it would cost them. She began to work out a spell, a small shield designed to cover the children, protecting them from harm. Her father was snarling down at the Fishfolk who were terrified. Everyone knew what Cyrus could do. He was a legendary warrior feared even in the Horde and well into the depths of the Dark Lake and the colonies within.

The guard captain had taken up a position near her behind an overturned refuse cart, aiming her rifle down towards the leader of the Fishfolk who was currently speaking in his guttural, wet voice threatening them all overcompensating for his fear with bravado. The Fishfolk loosened his grip for a moment and the heartbeat that he did, Catra cast her spells.

The first was a shield buffering them against harm, the second was a gale force wind generated by an explosion on the surface of the lake, the strength of which caused several of the Fishfolk to stagger, and the children to get knocked away from the blast and to the ground. The guardswoman adjusted quickly to this unknown and impromptu signal and put a single round clean through the eye of the now rising Fishfolk leader who toppled backwards very dead.

It was a sudden blur of violence. Cyrus leapt into the group while several guards rushed forwards to grab the children and pull them back to safety. The Fishfolk sorcerer began to encant a spell, but suddenly found his gills filled with Halfmoon indorium from Cyrus' blade striking his throat. Two had recovered quickly and went to rush Cyrus, but he wove around their strikes and cut down the first while Catra engulfed the other in an explosion, killing him instantly. The rest fell just as quickly to the combined might of the royals and the small surviving guard unit, until there was only one left, several guns and swords pointed at him.

Cyrus leaned over the last one, his voice barely a whisper. "How many?" The Fishfolk quavered in fear. "How many children did you get down there, and what's waiting? Tell me that and you can swim back to your little colony and tell them that this was as bad an idea as you could fathom."

The Fishfolk looked around at all its allies lying dead on the shore, and at the safety of the lake still rocking with waves from the explosion only a few seconds earlier. "Fi-five," it stammered out. "Five children we managed to grab, a few of us took them down to meet a Horde company. They'll be there by now." With a thought, Melog, who had been acting a silent vigil, set off into the

tunnels following their scent. Cyrus nodded once and raised his sword from the Fishfolk's throat, who instantly bounded towards the water.

He looked over at Catra, and then swore under his breath. “Alright, we're going together. But you follow my instructions. If I say retreat, we retreat.” Catra stepped up next to him.

“We need to do this.” She had conviction and anger in her voice. “Melog has found them—there’s tanks, Dad. I can deal with them if you can get the kids.” She turned, her staff already twirling in her hands. Cyrus sighed and went to move after her. When the one soldier who had shot the leader stepped forward, she gave a sharp salute.

“My name’s Elara, Former Scout of the fifth company. You’ll need someone to watch your backs down there, Your Majesty.” She had the look of a career soldier. Cyrus nodded.

“You’ll have to keep up; we can’t afford any time wasted. But if you can do that then welcome aboard this suicide mission, Elara.” He gestured towards the mouth of the cave which Catra was already entering, staff glowing with arcane fire. The two broke into a jog to catch her.

Deep Caverns

Under the Dark Lake

Halfmoon Exterior

Subtheria

One Year After Adora’s Abduction

The Horde were fools to think to use caverns against them, but the Horde was often foolish. The Magicats had spent their lives hunting in the dark, and the difference between the great

forests and the sprawling tunnels was not so great. Light had a difficult time penetrating it and the prey they hunted made a lot of noise. It was true in the forest as it was true in the caves, only the creatures of Subtheria were better suited to this existence than them.

Melog had followed the trail to the Horde encampment: a small area lit by floodlights and the burning of a small campfire, over which a handful of soldiers had left the corpse of some beast that had got to close to the Horde's movements roasting over the flame and no doubt tasted better than ration bars even completely charred. As the three approached the edge of the firelight, Melog wrapped them in their cloaking magic. All three could hear the sound of shouting and fighting already taking place deeper in. The three moved ahead silently, Elara looking around confused when she realized she was invisible. They got towards the back of the cave only to see a confusing scene.

The five children were cowering behind a stalagmite, a Lizardfolk carrying a quarterstaff stood between them and the rest of the Horde soldiers, a pile of over a dozen broken bots and fallen soldiers. The shouts of "Traitor" and "Coward" were screamed above the roar of the tanks trying to get a clear shot. The Lizard was injured, bleeding from a dozen places, clearly powering through his pain through sheer force of will.

Cyrus leaned over, and muttered so only their hearing would pick it up. "Elara, take pot shots at any sorcerers you see and the commander if you see them. Catra, take out those tanks. I'll go help the Lizardman." They each moved into position. With a gesture, Melog followed Elara; her sniping would be better suited to stealth.

The Lizardfolk roared once, and it was clearly an expletive as Cyrus chuckled, then lunged forward, directly into the back of the amassed attackers. Catra stepped out, flaring her arms wide, tapping into the ley lines that surrounded Subtheria and with it reached a spell into the engines of each of the Horde's tanks,

causing a cascading explosion through each of them, and raining shrapnel down on the closest Horde soldiers.

The shout went up of “Sorcerer!” and a hail of blaster fire rained down upon her hastily erected shield which cut off quickly as the twin blades of Cyrus cut a swathe through the troops at the middle.

In the tight confines, Cyrus became a whirlwind of death, cutting through Horde soldiers like a bolt of lightning headed towards the staggering Lizardfolk. One of the soldiers managed to lean up behind Cyrus, only for his head to snap sideways as a bolt of a sniper rifle struck him from the dark. Cyrus continued as if nothing had happened.

Catra had room to breath, which meant she had room to cast. She could see what the Lizardfolk was trying to do: create a narrow corridor along which the soldiers would be funneled to face his wrath. The man was clearly an expert warrior, but his injuries would cause him to fall. She flicked her wrist and every Horde bot that had fallen detonated into a small column of flame which she spread in a wide ring around the children and a tunnel towards the Horde soldier. The only clear path around the stalagmite was through him. A warning to him and the whole Horde army of her power, and to show she had no intention of hurting the children who clang tightly to each other, ears pinned back and tails tucked low.

Every Horde soldier in the room was now trying to split their focus three ways, and without the heavy armour of the tanks to support them, they knew this was a losing battle. The commander had got out of his tank and was shouting orders when a round from a different corner of the room went through his throat and he toppled in a heap. Cyrus had cut down two dozen soldiers and the rest were trying to give him a wide berth to bring their guns to bare, but as soon as they stepped back, Catra was free to annihilate them with blasts of magic, all the while the bots, ordered to capture the children, continued their descent onto the lone traitor.

One of the soldiers reached onto his belt and pulled a grenade, a mistake he couldn't even begin to comprehend. Catra was the master of explosions here. As he pulled out the pin, she simply reached over with a gesture and caused it to detonate in his hand.

Others began to drop their weapons and flee. There was not much to be done. As skilled as they were, three warriors could not kill everyone in the room. The goal was not slaughter, it was securing the children.

The remaining bots became Catra's priority, even as they descended upon the strange Lizardfolk. She leapt forward, creating a burst of superheated air behind her to propel her forwards, over the heads of a handful of the bots. As she passed over each one, her hand flashed open, dropping a seed of flame which burst amongst them destroying whole groups and sometimes Horde soldiers who lacked the ability to get away. She landed gracefully, bringing her staff up next to the Lizardfolk and driving it into the core processor of one of the bots.

The children watched in fascination. In *Aiilayra,* they started to shout "It's the Princess! She's come to save us!" Before she could respond, another of the bots rushed down the column of fire. She held out her staff and it became a torch throwing fire down towards the bot, which melted into slag.

With a final snapping shot, the last of the unbroken Horde soldiers fell. The others had retreated into the tunnels of Subtheria where they would surely die, and if any did make it back, they would have to report this failure to Shadow Weaver. The Lizardfolk rounded on her while she let the fire die, hissing and clicking in their guttural language that she couldn't understand. But his staff came up in a defensive posture, even as he swayed on his feet.

The children with no understanding of what happened darted out and around towards her. Seeing the kittens protected, the Lizardfolk took one look at her, and then toppled backwards. Catra

stared at him, this warrior who had betrayed the Horde to protect a group of kittens, blood leaking from a dozen wounds and Catra had the distinct impression that his leg shouldn't be bent that way.

"He needs a healer," she said as Cyrus approached. He looked down at him, and sighed.

"Your mother is going to kill me tonight, I think. Not today; she wouldn't want to ruin Caspin's birthday anymore than it already is." He reached down and picked up the Lizardman by the shoulder. He was no expert in these things, but he would guess this Lizardfolk was young, less than two decades old. Cyrus was never one for tradition but he was about to break one of their most sacred rules. He had to hope that this Lizardfolk's honour stretched far enough to not get them all killed.

Royal Infirmary

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

One Year After Adora's Abduction

Rogelio awoke to a bright light. He was laying down on a large metal bed, his right leg wrapped in heavy cloth and two wooden sticks acting as a splint. His left wrist was shackled to the side of the bed and his right hand was unusable at the moment anyway from where that stray bolt had hit his hand. It burnt through the metal of his glove and nearly took off his fingers—they wouldn't bend properly. But waking up at all was a miracle.

He hissed as he tried to move his head, and a large figure came into view over him, a grey furred hybrid, like the children he had saved and condemned himself for. Were all of the beings

down here cat hybrids? It approached him, wearing the gear of a medic.

Leaning over, the figure said in a deep, gruff voice in an accent he didn't recognise, [[You took a few nasty injury. What is name?]] His mouth barely formed the words properly; each syllable was only barely comprehensible. He clearly realized the confusion on Rogelio's face when he followed up with [[Speak Etherian? NodShake]].

Rogelio nodded once and the figure chuckled. [[I am Sergeant Rogelio of the Fifteenth Scout Division, badge number 2814/15/D]] Rogelio went back to his old training, what to do when captured. This was a medical officer, so someone clearly trained in torture. He had betrayed his company, he would not betray the Horde's secrets. Especially not to a torturer.

The figure approached again. "Hello, Rogelio. My name is Healer Lenio. You took several injuries during the fighting. I would ask why you did it but, to be honest, I think you're just young and idealistic. Your leg is broken, you are suffering from severe internal bleeding, and that's beside all the external wounds. You are lucky they got you to me when they did."

Rogelio stared into the hybrid's eyes. The man was ancient; he seemed to have some wisdom, but he had the terrifying aura of command of not only a sorcerer but a doctor. The fear that gripped Rogelio caused him to repeat [[I am Sergeant Rogelio of the Fifteenth Scout Division, badge number 2814/15/D]]. The doctor only sighed.

"I have to let you know, we have no intention of torturing you." Which was exactly what a torturer would say. "If you wish to go back to the Horde, I shall make sure you receive appropriate medical attention." So, they were going to torture him. "Then we will blindfold you and take you out to one of the far tunnels near Horde territory via a route you wouldn't be able to find back, then take the blindfold off. Can't have you knowing where we are. However, the King has given special dispensation for you to

remain on account of you saving those kits.” Rogelio tilted his head again, and felt woozy.

[[I have betrayed the Horde.]] The weight of the statement hit him like a blaster bolt to the chest—it suddenly felt tight. [[I have betrayed Lonnie, and Kyle,]] he choked out the words. [[I…]].

The old hybrid laid one paw on his shoulder and said. “You can rest now, Rogelio. Make your decision in the morning. Princess Catra will want to speak to you. I can give you something for the pain?” This doctor was hiding behind a veneer of kindness, but he was his only chance out. He wanted to bring a Princess to speak with him. Let her come.

He bared his teeth at the doctor. [[Bring her now! She wants to speak, let her talk!]] If they were going to have a Princess torture him, then he would do it with a clear head. Full of righteous anger, as Lonnie had shown him. He would be defiant as Adora had been this last year against the Dark One’s intimidations.

The old doctor sighed, and reached down to a device and began speaking into it in a language Rogelio couldn’t understand. The doctor finished his conversation and set about checking over his bandaged wounds. “Once you have spoken to the Princess, I am giving you something to help with your pain. I know your young and tough, but unnecessary suffering is a pet peeve of mine. So you will shut up and take the treatment. Got it?”

A few more minutes later and the door slid open. Rogelio peaked outside to a corridor filled with a few more of those hybrids. The sorcerer from the fight stepped into the room, the one wearing a diadem of copper and wielding a staff of arcane power. She stormed into the room towards him.

This was a Princess? She was shorter than the films made them out to be. He had expected her to be ten feet tall and wreathed in flame. Instead, she was just over five feet of nervous anger. Before she could reach him, the doctor intercepted her and

they had a brief flurry of conversation in that sharp and fast language. It ended with her saying "Direct translations, I need to know!" and him nodding to her in acquiescence.

After their conversation, she continued towards him. Her voice was anger tinged with sadness. "You saved those children. Why?" She glared, expecting an answer. This was not an interrogation, but someone asking why they would act with kindness. The truth was complicated and oh so simple: Because it was the right thing to do, so no more children are taken from their creche and back to the suffering of the Horde, because they would suffer and he couldn't allow that. But mainly because that girl had put notions back in his head of honour and duty. She was getting to him and to Lonnie.

[[They would have suffered,]] he said, and the doctor translated. [[They would have suffered at the Dark Witch's hands.]] The young princesses eyes went wide. [[I couldn't bare to see crechling's suffer, not while I have strength in my claws.]]

"Awfully noble considering what the Horde do," she tried to snark at him, like he was unaware of the destruction. "Why the sudden change of heart? That's how they got most of you, right?"

He made an indignant noise. [[Some. I was given by my clan: an offering to the Horde. Most others are orphans; few are taken from living parents. I would not allow that.]] She seemed to accept that.

"I have one more question. You said your name was Rogelio? Do you know a woman named Adora?"

Caspin's Room

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

One Year After Adora's Abduction

After the terror of the morning, Caspin had retreated to their room, the lights cut off to rest in the dark. Kittrina had sat with him, curled around him and purring.

It took less than fifteen minutes for Mama to appear. She clambered up and Kittrina pulled back, and she took over purring. "I am sorry, my heart. This was not supposed to happen."

"Is it me?" Their voice was small. They were just a kitten, after all—eleven years old and already so scared. "Is my birthday a bad omen?" Tears spilled down their face. "Was it my fault 'Dora got taken?"

Lyra couldn't help the little sob that escaped her own throat as she gathered her child up in her arms.

Chapter 6: What Should Have Been

Chapter by Zelenal

Chapter Summary

Adora's eighteenth birthday rolls around and Kesi does not take it well.

Chapter Notes

My siblings in Kesi, prepare for pain.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora and Kesi's Rooms

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Almost Thirteen Years After the Coup Attempt

Kesi was purring before she was even fully awake. This had become her new normal ever since she started waking up in the strong arms of her one and only *khai'tel.* The warm scent of honey enveloped her and coaxed her back into the land of the awake even as the sound of Adora's almost purring and the feel of one her hands petting her ear made her let out a dreamy sigh.

There were precious few things better than getting to wake up in Adora's arms in Kesi's opinion. The love and care that her *khai'tel* radiated for her on a daily basis was euphoric and was something beyond even her wildest dreams. The fact that the strange, Etherian-looking girl she had met all those years ago was now the love of her life was simply incredible.

"Good morning, love," Adora said gently with a tender smile as Kesi slowly opened her eyes. She was laying on her side with her arms wrapped around Adora, her head pillowed on her shoulder, and her tail wrapped around Adora's calf while Adora laid on her back. It was their favorite position to sleep in.

Kesi couldn't hold back anymore—she didn't *have* to now that it was Adora's eighteenth birthday. She had wanted to stay up until midnight to do this as soon as possible but Adora had talked her into going to sleep at their normal time. She had said that they would have *plenty* of time for it in the morning and they wouldn't have to worry about getting sleepy.

Kesi surged forward and kissed Adora.

Kissing Adora was everything that Kesi had dreamed it would be and then some. Her lips were soft and warm, welcoming in a way that nothing else was. While the kiss was a bit clumsy due to Adora being inexperienced—what with this being her very first kiss (a fact that made Kesi's heart soar)—she *more* than made up for it with her enthusiasm and her being a fast learner.

Kesi brought one hand up to cup Adora's cheek, using gentle pressure to tilt her head to a better angle so that way Kesi could deepen the kiss. Adora chuckled slightly as Kesi's incredibly loud purr reverberated through their lips and tickled her. She quickly got used to the sensation, however, and returned the kiss with equal passion, her own pseudo-purr becoming as loud as she could make it.

Kesi pulled back for a moment, panting slightly to catch her breath while taking in Adora's deliriously happy smile before diving back in. She moved the hand that was cradling Adora's cheek to instead scratch lightly at the nape of her neck with her claws. This had the desired effect of making Adora open her mouth as she gasped, allowing Kesi to deepen the kiss further.

Adora tasted *incredible.* Kesi already knew this from all of the times she had groomed her *khai'tel* but being able to taste Adora

more directly and share her air with her was heavenly. This was only their first real kiss and Kesi was already addicted, wanting to do little more today than kiss her girlfriend senseless while cuddled as close to her as she possibly could be.

(Despite how much they were already pressed up against each other, there was still the annoying barrier that was their chestwraps and underwear getting in the way. While they both normally slept in the nude when sleeping on their own [a rarity once they imprinted], they don't when they share a bed due to, as Adora would say, magic number theory.)

(Kesi was very much looking forward to tonight for when she could *finally* feel all of Adora pressed up against all of herself as they went to sleep.)

As much as Kesi wanted to just keep kissing Adora, she had big plans for today so, with an effort worthy of She-Ra, she pulled back. Both of them were panting now and Kesi was pleased to see that Adora was flushed just like she was.

"Happy birthday, Adora," Kesi said softly with all of the love in her heart, her voice slightly distorted by the strength of her purr.

Adora's blush deepened as she gave Kesi that goofy little smile that she loved so much and said, "Thanks, Kesi. It's already my best birthday ever and we haven't even gotten out of bed yet."

Kesi couldn't help herself so she kissed Adora again, this one just a quick peck. They had plans for the day and other people who wished to see Adora on her special day so, with the greatest reluctance, Kesi got up.

They took their sweet time getting ready for the day—they got up before just about everyone else and both of them had the day off so they *could.* They chatted a bit about their plans for the day and a lot about nothing in particular as Adora went about carefully grooming Kesi, learning how to properly groom her chest and thighs for the first time.

When Adora was crouched down in front of Kesi to groom her legs, Adora looked up at her with a smirk that promised trouble before slowly kissing up the inside of one thigh and then slowly kissing down the inside of the other. Kesi couldn't help the slightly strangled noise that she made or the way her tail fluffed up even as she blushed bright enough to be visible through her fur.

Kesi had to fight down the urge to forgo all of their plans and make Adora hers right then and there. That would almost certainly happen today but that was for later. So, for the time being, Kesi just laughed and playfully swatted at her *khai'tel* while affectionately calling her a pervert.

"Only for you," Adora returned immediately with a slight laugh of her own. That did *not* help Kesi control herself in the slightest but she managed to do it somehow.

Once Adora was finished, Kesi returned the favor by brushing Adora's shoulder-length hair before doing it up in a complex braid that Adora loved. Once she was finished, Kesi decided to return the favor wrapping Adora in a tight hug from behind, purposefully pressing her breasts against Adora's back and giving her a slight nip on her shoulder.

Adora's breath stuttered as her eyes widened even as they darkened as her face was consumed by a blush. "If we keep this up, we'll end up missing breakfast," she said, trying for casual but *failing* due to the slightly rough quality of her voice. Kesi could *smell* the desire coming off of her *khai'tel* and it caused her self-control to fray just a little bit more.

"It wouldn't be the *worst* thing in the world," Kesi returned before kissing Adora on the cheek.

Adora pseudo-purred for a bit before saying, "Maybe but the others might come looking for us and *that* wouldn't be any fun."

Kesi let out an overly dramatic sigh as she pulled back. "You're right, as usual," she said before placing another kiss atop Adora's

head. “C’mon. Let’s get ready.”

After they finished with that, the couple moved on to their morning exercises (which may or may not have involved far more kissing during rest periods than usual) before finally getting properly dressed and ready for the day.

Kesi and Adora left their rooms and made their way to the private dining room for the Royal Family and friends hand-in-hand. When they arrived, it was to breakfast being laid out. Queen Lyra, King Cyrus, Caspin, Kittrina, Percival, Cloudfoot, and Clover were all already seated while Catra was just now sitting down.

“Took you two long enough. Thought you weren’t going to make it,” Clover greeted them as soon as they entered the room. She had a cup of tisane in her hands and a slight smirk on her face as her eyes were alight with mischief.

Adora gave an embarrassed chuckle but, before she could reply, Caspin shot out of their chair with a cry of “HAPPY BIRTHDAY, ‘DORA!” as they launched themself at her. Adora was forced to let go of Kesi’s hand so that way she could grab the young Princeps with a slight *oof.*

The others wished Adora a happy birthday in turn as she shifted Caspin in her arms to be able to hold him better before petting down his mane. “Thanks, everyone,” Adora said with an embarrassed smile as she and Kesi made their way over to the table.

Breakfast was its usual raucous affair with everyone chatting animatedly about their plans for the upcoming day. Well, most everyone. It was known that Kesi had claimed Adora for most of the day and that her plans were largely a secret (even though Adora, as clever as she was, no doubt had an inkling as to what her *khai’tel* had in store for her).

As breakfast was winding down, Clover got a mischievous look in her eye as she looked at Adora and asked, “So, Adora, how

good of a kisser is Kesi?"

Kesi promptly devolved into a coughing fit as she choked on her tisane while Adora sputtered even as she rubbed Kesi's back. Clover threw her head back as she laughed while Kittrina rolled her eyes and playfully swatted her girlfriend on her arm.

"EWWWW! Quit being gross at the breakfast table!" Caspin complained which just caused Clover to laugh louder.

"You won't find it gross in a few years, kiddo. Or maybe you still will. Who knows," Clover replied through her laughter.

Once Kesi had stopped coughing, Adora squeezed her shoulder before addressing Clover. "She's fantastic," she answered Clover's earlier question with a smug smirk.

That set Clover to laughing again even as Kesi exclaimed "Adora!" as her tail fluffed up and fur stood on end.

"What? You are," Adora replied breezily with an unapologetic smile.

Kesi buried her face in her hands as she groaned. She wasn't *actually* all that embarrassed—there was a *lot* that you didn't hide in cave culture and this was among them—it was just that playing up her reactions as if she *were* was fun. Adora *knew* this and thus played into it.

Judging by the amused expressions of everyone at the table sans Caspin (who was now complaining to Queen Lyra about them being gross), they were enjoying the show.

"Isn't Kesi the only person that you've ever kissed?" Kittrina pointed out as she reached a hand out to stop her girlfriend from falling out of her seat due to laughing so hard.

Adora was undeterred. "So? Kissing Kesi is still *fantastic.* Ten-out-of-ten experience, I'm keeping her all to myself."

"Good answer," Kittrina said with a nod.

Kesi, meanwhile, found herself purring as her tail wrapped around Adora's calf. "Awww, thank you! I feel the same," she said with a smile before kissing her *khai'tel* on the cheek.

Caspin threw their hands up in frustration. "ARGH! That's it! If people are going to keep being gross, I'm leaving!"

Everyone just laughed.

Adora and Kesi's Rooms

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Almost Thirteen Years After the Coup Attempt

The rest of the day passed in a bit of a blur. After breakfast, Kesi *finally* took Adora to the deep caves, showing her those parts of cave culture that they keep hidden since most of Halfmoon wouldn't accept them. Adora had been a little surprised by some of it but mostly just awed as she accepted absolutely everything.

While they were down there, their cave culture friends sans Clover threw Adora a party, one which everyone was allowed to join. It got a little wild—as parties thrown in the deep caves are wont to do—but Adora was laughing, smiling, and often pseudo-purring throughout all of it. It was during the party that Adora finally got her nipples pierced, Kesi holding her hand through it since it stung like a *bitch* at first (not that Adora reacted all that much since her pain tolerance was disturbingly high. The moonleaf also helped).

Throughout it all, Kesi never once left Adora's side and was often hanging from her *khai'tel's* arm. They had also made out a *lot* with things getting so passionate at one point that Kesi very nearly decided to take Adora then and there. She refrained, however, wanting their first time to happen in the privacy of their bedroom where she could have Adora all to herself.

It always warmed Kesi's heart to see how much Adora had embraced cave culture and how the people had embraced her in return. She knew that her *khai'tel* often felt somewhat inadequate due to not being a Magicat but no one who knew and loved her cared the least bit about it. While some people in Halfmoon might treat Adora a bit unnecessarily differently due to her race, down in the deep caves, Adora was no different from every other Magicat there.

They stayed there until well into the evening before eventually bidding their friends goodbye and returning to Halfmoon proper. Kesi took Adora to her favorite restaurant for a private and romantic dinner before then heading back to the castle. They met back up with the Royal Family et al for the second party of the day, this one a comparatively infinitely more subdued affair.

It wasn't much longer before they were wrapping everything up and bidding everyone a goodnight before finally, at long last, retiring to their rooms.

The instant that Kesi closed the door to their bedroom, Adora pinned her against it with her *mouth.* The kiss started off open mouthed and hungry, Kesi letting out a surprised moan that let Adora slide her tongue inside. Adora carefully ran her tongue over Kesi's fangs, drawing a moan from her that Kesi greedily drank down.

Adora pulled back from the kiss, catching Kesi's lower lip between her teeth and giving it a light tug earning her a whimper from her *khai'tel.* "Bed?" Adora asked in a rough voice that sent a shiver down Kesi's spine and made her fur stand on end even as her tail lashed.

"Bed," Kesi agreed before pushing Adora back towards it with a hungry kiss of her own. Kesi licked into Adora's mouth this time and she moaned at the taste of her *khai'tel* while Adora moaned due to the rough texture of her tongue that she loved so much.

Their hands weren't idle during all of this, roaming and squeezing as the bed loomed ever closer. One of the many wonderful things about cave culture clothing was that you weren't usually wearing much and thus it was the matter of mere moments before both of them were topless.

The backs of Adora's legs hit the bed and the two of them fell onto it, Kesi pinning her girl down and claiming her mouth as though it were *hers.* And, in a way, it *was.* Only Kesi got to kiss Adora like this, only Kesi got to *have* Adora like this.

And only Adora got to have Kesi like this, too.

One of Adora's hands moved lower down Kesi's abdomen until —

Kesi's Rooms

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Almost Two Years After Adora's Abduction

Kesi was roused from her sleep by a knock on her bedroom door. She scowled as she chased after the fragments of her dream that were already slipping from her mind. It had all felt so *real* and Adora was still here and she was *hers* and—

Another knock scattered Kesi's spiraling thoughts. She sniffed quietly and rubbed at her eyes with the back of her hand, trying

to will herself to not cry. Maybe if she was quiet, whoever it was would go away. Kesi didn't think she was in much of a state to handle people at that moment.

"Kesi? Are you awake?" she heard Catra ask from the other side of the door.

Kesi sighed. If there way anyone in all of Halfmoon who she shouldn't shut out, it was Catra. She loved Catra very much and Catra loved her in return. They were imprinted on each other in much the same way that they were imprinted on Adora. They had anchored each other this entire time and would no doubt keep doing so until they got Adora back.

But then there was that dream. In that dream, Adora had been Kesi's and Kesi's alone. There had been no Adora and Catra or Kesi and Catra, just Adora and Kesi. Was that a betrayal of Catra's love for her and her love for Catra? She recalled feeling remorseful that Adora would never be wholly hers back before everything went wrong. Did she still feel that way now?

It was all so confusing that it made Kesi's already exhausted mind that much more tired.

"Kesi, if you're awake, I'm coming in," Catra said as the door handle started to move.

Kesi sighed again. "Just one moment," she called out before somehow finding the strength to pull herself out of bed. She quickly threw on some underwear and Adora's jacket, making sure to zip it up. Sure, Catra was eighteen now and had seen Kesi naked on a number of occasions but she didn't feel like being that level of exposed right now.

Kesi buried her nose in the collar of Adora's jacket before taking a deep breath, letting the sweet honey scent of her first *khai'tel* soothe her somewhat before opening the door.

"Morning, Kesi," Catra greeted with a thin smile. She was dressed casually for the day in Adora's shirt with her mane done

up in a high ponytail but Kesi could see the signs of where she'd been crying.

"Morning, Catra," Kesi returned with a wan smile of her own. This was the one day of the year where Kesi's didn't say "good morning."

Catra leaned in, standing up on her toes to give Kesi a quick kiss. Kesi hummed into it for a moment, unable to purr.

"You wanna get ready to go?" Catra asked softly. They had a bit of a ritual on Adora's birthday when the pain of her loss was typically at its most acute. This year was promising to be particularly rough since she would have finally been able to start dating Adora properly had she been here.

She had never truly gotten to call her *khai'tel* her own. She hadn't gotten to hold her the way she truly wanted to, to kiss her, to show her all of the deep caves, to date her, to simply *be* with her *as* Kesi and Adora.

It wasn't fair, it wasn't fair, it wasn't *fair.* Why did things have to work out like this? Kesi had been willing to be patient! She had been willing to abide by stupid magic number theory and wait and now her first *khai'tel* was *gone.*

Kesi took a deep breath and squeezed her eyes shut to fend off the tears that threatened to spill over. When she blinked them open, it was to find Catra looking at her with concern in her eyes.

"Hey, we don't have to if you don't feel up to it. We could go later today or maybe even tomorrow," Catra offered.

Kesi shook her head. "No, I'll— Just give me a minute and I'll be ready."

Catra nodded and left Kesi to it, making her way into Kesi's sitting room.

Now more or less alone again, Kesi sighed once more before making her way to her closet. She knew that she was going to be wearing Adora's jacket with nothing else underneath today so she just grabbed a pair of loose-fitting pants that went together well enough with it. Now properly dressed, she quickly ran a comb through her hair until it was good enough before putting in her earrings—especially that one that she got from Adora: a small, white-gold stud—and calling it there. She didn't even bother with the indorium torc of her office since she had the day off.

When she left her room, she found Catra sitting in front of a box from Tethlan's bakery. In it were the berry-filled pastries that were her favorite and the apple cinnamon ones that were Adora's favorite. She managed to eat one of each while Catra ate one of the latter before heading out.

The Waxing Market

Lower Residential District

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Almost Two Years After Adora's Abduction

The Waxing Market was unusually subdued for this time of day. There were plenty of people about, to be sure, and business was still being carried out but it was all done with a solemn air.

This wasn't in the least bit surprising to Kesi and Catra as they made their way through the busy streets of the market. Today was a day of mourning, after all, and not just for the two of them. It had been decided that today would be used to mourn all of those in cave culture who were lost during the second coup attempt after Kesi and Catra had publicly mourned here a year ago.

There was now a monument in the Waxing Market, an obelisk located where a certain shop once stood. On it was engraved the names of every cave person who lost their life that day. Near the top was a picture of a smiling Adora and a plaque that read "May their lights forever guide us in the dark."

(While Adora's status was officially listed as "missing in action," she was still included in the monument out of respect, especially since Adora's exact location was top secret. Most people suspected that she was simply dead but her body hadn't been found much like with Aster all those years ago. As for why Adora's picture was at the top, there were multitudinous reasons but chief among them was the simply overwhelming number of people that knew and loved her.)

Kesi clasped her hands and bowed her head in prayer, squeezing her eyes shut tight to once again fight off the tears that threatened to fall. She prayed for those who were lost that they may find peace; for those that remained that they may find strength and happiness; and, most of all, she prayed for Adora that she might be as safe as possible and come back to them quickly.

As she prayed, Kesi buried her nose in the collar of Adora's jacket and leaned slightly against Catra. Coming here hurt more than she could rightfully say but she also couldn't *not* come no matter how much she wished to just wallow in misery in the relative comfort of her own bed. She prayed for Adora's safety every day but something about being in front of the monument like this made it feel like her prayers might actually be heard and answered.

Kesi knew that this was just wishful thinking on her part, that the Stars Above would hear her plea no matter where she was or when she prayed. However, the ritualistic nature of it brought her just the smallest iota of comfort and she'd take any comfort she could get, *especially* today.

Eventually, after the fifth or sixth plea for Adora's safety and swift return, Kesi lowered her hands as she brought her prayers to an end. She still kept her nose buried in the collar of Adora's jacket, however, taking deep, shuddering breaths as she willed herself not to cry. While there was nothing wrong or shameful about crying, this particular wound was too large, too personal for her to cry in public. Especially since, once she started, she wasn't sure when she'd stop.

At length, Catra spoke up. "Come on, Kesi," she said softly as she nudged her shoulder with her own. "Let's go someplace else."

Kesi finally raised her head to look at Catra who seemed to be fairing only the tiniest bit better than she was. "Where are we going?" Kesi asked as she started to follow her Princess.

"Someplace private where you can finally cry," Catra answered.

Kesi said no more.

Adora's Room

The High Temple

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Almost Two Years Since Adora's Abduction

Despite not having been used in nearly two years, Adora's room was still kept meticulously clean and exactly how she left it. It was usually cleaned by people who worked at the High Temple but sometimes Kesi or even Catra would come by and do some cleaning while they were there. While all of the cleaning meant that Adora's scent could no longer be found on the vast majority of surfaces and items in the room, Kesi *had* preserved her scent in her bed sheets, blanket, and pillow case.

The advantage of knowing that spell was the ability to cast it on anything you wanted.

Adora's room was a sort of safe haven for Kesi and Catra. It was a place they could go and hide if the day just became a little too much for them to handle. They could cuddle up together under Adora's blanket and just decompress, letting their emotions wash through them in the most comforting place in all of Halfmoon for them.

As Kesi entered Adora's room, she paused as she noticed that Catra wasn't following her in. She turned around to face her Princess and saw that she still had a hand on the doorknob.

"Aren't you coming in?" Kesi asked, her brow scrunched up in confusion.

A sad smile graced Catra's face as she slowly shook her head. "No, this is for you. You deserve to be able to mourn her in private. I'll be in the main hall if you need me."

"But, Catra, she was your *khai'tel,* too," Kesi objected.

"Yeah, but I got to have Adora as my girlfriend for two years even if we tried to hide it. You, meanwhile, never even got to *kiss* her. If Adora were still here, I would have been *more* than happy to let you have her all to yourself pretty much all day today," Catra rebutted.

The remnants of the dream came fluttering back to Kesi's mind making her blush slightly. She still didn't truly have an answer to her question from that morning but maybe, just maybe, she was allowed to be a little selfish at least in her dreams from time to time.

Kesi searched Catra's face for a moment and, after only finding sorrow, pain, and *love* there, walked over to her and pulled her into a firm hug.

“Thank you, Catra,” she whispered into Catra’s mane. She still couldn’t purr but she wanted to.

Catra stood on her tiptoes to kiss Kesi on the cheek before saying, “You’re welcome, Kesi. I’ll be in the main hall if you need me.”

Catra stepped out of the embrace and offered Kesi one last thin smile before closing the door.

Now alone once more, Kesi sighed before taking out her earrings, taking off her clothes, and carefully hanging them up in Adora’s closet. She then crawled onto Adora’s bed and slipped underneath the blankets before just laying there on her back, staring up at the ceiling.

Kesi didn’t know how long she laid there, her mind blissfully blank as she let Adora’s scent soak into her fur and skin. All she knew was that time continued to pass without her and that Adora’s bed felt lifeless despite the presence of her scent.

Memories of her time with Adora came back to her one by one. She remembered their first meeting, their first sleepover, the day that Adora found out that Kesi was aeonic (and learned what that word meant), their first time seeing a movie together. She remembered the day that she moved in, all of the times that Adora had comforted her after she had an argument with her parents, the first time Adora had proudly shown her the map she was making (the map that was still safely tucked away in her desk drawer).

Kesi remembered all of that and so, *so* much more. As she did, she felt her tears well up again but didn’t fight them this time, letting them flow freely as a heartbroken sob was torn from her chest.

Kesi had treasured their time together but she hadn’t treasured it *enough.* She should have spent more time with her, should have talked to her about more things, should have shared

more of herself with her, should have damned the rules and kissed Adora when she was sixteen.

She should have had more *time* with Adora. She should have had days, weeks, months, *years* more with her. She should have had Adora by her side. Today should have been one of the best days of her life rather than one of the worst.

Kesi cried out her sorrow, mewled out her grief, and screamed out her pain.

It wasn't fair, it wasn't fair, it wasn't *fair.* Her first *khai'tel,* a large part of her *soul,* had been *taken* from her just after she had found her. The past two years of joy had been *taken* from her. Her happy life in Halfmoon had been *taken* from her.

She hadn't thought that she could have hated anything more than the Cult of the Whispered Promise but she now hated the Horde just as much, if not *more.*

As Kesi cried herself to sleep, she had just one thought with which to comfort herself:

She *would* get Adora back one day and, once she did, she would never let anything or anyone take her from her ever again. She'd make sure of it.

Chapter End Notes

Some lines in the back half of this chapter were painful to write.

Yes, Kittrina dating Clover is actually happening. They date for a couple months and have a great time but mutually agree that there isn't anything romantic there.

In case you're curious, had Adora not been abducted, her eighteenth birthday would have gone almost exactly as it did in Kesi's dream. There would have been a *bit* more Catra and there *probably* wouldn't be any sex but that's about it.

As a fun fact, this originally started off *completely* differently until I had the idea to start it with that dream sequence.

If you're disappointed by where the dream ended, don't worry! Just give it a couple minutes and the extended edition will be up if it isn't already!

Chapter 7: Baptism by Fire

Chapter Summary

> Halfmoon's greatest fear has been made manifest and it's up to Catra and crew to save the day with some help from a certain pirate.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra's Office

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Years After Adora's Abduction

Catra was exhausted, anxious, and more than a little terrified but she didn't let anything show. She maintained the carefully curated mask of a royal even when all that she wanted to do at that moment was grab Kesi and hide somewhere for a few hours.

Halfmoon's worst nightmare had come to fruition: an epidemic. It was a vicious disease that they were calling "Cave Fever." It struck a person hard and fast, crippling them with a deliriously high fever and had a frighteningly high mortality rate if it went untreated.

Thankfully, Cave Fever *could* be treated and it wasn't even terribly hard to do so—simple antibiotics and restorative potions could reduce the mortality rate to almost zero. However, Halfmoon's supplies of those were being burned through at a truly alarming rate.

They needed more supplies and they needed them *fast* but it was the second part that was currently a problem. They had a *perfect* avenue to get supplies into Halfmoon now that what was unofficially called the Princess' Path was open; it wouldn't take any time at all to get them from the hidden cove (Catra's Cove) that it was connected to. However, getting the supplies and then getting them to said cove was currently going to take *far* more time than they had.

As if all of *that* weren't enough, Catra was now the acting sovereign. Lyra and Cyrus both had been hit with Cave Fever at around the same time and were currently laid up in the infirmary. The only good news as far as her family was concerned was that Caspin had yet to catch it and, if Catra had her way, never *would* seeing as how it hit the young and the elderly the hardest. As it was, Caspin was quarantined in their rooms with Clover (who had already gotten and then recovered from it—anyone who'd recovered from it had an immunity and was no longer a carrier).

(Normally, Kittrina would have been the one with Caspin but she was *also* currently in the infirmary.)

As for Catra herself, she seemed to be immune to it due to the large pool of celestial magic left in her by Adora when she had saved her life roughly four years ago. Those with sufficient amounts of celestial magic were highly resistant, if not outright immune, to diseases (which also meant that Kesi was immune). That being said, she was still keeping her distance from Caspin as a safety precaution just in case she was wrong. Her situation was a rather unique one, after all.

But none of that helped her current situation. She wasn't ready to be Queen yet but already there were whispers that she might be sooner rather than later. That was a possibility that she *refused* to entertain, however. Her parents *would* survive this.

Even with that firm belief, Catra knew that there was work that needed to be done and that she was currently the only one capable of doing it no matter how ill prepared she felt. As such,

she had called a meeting with all of the remaining advisors—both hers and her mother's—and had tried to hash out a plan of action.

Ideally, they would have been reaching out to the surface nations for aid but that simply wasn't possible. While she had gotten the approval of the Royal Council to begin forging diplomatic relationships with the surface nations and the Princess' Path had been finished for around a year, there was still work to be done. In order to establish the diplomatic relations that they'd need, they would need to prove that Halfmoon existed as a nation.

Proving the existence of Halfmoon would actually be super easy, barely an inconvenience—it was something that Catra had accounted for when making her proposal. Elemental Princesses could recognize each other: they could feel if someone else was bonded to a RuneStone. As such, all they'd have to do is have Catra or Lyra be present when negotiating with an Elemental Princess and, just like that, their existence would be all but undeniable. *Especially* with the other plan that Catra had in the works.

But the problem there was that Catra or Lyra would have to be present. Under better circumstances, Catra would currently be preparing to willingly depart Halfmoon for the first time while Halfmoon's agents got in contact with Captain Sea Hawk. However, with both Lyra and Cyrus incapacitated, Catra was the one wearing the Crown and thus she was stuck in Halfmoon until either the epidemic ended or her parents recovered. If she were to leave, the Crown would fall to Caspin and, as precocious as they were, he was *not* ready for this level of responsibility.

And so Catra was left trying to find alternate solutions. That process wasn't going well, however, until an unexpected voice spoke up.

[[Send me,]] Rogelio said from where he leaned against a wall. [[I can get to Etheria in three days and get to Bright Moon and Seaworthy in two. I know the Horde tunnels, patrol routes,

and schedules! I *will* find Captain Sea Hawk and and we will buy or take what we need and I will bring him to the Cove.]]

(Catra was *infinitely* grateful for the fact that she could pick up new languages *very* quickly; after learning the arcane language, nearly every other language was simplicity itself.)

Once Rogelio had gotten acclimated to living in Halfmoon, Catra had been quick to offer him a position as her advisor on matters concerning the Horde; a position that he had accepted immediately. Having someone as knowledgeable of the Horde as Rogelio had been a gift from the Stars Above.

"Your Highness, I must object," one of Lyra's advisors said. "While Rogelio has done us a great service, he still can't be trusted to leave Halfmoon. For all we know, he'll sell us out to the Horde!"

Rogelio hissed at that and Catra had half a mind to join him. Instead, she kept her mask firmly in place as she said, "We don't really have a choice in the matter. The longer we delay, the more of our people die. While not everyone may trust him as I do, you *must* see that this is a risk we must take."

"Send me with him," Elara said before the advisor could reply. "I used to be a scout and a damn good one. Between Rogelio and me, it'll take us four days to reach Etheria and another three to reach Seaworthy. We'll need a number of things from Percival but we'll be able to leave today."

Catra looked at Rogelio who nodded. Catra nodded in return. "Go. Perci, get them whatever they need. Don't worry about any of the usual procedures, I'm exercising royal prerogative.

"Find our agent or Captain Sea Hawk—whoever you can get to first. You'll have a list of things we need and as much money as you can carry. If Captain Sea Hawk won't do it, find someone who will."

As Catra watched Rogelio, Elara, and Percival leave, she had to bite back a sigh. It didn't feel like she was doing enough but this was all that she *could* do. She just prayed that it'd be enough.

Catra's Cove

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Years After Adora's Abduction

Daylight was still foreign to Catra despite having been to the secret cove on a number of occasions. Her memories of when she had been abducted were fuzzy at best and consisted mostly of screams, explosions, and Adora. As such, her first time at the Cove had practically been her first time under the light of the daymoons.

(According to Cyrus, the sky of the Fright Zone had mainly been filled with smog, smog, and more smog so she wasn't actually missing much.)

The trading post/settlement that was to be the final stage of their preparations before they began forging diplomatic relations had been coming along nicely until the epidemic hit. The commercial docks had been built and there were numerous buildings in various states of completion with the only one finished being what would be the main administration office. The construction process had been going so smoothly that they had actually been *ahead* of schedule but now they were quite a ways behind.

It had taken Rogelio and Elara sixteen days to procure everything they needed and then get back. During that time, Catra's parents had recovered enough to resume their duties meaning that Catra no longer bore the Crown (a fact that she was endlessly grateful for. While she had done a truly fantastic job

under the circumstances, she wasn't *nearly* ready yet). Kittrina had also recovered enough to resume her duties much to Caspin's delight (they loved Clover but his bond with his "Auntie Kittrina" was special). This freed Clover up to come with Catra to act as extra muscle and security.

Also during that time, it was determined by Healer Lenio that Catra was not only immune to Cave Fever, she also wasn't a carrier of it. Naturally, the instant that she discovered this, she had practically bolted to Caspin's rooms to smother her little sibling with affection. She then spent as much time with them as she could afterward, wanting to make up for lost time.

Unfortunately, what gave Catra her immunity wasn't replicable. While Kesi also had a fair deal of celestial magic, hers was but a fraction of what Adora could use. While she *might* be able to replicate the process, it would likely leave her unconscious for a number of days which Catra would *not* allow. Even if Kesi *wasn't* needed to help keep things running, Catra wouldn't have allowed it on principle. Of course, that was assuming that the imprint didn't factor into it in any way. If it *did* then it was truly irreplicable.

But none of that mattered anymore. Captain Sea Hawk had shown up (in a rather dramatic fashion) with a stolen ship, stolen cargo, and a truly harrowing tale.

(Everything had *technically* been paid for, from a certain point of view, when Captain Sea Hawk threw *more* than enough precious gems onto one of Bright Moon's ships that had been chasing them but that currently wasn't Catra's concern. She'd issue a formal apology whenever she made her way to Bright Moon. Maybe.)

While Captain Sea Hawk was well acquainted with a number of Magicats who worked at Catra's Cove (including Ferris who was in charge of the whole thing), he had yet to meet Catra herself. So, Elara called him over.

"Greetings, Captain Sea Hawk. I am Princess Catra Dr'iluth of Halfmoon. On behalf of my people, I would like to thank you for your service," Catra greeted with a polite bow.

Captain Sea Hawk gently set the small box that he was carrying—the contents of which none but the Captain knew—down before bowing deeply in return. He took one of Catra's hands in his own and kissed the back of it, much to her confusion.

"Think nothing of it, Your Highness!" Sea Hawk said as he straightened and let go of Catra's hand. "When I heard that my most consistent and trustworthy employer was in dire straits, it was only natural for me to leap into action!"

Catra felt Melog probe at her consciousness and, through them, peered into Captain Sea Hawk's mind. She saw his excitement, his burning curiosity as to who had been richly paying him to deliver necessities and tea (her mother would argue that tea *was* a necessity) through dangerous waters.

What's more, she saw that he was hoping the leverage this situation to get those answers and had even come prepared. That mysterious box of his was filled to the brim with rare and expensive teas from all across Etheria. He had gambled that whoever was the one ordering the tea was someone of importance and it was a gamble that was very much going to pay off.

Her mother may very well *kill* to get her hands on that box of teas.

Further still, Captain Sea Hawk was hoping to further utilize this situation to start working directly for Halfmoon rather than through their agents (agents that he didn't trust). By cutting out the middleman, he could make deliveries more often and bring more with him which meant more profit on his end.

Captain Sea Hawk was *exactly* the kind of man that Catra needed.

Catra had a plan beyond saving Halfmoon and it was one that she had told very few people (her mother being one of them since having her support would make it a *lot* easier). She needed Captain Sea Hawk in order to hopefully easily gain an audience with Princess Mermista of Salineas and showing him Halfmoon was the easiest way to get him to agree. Given what Melog had shown her, her plan was all but a guaranteed success.

Catra hadn't shared this plan with the Royal Council but she didn't care. They had already agreed to the general idea of opening Halfmoon up to diplomatic relations and the pieces just so happened to align to make this the most expedient method to get that process well and truly started.

"Even so, you have just saved a *lot* of lives, Captain. In light of your service, I would like to extend an invitation to Halfmoon to meet with my mother, Queen Lyra. I feel it only proper to let you see the home of those you're saving," Catra said diplomatically.

Despite being a very perky person, Captain Sea Hawk surprised Catra when he somehow managed to perk up even more at this. "I would be most honored, Your Highness! I do so hope that Her Majesty enjoys this gift I procured for her." He bent down to collect his little box.

Catra nodded with a smile that highlighted her cat features as she said, "I'm positive that she'll *love* all of the teas you've gotten her." She allowed herself a moment to enjoy Captain Sea Hawk's thoroughly flummoxed expression before saying loudly, "Alright, everyone! Let's get everything loaded up quickly! The longer we take, the more lives we lose!"

It didn't take much longer after that to get the last of the cargo loaded. Once it was ready, Catra was faced with the immutable fact that it would take them about half a day to get the supplies from the Cove to Halfmoon and that was *with* all of the preparations they had undergone.

The Princess' Path was a winding, twisting, confounding series of maze-like tunnels. Many paths were simply dead ends and many more were laced with traps of both the magical and mundane variety. It was a system designed to protect Halfmoon from a theoretical sea invasion as the only way to get through the tunnels was if you already knew the route (which Catra did—she had even piloted a train from the Cove back to Halfmoon once when her mother had wanted to visit).

Privately, Catra thought that all of it was a bit overkill. Even if they *were* to be invaded via the sea (something that'd no doubt be significantly harder to do once Catra managed to secure a mutual defense pact with Salineas), they could have very easily just collapsed the tunnels with the invaders inside. However, the Royal Council had been quite insistent on that matter and Catra simply hadn't been able to secure the votes that she had needed.

Another thing that had been delayed by the Royal Council was the number of lines that the Path was designed for. Catra had wanted it to be capable of running at least two concurrently but they had insisted that they finish construction on the settlement/trading post first. Once Catra was away, hopefully forming diplomatic relations with Salineas, *then* they'd expand the Path.

Because of all of that, they were forced to run ten trains of twelve carts on a single line in order to get all of the supplies to Halfmoon. Worse yet, the trains and Path both were designed for smaller, more stable cargo.

Frankly speaking, if they managed to pull this off, it'd be a borderline miracle and it just might be enough to get Catra to convert to the Celestial Promise.

Once all of the cargo was in place, Catra set about stationing her people across the trains. Captain Sea Hawk, Ferrus, and Rogelio would be in the first train; Elara in the fifth train; and Catra and Clover in the last train.

Catra's reasoning was this: Ferrus in front so that he could see and handle any potential problems with the Path with Rogelio acting as protection. Captain Sea Hawk was with them because he *needed* to reach Halfmoon because they *needed* that relatively easy in with Princess Mermista. Even if things somehow went catastrophically wrong, Captain Sea Hawk could always take Lyra to meet with her.

Elara was in the middle of the convoy in order to act as a messenger between the trains in case something went wrong with the comms.

That left Catra and Clover in the final train which was an open-air cart with two sorcerers and a number of soldiers. Catra was to seal off the entrance and handle anything in front of them. As for Clover, she would serve as Catra's bodyguard—if she was good enough to teach Caspin martial arts, she was good enough to help keep the Crown Princess alive.

"Princess, if I might have a moment?" Clover requested as they finished loading the last of the cargo. Catra was *immediately* on edge. Clover was a fairly laid-back person and usually just referred to Catra by name. The fact that she was calling her by her title could only mean that, whatever it was that she wanted, it was deathly serious.

As such, Catra acquiesced immediately and led Clover a little ways away so that they wouldn't be overheard if they spoke quietly. "What is it?"

Clover glanced over to the last train and said, "There are more soldiers than there should be and some of them are wearing ill-fitting uniforms."

Catra's eyes went wide for a moment before she slipped on the mask of a royal to stop any further outward reaction. "The Horde?"

Clover grimaced and nodded. "Most likely."

"But how?"

Clover shrugged minutely. "Your guess is as good as mine."

While they were talking, Catra sent a request to Melog to peer into the minds of the soldiers. From what Melog could gather, they were angry, tense, and violent; clearly waiting for something.

Catra sighed. She was suddenly *really* glad that she talked Kesi out of coming with. "I'm honestly impressed that they managed to throw this together so quickly. Well, Clover, I hope you're ready for a fight."

Clover gave Catra a wry smile and replied, "Catra, I'm *always* ready for a fight."

"You better not be teaching Caspin any bad habits," Catra shot back.

"I'm only teaching them the *best* habits," Clover returned with an innocent smile.

Catra wasn't buying it. "Right. Come on, let's get this over with."

The duo returned to the trains and Catra gave a quick speech about what was on the line and that they wouldn't be running through the dark today before lighting the Princess' Path up with the one spell her mother was allowing her to cast.

(Originally, Catra had been a little put out that she wouldn't be allowed to cast the navigation or stabilization spells but now she was glad for it since it freed her up for the upcoming fight.)

With that taken care of, Catra and Clover climbed aboard their train cart, Catra taking the time to close and seal the door as the spells to move and stabilize the trains were cast. All that was left to do was to take a seat on the bench and wait as the train carried them back to Halfmoon and to the fight.

The Princess' Path

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Years After Adora's Abduction

Clover kept her breathing calm and even as she sat next to Catra even as she felt her nerves start to come to life at the promise of a good fight. She had always been a bit of a scrapper and had been a bit violent in her youth. Her parents had enrolled her in a martial arts class to help give her an outlet for those more violent tendencies and to teach her discipline.

While those classes had *more* than worked (even if it had taken her some time to find a fighting style that felt right to her), her desire for a good fight never went away. If anything, that desire had simply grown as her innate skill had let her outpace her peers and even some of her elders. Nowadays, while she was *far* from the best at martial arts, her unorthodox fighting style meant that people who were, strictly speaking, more skilled than her often couldn't figure out how to *handle* her before they went down.

And then Adora had entered Clover's life and it was easily the best thing to have ever happened to her. Sure, Clover could easily kick Adora's ass whenever they fought hand-to-hand (although, it became a bit harder each time due to Adora's own innate talent) but whenever they sparred with Adora using her *kiari? That* was when Clover's blood came to life. Adora quickly became her fairly regular sparring partner and a damn good friend.

Then the second coup attempt had occurred and Clover had found her calling. As horrible as that day had been, Clover had never felt more alive. Fighting off the insurrectionists while saving lives had given her a thrill like no other.

She had never had any interest in joining the military and still very much didn't but she knew that she had to be ready for the next time the traitors made a move. She hadn't been kidding when she had told Catra that she was always ready for a fight.

And now here she was, sharing a train car with her Princess and a gaggle of traitors that she was mere minutes away from fighting.

The first part of the Princess' Path was too confined for any fighting so that just left them all sitting there counting down the moments. It wouldn't be long until the confined tunnel opened up to a more cavernous section—a long bridge over a massive lake that connected to the Dark Lake. It was there where the fighting would begin.

"So, fellas," Clover began as the cavern loomed ever closer. She interlaced her fingers and stretched her arms with a slight groan before continuing, "Any of you want to quit now? You'll get a cushy stay in one of Halfmoon's prisons instead of a one-way trip to whatever afterlife awaits you."

Several of the "soldiers" had been "subtlety" reaching for their weapons. Clover was already calculating the fastest way to dismantle all of them while Catra was idly drumming her fingers along her staff. Melog sat by Catra's feat, their gaze never once leaving any of the traitors.

"How'd you know?" one of the traitors asked as they drew a pair of curved, serrated daggers.

"You guys aren't as subtle as you think you are," Catra replied as she twirled her staff into a ready position.

With that, they crossed into the cavern and the fight began.

Clover made the first move by lashing out with a lightning-fast backhand into the face of the nearest traitor. There was a satisfying *crunch* as their nose broke while their head snapped

back, leaving their throat open for the claws on Clover's other hand.

Clover then charged at the one with the twin knives and brushed their vertical swing aside before grabbing their wrists. A twirling flip took her out of the way of another traitor trying to slash at her with a shortsword and behind the one she had grabbed the arms of. As she had been midair, her eyes had gone wide as she saw a swarm of Fishfolk with blasters taking aim from the lake.

"Catra! Shield!" Clover called out as she planted one foot against the traitor's back and pulled with all her might, smirking as the traitor screamed as their shoulders were dislocated.

Meanwhile, Catra had struck the traitor nearest her with preternatural speed, the thrust of her staff accelerated by a burst of magical energy. The tip of her staff outright shattered the breastplate of the traitor she had hit before launching them off of the train and into the water fifty feet below.

At Clover's call, Catra growled and quickly constructed a plane of force around the train, the barrier lighting up as blasterfire struck against it. She then leaped onto the enlarged Melog's back just in time for them to pounce at another traitor. While Melog was mid-pounce, Catra jumped off of their back and flipped through the air, her free hand out as dozens of red-gold sparks materialized in it like glistening jewels.

At the zenith of her flip while she was upside down, Catra thrust her hand out with a roar, the sparks shooting from her palm to arc out and then down around the train. They zipped into the water before exploding, sending up geysers of water ten feet tall at their highest. The resulting sequential shock waves tore through the Fishfolk like wet tissue paper.

While Catra was dealing with the Fishfolk, Clover threw the now helpless traitor whose arms she had dislocated off of the train. She smoothly transitioned from her shoulder throw into a

stabbed windmills breakdance spin, her lower leg tripping up a couple of traitors while the claws on the foot of her upper leg caught them in the face as they fell.

A spinning kip-up got Clover back on her feet as Melog finished off the traitors that she had downed. Catra landed just as she got up and the two stood shoulder-to-shoulder as they stared down the remaining six traitors.

"How are you holding up, Catra?" Clover asked as they entered into a brief standoff, neither group willing to make the next move quite yet despite the numerical advantage the traitors had.

"I could do this all day," Catra replied breezily. "You?"

Before Clover could respond, their comms sprung to life. *"What's going on back there?"* they heard Elara ask. *"Your Highness, Clover, respond!"*

No reply would be forthcoming as the traitors used what they thought would be a lapse in their attention to charge. Catra and Clover both were *far* too disciplined for that to be true, however, as they met the charge head-on.

Clover did a low sweep to grab one of the daggers that one traitor had dropped with her foot before transitioning into a rising kick to ram the knife into the underside of one traitor's jaw, dropping them instantly. Catra, meanwhile, casually parried the sword swing of another with her staff before crossing her off-hand across her chest to hold her palm out toward them. They had half an instant to see the flash of fire behind Catra's eyes before a focused explosion rang out, sending them flying into two more.

Catra twirled her staff before hurling it like a javelin into the chest of yet another, staggering them. Clover was on them in an instant, grabbing the staff out of the air and slamming it into the top of their head to knock them to the ground. As Clover tossed Catra's staff back to her, Melog sprang forward, their fangs tearing into the back of the traitor's neck.

The comms sprung to life again. *[[Elara, go to them and—Captain! Get back here!]]* they heard Rogelio say.

Clover thought that Sea Hawk was insane for trying to cross the trains without the alacrity of a Magicat. If he managed to pull it off, however, she'd buy him a drink. Hell, she might even take him out on a date. He was cute enough.

There were four more traitors left and Clover felt her blood sing and a feral smile spread across her face as she realized that she finally had the room needed to actually *move.* Up until now, she had to keep her movements relatively constrained to account for the number of combatants, allies, and limited space but now?

Now, Clover could show these fools just why she was chosen to train the Princeps in martial arts.

Clover's stance changed. She started stepping, almost swaying, side-to-side to an unheard beat as her posture loosened up to become more fluid. The remaining traitors had only the briefest of moments to take in this change before she *moved.*

Clover was everywhere, her movements fast and fluid as she almost literally danced around the traitors. She struck out with lightning-fast strikes from her palms, elbows, and knees. Her claws cut deadly arcs through the air as she tore at any bit of exposed flesh that she could reach.

While Clover couldn't do much but hurt herself if she attacked their armor, she wasn't the only one in this fight. She delivered a thrust kick into the small of the back of one to send them tumbling to Melog who proceeded to tear them to shreds. To another, she snapped their arm at the elbow before spinning them around and hurling them at Catra who lashed out with a vicious series of blindingly fast swings of her staff that left them crumpling to the floor like a puppet with its strings cut.

In the matter of mere minutes, the last of the traitors was dealt with when Catra caught them in the side with her staff to

send them tumbling out of the train and into the lake below.

Just as they were starting to wind down, Clover's eyes went wide as she looked past Catra and saw the sorcerer that had been casting the stabilization spell suddenly pull out a cudgel. Clover cried out a warning but they were helpless to stop the sorcerer from bashing it into the back of the driver's head, causing it to then smash into the steering wheel.

The train rocked dangerously as the wheel was turned. Melog dodged out of the way of what looked like a blast of fire but Clover was forced to abandon her charge as she saw Catra start to fall off the train. She dived for her Princess and managed to grab her arm as Melog rushed behind her to stabilize her.

With the Crown Princess no longer in imminent peril, Clover looked back over to the sorcerer to see that all three of them were now in imminent peril as they prepared a spell.

There was nothing Clover could do here. She knew just enough about spellcasting to know that their spell—some sort of wind spell—was almost complete; she wouldn't be able to reach them in time. Catra was still too off-balance to do anything about it and Melog was in an even worse position than Clover was.

Clover was just starting to accept that there were worse ways to die when a shot rang out at roughly the same time that a streak of yellow light punched through their head right between their eyes. The sorcerer's corpse hung there for one moment, two, three, before finally crumpling to the ground and off of the train.

Clover looked up the train and saw none other than Captain Sea Hawk practically dancing his way toward them with Elara at his side and a single-shot pistol in his hand. He was even smiling and laughing.

Privately, Clover was contemplating giving the Captain a more… *intimate* introduction to cave culture.

Before Clover could start celebrating *too* much, she suddenly remembered the little problem of the train that they were on suddenly having no driver and no one to stabilize it. She wasn't the only one to remember that, though, as Catra shot forward and grabbed the wheel even as she began chanting at a frankly astonishing rate. The light spell that she was maintaining flickered a few times but eventually steadied back out although not quite as bright as it was before.

If Clover understood everything right, her Princess was now maintaining three spells simultaneously. Even for an Elemental Princess and a Magicat that could draw upon the ley lines, that was no mean feat and she'd have to maintain it all for *hours.*

With nothing left to do, Clover brought up her wrist comm and called in. "This is Clover. We had some party crashers including one of the sorcerers but they've all been dealt with. Princess Catra is currently maintaining the spells needed to keep our train moving."

She heard Rogelio mutter something that she was pretty sure was a curse before saying, *[[Don't touch any of the food or drink that you didn't bring with you personally. It can't be trusted.]]*

Clover swore under her breath; she hadn't thought about that. This was going to be a *very* thirsty trip.

"Wait, she's maintaining all three spells by herself?" Elara said. She had stopped moving but Sea Hawk was almost to them.

"I like it just about as much as you do but it's not like we have any spare sorcerers. We're just going to have to trust the Princess," Clover replied.

"We should stop at the closest waypoint and get some more help. One person maintaining three spells like that can't *be good for them,"* Elara suggested.

"I wouldn't recommend it," Sea Hawk said as he jumped into the train, landing next to Clover. "If those people are even half as

clever as they think they are, they'll have ambushes set up on any footpaths you might have."

[[The Captain's right,]] Rogelio agreed. *[[So is Clover.]]*

Elara sighed down the line. *"Alright, but I want updates every half hour."*

"Understood," Clover replied before shutting off her line. She then sighed wearily as she unceremoniously plopped down onto the nearest bench, her arms stretched out across the back of it and her head leaned back. She could still make Catra out in her peripheral vision.

"That was a hell of a shot, Captain," Clover praised Sea Hawk as he sat down next to her.

Sea Hawk flashed Clover a winsome smile. "Why, thank you! It wasn't the most difficult shot I've ever made—far from it—but it presented some interesting challenges."

Clover barked out a laugh. "If you shoot even half as good as you talk, Captain, you just might be one of the greatest marksmen out there."

Sea Hawk grinned at her. "I'm afraid I'm not quite *that* good. Out of all of my many talents, my skill with my tongue is perhaps my greatest."

Clover raised a brow as she lifted her head to properly look at Sea Hawk. *"Really* now? Well, *that's* interesting. I've met a number of people with talented tongues. Perhaps we'll have to see how you measure up."

Sea Hawk laughed heartily. "Perhaps we shall! I don't think we've been properly introduced. I am Captain Sea Hawk, pirate and adventurer extraordinaire!"

Clover chuckled in return as she shook Sea Hawk's hand. "I'm Clover. I teach Princeps Caspin martial arts and occasionally play

bodyguard to him and Catra."

"I saw a bit of your fighting on the way here. I must say, I've never seen anything quite like that before!"

Clover smirked at him, showing off one of her fangs. "That's because my fighting style is a cave culture specialty. Doesn't really have a name."

"Cave culture, eh? Please, tell me about it."

And so the two chatted amicably about this and that, Clover teaching Sea Hawk about Halfmoon while Sea Hawk regaled her with stories of the surface. Clover kept a close eye on Catra during the whole thing and was growing more concerned by the minute.

Catra's arms and legs were starting to tremble and her eyes would occasionally become unfocused. Despite all of that, her voice remained steady and the spells never wavered.

Sea Hawk had evidently noticed Catra's state as well as he started directing his stories less at Clover and more at her. Clover picked up on what he was doing and shifted her stories to be more about things that Catra likely wouldn't know about including stories about her training Caspin.

After an interminable length of time, Sea Hawk cut his story short as he noticed something rather troubling. "Am I just seeing things or is your princess literally smoking?"

Indeed, steam rose from Catra's body in numerous places even as her trembling got worse.

Clover grimaced. "Catra is the Elemental Princess of Fire, bound to the Spirit Ember. I'm no sorceress but, if I had to guess, she's burning up due to channeling its power for so long and what we're seeing is the sweat evaporating off of her."

Sea Hawk frowned as he looked between Catra and the trains ahead of them. "How much longer until we reach Halfmoon?"

Clover looked at the various landmarks as she hummed in thought. “About an hour? Maybe more.”

“Well, this simply won’t do,” Sea Hawk said with a shake of his head. “While I might not know the best day to cool you down due to your fur, I *can* make your life a tad easier.”

Sea Hawk got up from where he had been sitting and went about gathering materials to make a knee-high stack. He then whipped off his jacket before carefully folding it and placing it on top.

“While not the most comfortable chair,” Sea Hawk began, “it should serve you well enough for the rest of the trip.” He then positioned the makeshift stool behind Catra and said, “On ‘three,’ I'm going to push this into you. All you need to do is sit back. Okay? One… two… three!”

Catra’s entire body sagged with relief as Sea Hawk skillfully positioned the makeshift stool underneath her. Once he was certain that she was about as comfortable as she could be, Sea Hawk returned to seat.

“Do you know what I think we need to help us pass the time? A shanty!” he said cheerfully. He then started to sing in a strong and clear voice after a slight delay with a very particular cadence.

It took Clover a moment to realize that Sea Hawk's shanty was following the rhythm of Catra's chanting. After she realized that, she pitched in by drumming against her seat and legs.

“Don't worry, Catra,” Clover said after a moment. “Healer Lenio will be waiting to scream at you for pushing yourself too hard once we get there. As a bonus, Kesi will be there to scream at you, too.”

Clover snickered as Catra's ears went back and her eyes widened in fear. Sea Hawk paused his shanty just long enough to ask, “Who's Kesi?”

Catra sent Clover a glare that was somehow also pleading but Clover simply returned a smile that was all fangs. There would be no mercy for her Princess.

"Kesi is many things, my dear Captain," Clover began. "She's Catra's Seneschal; she's an Adherent of the Celestial Promise; she's basically the spiritual leader for all of cave culture; she's an icon among cave people for several reasons; and, most importantly, she's *basically* one of Catra's girlfriends."

Catra had squeezed her eyes shut, her ears still pinned back and her tail lashing furiously. She knew Clover well enough to know what was to come.

At Sea Hawk's raised brow, Clover continued, "Let me tell you about a little thing called 'imprinting' and then tell you about how *disgustingly* in love those two are."

And so the rest of the trip passed as such with Catra's steady chanting, Sea Hawk's cheerful singing, and Clover's continued drumming as she tried her level best to make Catra combust from embarrassment.

At long last, they exited the tunnels and Catra's chanting changed as the trains started to slow down, coming to a stop in the largest cavern before the last tunnel to Halfmoon proper.

The platform was crowded with people: workers, soldiers, medical personnel (including Healer Lenio who was waiting on the platform where their train would stop), and Kesi who was staring at their train with wide eyes, her ears pinned back and her tail in her hand.

Clover let out a breath of relief as she saw who she recognized as the Royal Sorcerer start casting to take over the spell from Catra.

As the train finally slid to a stop, Catra dropped her spells and started panting for breath. Clover carefully reached out to place a steadying hand on Catra's arm, suppressing a wince at just how

hot Catra's skin felt. She carefully guided Catra off of her makeshift stool as Healer Lenio dropped into the train car.

Both of their efforts were proven futile as Kesi all but *flew* off the platform to scoop Catra up in her arms, her entire body glowing with celestial magic.

"Catra! Are you okay⁉ Are you hurt anywhere⁉" Kesi asked frantically as she looked her girlfriend over.

Catra gave Kesi a somewhat delirious smile. "Hey, Kesi. I'm fine. Have I ever told you just how soft you are?"

And, with that, the Crown Princess of Halfmoon promptly passed out in her girlfriend's arms.

Chapter End Notes

A note about Catra's feat of thaumaturgy: she knew the spells, knew the path, had access to a RuneStone, *and* had access to ley lines. Ariel had/knew exactly none of that. This is why Catra could maintain three spells for the same length of time that Ariel only maintained two. Ariel is a *much* better sorceress than Catra will ever be.

A note on Clover's fighting style: it's inspired somewhat by capoeira. Mind, I don't actually *know* capoeira so it's merely inspired by it.

As for whether or not Sea Hawk would go on to show Clover his talented tongue, we shall leave that as an exercise for you, our dear readers.

Chapter 8: The Faces of Fear

Chapter Summary

Everyone has their own fears but it's important to remember that you don't have to face them alone.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Castle Gates

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Years After Adora's Abduction

Catra was beyond excited. She was so excited that she honestly thought that she might *explode* if not given a means of releasing all of her energy. Thankfully, such a means would be arriving soon.

What had gotten Catra to such dangerous levels of excitement was one very simple fact: Adora was coming home. After two painfully long years, they had *finally* managed to get Adora out of the Horde and it would now be the matter of mere minutes until she was back in the arms of her loved ones where she belonged.

The only reason that Catra wasn't rushing off to greet Adora as she entered Halfmoon proper was because she and Kesi wanted to renew their scent marks ASAP and neither of them trusted themselves to not do that in the middle of the streets.

(Kesi also wanted to *finally* kiss Adora and she needed some place semi-private for that since her imprint on Adora wasn't public knowledge.)

Catra wasn't waiting alone. Aside from her family, Kesi (of course), Kittrina, Melog, and Clover were all with her. While the rest of them were hanging back and talking quietly amongst themselves, Catra and Kesi stood front and center. (Catra was trying her level best to not grab Kesi's hand and squeeze the life out of it. From the way Kesi's tail was wrapped tightly around her wrist, she was stopping it from lashing excitedly like Catra's was.)

Finally, after what felt like five more years of waiting, a familiar mop of blonde hair appeared and crossed the threshold.

Catra and Kesi couldn't wait even a second longer.

"ADORA!" they both shouted as they dropped to all fours and rushed at their mutual *khai'tel.*

"CATRA! KESI!" Adora shouted back as she ran at them in return.

The two Magicats leaped as one and promptly tackled Adora to the ground, their purrs loud enough to be heard from the other side of Halfmoon as Catra went about scent marking one of Adora's cheeks while Kesi scent marked the other. Adora laughed and, oh, Catra had somehow forgotten just how *beautiful* Adora's laugh was with that adorable little snort. The laughter quickly turned into tears as the three girls clung to each other, afraid that everything would disappear if they let go.

Melog and Caspin very quickly joined in on the impromptu cuddle pile while the rest of the adults stood back with fond smiles on their faces, some of them a little misty eyed themselves.

"Alright, everyone, I think that's enough," Cyrus said after a few minutes as he approached the cuddle pile. "We're all excited to see Adora but there're more comfortable places where we can get caught up."

It was with a great deal of reluctance that Catra and Kesi got off of Adora and helped her to her feet. Now that Catra could actually get a good look at her girlfriend, though, she could tell that she looked… *different.*

She was taller, for one—a couple inches taller than Catra but a couple inches shorter than Kesi. She was also a *lot* skinnier, possibly nearly anorexic. Her skin also had an almost unhealthy pallor to it—she had never had particularly tan skin thanks to living underground but this was something else.

Lastly, her blue-grey eyes which normally sparkled with love and occasionally mischief instead had an almost-but-not-quite haunted quality and were surrounded by lichtenberg scars. It was as if she was feeling everything from a distance

Catra privately swore then and there to *destroy* everyone who did this to her precious *khai'tel.*

"C'mon, Adora!" Catra began as she started to pull Adora back to the palace. "Let's get to my room so that way we can—"

Catra's words were cut off as pain bloomed in her stomach and back. She looked down, her eyes wide with shock, to see that a sword made from a twisted, black metal was running her through. She slowly craned her head to look over her shoulder at Adora.

If she had any air left in her lungs, it would have rushed out.

Adora was standing there behind her but she also *wasn't* Adora. She had a malevolent smile plastered across her face and her eyes were now a sickly shade of yellow while her skin was deathly pale. In her hand was the hilt of the black blade currently lodged in Catra.

"Hey, Catra," 'Adora' practically purred with malicious glee before unceremoniously yanking the sword out of her.

Catra fell to the ground onto her hands and knees, blood pouring out of the open wound in her torso to pool beneath her. Her breathing was ragged and she could taste blood and bile in the back of her mouth. She blinked once, twice, thrice as her head spun with the impossibility of what was happening.

When Catra somehow found the strength to look back over at 'Adora,' the sight that she saw made her want to scream in despair.

All of Catra's loved ones were splayed out around 'Adora,' each one of their corpses horribly mutilated almost beyond recognition while 'Adora' herself was bathed in their blood. Behind her, Halfmoon burned as the Horde flag was raised.

"A… dor… ra… why?" Catra somehow managed to choke out as her vision started to fail her.

'Adora' sneered down at Catra's dying form. "Two years, Catra. You lied to me, said that the Horde would never get me, and then left me with them for *two years!* Do you know what I've been through? Do you know what they did to me? Going back to them was my worst nightmare and yet you, my *khai'tel,* a part of my soul, *left me with—"*

Catra's Rooms

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Years After Adora's Abduction

Catra awoke with a start, a scream dying in her throat as Melog cuddled up against her. They reached out into her mind and

blanketed her thoughts, grounding her in reality and slowly but surely calming her down.

Catra lay there for a while, breathing heavily as she brought up one hand to idly scratch behind Melog's ears causing a spectral purr to rumble forth. The combination of it and them grounding her thoughts helped to calm her racing heart even as she blinked away tears.

That nightmare had felt *so real.* Almost without thought, Catra placed her free hand against her back where 'Adora's' sword had run her through only to find the silken cloth of her pajama top.

Running a hand over her face, Catra dragged herself out from underneath her bed and stood up, carefully stretching her tense muscles. According to her clock, it was just after three in the morning and she knew that she wouldn't be getting any more sleep. So, with that in mind, she got out of her pajamas and put on some simple clothes—a maroon tunic with beige trousers and black stirrup socks—and tied her mane into a low tail before sliding on her diadem and making her leave.

She wasn't dressed as a royal beyond her diadem but she also didn't care. At that moment, she wasn't Crown Princess Catra Dr'iluth, she was just Catra and so she made her way to one place where she would be considered just Catra by everyone: the training grounds.

Catra nodded to the few guards and the odd servant along the way, not trusting her voice for any serious greeting. She was unsurprised to find that the training grounds were deserted and was grateful for that. While she could be just Catra here, she wasn't in the mood to talk to anyone.

Grabbing a training staff, Catra first went through some warmup exercises before eventually approaching a training dummy and getting to work practicing her forms. Her blows came hard and fast as she tried to purge the remnants of the nightmare

and her fear from her mind with Melog's help. She *needed* to calm down and get her fear reigned in before anyone woke up.

After all, Catra was seen by her people as a fearless Princess, an icon of bravery. She had stared down traitors, the Horde, and those who'd side with them time and time again without even an ounce of hesitation. She guided Halfmoon through the Cave Fever epidemic with the grace and dignity befitting a royal when her parents were incapacitated. She hadn't even let the capture of her *khai'tel* so much as slow her down.

But, as far as Catra was concerned, that was all just an elaborate ruse. Catra was someone who was deathly afraid of a great many things. She feared losing her family; she feared terrible things befalling her people; she feared being unworthy of her family's legacy; and, chief of all, she feared that she had failed Adora and that it was too late to save her.

Even after all these years, she feared being taken by the Stars Above and thus slept under her bed unless she was having a sleepover with Kesi and/or Adora.

To this day, there was exactly one person who Catra had confided that particular fear to and that person was Adora. Adora had been considerate, hadn't mocked her or made light of her fear. She had just promised Catra that nothing would take her away as long as she was around.

Catra had slept better after that even if she had still rarely slept on top of her bed when by herself. She trusted Adora more than she trusted just about anyone. It was silly that just the words of her at-that-time best friend could comfort her so but they had. Adora made all of Catra's fears seem small simply by being there.

But now Adora was gone and Catra was left alone with her fears. She could tell her parents, she could confide in Kesi, but fear stilled her tongue. Not the fear of judgement but rather the fear that they would make her feel safer only for her to then lose

them, too. Besides, they were all dealing with more than enough as is. They didn't need to deal with Catra's fears on top of everything else.

Catra was strong now—*much* stronger than she had been on the day of the second coup attempt a bit over two years ago. She was a powerful sorceress and a skilled warrior and her capabilities grew by the day along with her political acumen and her strategic thinking. She should be able to handle her fears on her own, to stand strong and have her lack of weakness not be a mere act.

And yet.

Catra's thoughts came to a stop when a new presence made itself known.

"Well, you're up early," a familiar voice said. Catra whirled around and saw her father standing near the entrance to the training grounds. Much like her, he was also wearing casual clothing—a blue shirt with a maroon vest and white trousers.

Catra glanced at a nearby clock and saw that it was nearly four in the morning. "I could say the same to you," she replied.

Cyrus chuckled lightly but his face otherwise remained impassive as he properly entered the training yard. "I'd say 'good morning' but something tells me that nothing about this morning is good for either of us." When Catra just grunted in affirmation and went back to training, he continued, "So, what's got you up so early?"

"Woke up. Couldn't go back to sleep so I decided to get some training in. Maybe make myself tired enough to get some more sleep before I have to be up," Catra replied somewhat tersely between strikes.

"Like father, like daughter. I'm here to do the same thing. What woke you up?" he asked. When Catra didn't answer, he sighed and did his own warmup exercises before grabbing a

practice sword. “Why not spar with me instead of beating up that hapless training dummy? We’ll get more out of it that way.”

Catra stopped her practice and took a moment to catch her breath before considering her dad’s offer. It had been some time since they had gotten the chance to spar together so she nodded before following him to one of the sparring circles. Once there, they bowed to each other and assumed a guard stance.

Things started off slowly with Catra testing her dad’s flawless guard but things eventually picked up the pace as Catra threw herself into an offensive. Their respective weapons were little more than blurs as they danced around each other, the air full of the distinct *thwack* of wood hitting wood. The two were mostly silent with Cyrus occasionally giving out bits of advice. Eventually, however, Cyrus spoke up.

“What woke you up?” he asked again, his voice casual as though he weren’t currently sparring with his daughter.

Catra’s mental defenses couldn’t hold out against both her dad’s concern and Melog’s insistence that she open up. “Nightmare,” she gritted out.

A look of sad understanding crossed Cyrus’ face as he fended off another string of attacks. “Want to talk about it?” he asked.

“Not particularly,” Catra replied as she shifted her attack pattern. She ignored the exasperation she could feel coming from Melog.

“I get those, too. That’s also why I’m awake,” Cyrus said as he parried Catra’s swing before gently tapping her throat with his practice sword. Catra nodded in acknowledgement of the point before returning to her guard stance and starting again, ignoring how her muscles were starting to ache.

“Mine was about that first coup attempt, the one that took your grandfathers, aunts, and your Uncle Aster,” Cyrus started as he brushed aside a swing and tapped Catra’s forward leg. “I came

so close to losing you that night. If I had just been a hair slower or hadn't found that knife, I— I don't know what would have happened. There were an infinite number of ways that night could have gone even worse and yet an outcome better than even the best possible one happened instead."

Catra didn't bother to resume her attack as she struggled to catch her breath. She watched her dad with wide eyes, her ears pinned back even as Cyrus' ears drooped. She had never seen that far away look in her father's eyes before nor the almost pained expression on his face.

"I… I'm afraid, Catra. I'm afraid that I'm not strong enough to keep my family safe. Your Uncle Aster was like a brother to me and he's *gone* now. I was only good enough to get you and Adora out of the Fright Zone because I *got lucky.* Every time those traitors rear their ugly heads, I can't help but fear that, this time, I'll lose you or Lyra or Caspin."

"Papa…" Catra said softly as she watched her father visibly fight back tears. In the face of her father's vulnerability, Catra had no choice but to be vulnerable in return.

"Mine… Mine was… about Adora," Catra started, her voice weak. "She came back to us but she… she…" Catra's training staff clattered to the ground as she dropped it so that way she could wrap her arms around herself, her tail winding around one of her legs. In an instant, Cyrus' practice sword was on the ground as he held his little girl close.

"She killed everyone and she— Halfmoon was burning and she — she killed *me."* A sob escaped Catra's throat as tears started pouring down her face. "She— It's been *two years,* Papa! She's been in that place all by herself for two years and they— Who knows what they've done to her? I'm… I'm *terrified* that, even if we *do* get her back, the Adora that comes home will be completely different from the Adora that was taken from us.

"What if Adora's *gone,* Papa? Not physically but mentally and emotionally? What if she— What if she—" Another sob escaped her as Cyrus started to gently rock her back and forth, a soothing purr rumbling to life in his chest. Catra unwrapped her arms from around herself to instead cling to her papa for dear life as she forced the next words out.

"What if she hates me?"

Cyrus tenderly stroked Catra's mane as he let her cry for a moment before eventually speaking up. "She's not going to hate you," he said softly but with supreme conviction. "I don't know what the Horde might be doing to her but our Adora's *strong.* She's a lion, remember? She'll survive long enough for us to bring her back home where she belongs. She may not be exactly the same but she'll still love you and Kesi and Caspin and Lyra and me and everyone else. Our little lion has a *huge* heart that's full of love and *nothing* the Horde can do can turn that love into hate."

"You really think so?" Catra asked, her voice small as she looked up at her father, her eyes sparkling with tears.

"I *know* so. And you know it, too. Adora may not actively remember her time in Halfmoon but all of those memories are buried deep within her heart where not even the most powerful of magics can touch them. You know this from what Rogelio told us, how bits and pieces of her time in Halfmoon still leak through.

"Adora *will* remember everything one day and she *will* come back home. And do you know what you're going to do when she does?"

"What?"

"You're going to greet her with a smile. You're going to show her just how strong you've gotten in her absence. Not as a warrior or a sorceress but as a person. You are *strong,* Catra, so unbelievably strong. You're stronger than I am, in some ways. If I

were in your position, I don't think I'd be able to handle it nearly as well."

Catra had nothing to say to that so she instead buried her face into her papa's shoulder and let herself cry as the maelstrom of emotion tore through her.

Eventually, after a good, long while, Catra's tears dried up. She was left feeling hollowed out but in a pleasant way. She pulled away from Cyrus enough to wipe her eyes before smiling up at him.

"There's my girl," Cyrus said with a smile of his own as he cast a quick spell that every Magicat knew to dry her fur, hiding most of the evidence that she'd been crying. "You know what I think we need? I think we need a family picnic. We can leave affairs to the others for a while."

"Will you make fried catfish?" Catra asked hopefully. She *loved* her papa's fried catfish.

Cyrus chuckled. "Of course! Anything for my little girl. Come on. Let's clean up here and take a quick nap before we drop our plan on everyone. Sound good?"

Catra nodded, a small smile gracing her face. "Yeah. That sounds great."

As Catra and Cyrus returned their practice weapons, Catra hardened her resolve. She *would* get Adora back, Adora *would* still love her, and everything can be *exactly* as it should be. No matter what it took, Catra would see her dream turn into reality.

Caspin's Rooms

Halfmoon Palace

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Years After Adora's Abduction

Caspin was, as of late, typically a morning person. While they weren't quite as chipper as, say, Kesi, he enjoyed getting up before most people and using that time to work on their personal projects or maybe get some light reading done. It used to be that he woke up early due to nightmares but those had largely abated.

Today was no different as they arose at around six in the morning. Caspin thrived on routines and so he set about his morning one. He brushed his teeth, combed his mane (they didn't need their Auntie Kittrina or Mama to do it anymore; they weren't a mewling kitten), groomed their fur, and got dressed in loungewear.

After that, he did some light exercises and practiced some basic spells (it never hurt to shore up on the fundamentals). With those complete, he was about to settle down with a book that they'd already started when there was a knock on their door.

"Enter," Caspin beckoned and was surprised to see Auntie Kittrina open the door.

"Good morning, Caspy!" she greeted.

"Good morning, Auntie Kittrina," Caspin returned as they walked over to give her a hug. Auntie Kittrina was the only one who was allowed to call him 'Caspy.'

"Can I help you with something?" Caspin asked as they took a step back.

"I was sent to get you, actually," Kittrina revealed. "King Cyrus wishes to see you in the parlor."

"The parlor?" Caspin parroted. A quick glance at the clock revealed it to be just after 6:30 in the morning. They usually held

breakfast around seven so… "What's so important that it couldn't wait until breakfast?"

Kittrina shrugged. "Your guess is as good as mine."

"Do you think this is formal or informal?"

"Well, His Majesty was wearing loungewear as was Her Highness so it's informal."

"Sis is already awake?" Caspin asked with more than a little surprise. Unlike Caspin, Catra was very much *not* a morning person and almost always had to be woken up by Kesi. (Although, Caspin wondered about how much that was needed versus wanted.)

As Kittrina answered, Caspin made their way over to his vanity and put on his indorium circlet. Even if this was informal, he was *still* the Princeps of Halfmoon. It simply wouldn't do to be seen outside of their rooms without at least that.

"Yeah, that surprised me, too. According to the guard, both she and His Majesty have been awake for some time now."

"Do you know why?" Caspin asked as they went out the door. Kittrina, ever the diligent Captain of the Royal Guard, fell in line to Caspin's left and a pace behind.

"Your guess is as good as mine," Kittrina replied with a shrug. "They apparently spent some time at the training grounds but that's all I know."

The two lapsed into silence as they made their way to the family's parlor. Once there, they were surprised to find out that he was the last one to arrive. He was also surprised by the fact that no one other than the Royal Family was present, not even Kesi.

"Ah! Good! You're finally here!" Cyrus said with a clap of his hands. Utilizing the observational skills that Clover had been teaching them, Caspin could see signs that both their papa and sis

hadn't gotten much sleep (although Cyrus was *much* better at hiding it than Catra was).

"What's going on, Papa?" Caspin asked as they took a seat. Kittrina bowed to the Royal Family before making her leave.

"That's the question of the hour," Lyra remarked from her favorite chair, a cup of tea already in hand. Cyrus and Catra, meanwhile, appeared to have mugs of a tisane known for its high caffeine content nearby.

"Catra and I have been talking and we had an idea that we just *know* that you two are gonna love," Cyrus began with just a hint of manic energy. "We should take the day off and spend some time together as a family starting with a family picnic!"

Caspin perked up at the news. It *had* been a fair while since they all spent some time together as a family.

"That sounds like a lovely idea!" Lyra said as she set her cup down. "I also know just the park where we should have it, too."

Caspin fought with everything that they had to not react to that. They were going to have a picnic in one of the public parks? That made sense—that's where people normally had picnics—but he hadn't been to a park in about four years now. Not ever since *that day.*

Caspin *really* didn't want to go back to a park but they also didn't want to ruin this for everyone else. They were all so happy and excited, it wouldn't do for Caspin to ruin that just because of their own personal hangups. So, Caspin kept their smile firmly in place and tried to only think about spending time with his family.

"When are we going?" Caspin asked, trying to sound like their usual upbeat, energetic self. Based on the look that Lyra gave him, he didn't fully succeed.

"Well, I want to make everything myself so that'll take me a bit. I also need to see about getting everything to make fried

catfish—”

“Fried catfish? For breakfast?” Lyra interjected.

“Hey, I promised Catra that I’d make it so we're going to have some,” Cyrus explained. Catra smiled bashfully and sank down in her seat but a look of understanding came over Lyra’s face as she gave Catra a tender smile.

As for Caspin, they were starting to put some things together. Whatever had woken Catra up must have been something bad and this entire thing was to make her feel better. Did their big sis have nightmares, too?

“Anyway, it’ll take me a bit to get everything together and we’ll need to make sure Perci, Cloudfoot, Kesi, and the others are prepared for a day mostly without us so… Does meeting up at the palace gates at seven thirty sound good to everyone?”

“Works for me,” Catra said with a nod.

“An hour should be sufficient time,” Lyra agreed.

“I am fine with that,” Caspin concurred.

“Excellent! Now, then, if you’ll excuse me, I have some cooking to do!” With that Cyrus quickly made his exit, Catra trailing behind him. Caspin was about to get up when Lyra spoke up.

“Are you truly okay with this, Caspin?” she asked.

Caspin sat back down and gave his mother their best quizzical look. “Of course I am! Why *wouldn’t* I want to spend time with everyone?”

Lyra gave Caspin a rather unimpressed look. “I’m not doubting that, you just had an odd reaction to the choice of venue. Come to think of it, you haven’t been to a park in a very long time, haven’t you?”

Caspin *hated* lying to their family but they couldn't ruin this for everyone else. "I have no problems with going to the park. I just… haven't had a reason to go in a fair while."

Lyra closed her eyes and sighed deeply before looking at Caspin. "It's because of the assassination attempt, isn't it?" she asked softly. When Caspin said nothing, she continued, "You're worried about something like that happening again and, this time, there's no Adora to save someone."

Caspin couldn't meet his mama's eyes and found himself staring at his toes. "Worried? Why should I be worried? You'll be there and so will Papa and Sis is a lot stronger and I'm stronger, too! Another assassination attempt like that would be the height of foolishness!"

Lyra got up from her chair and crossed the room to kneel in front of Caspin, taking his hands in hers. "You're right in that there's nothing to worry about but that doesn't make your fear meaningless. My heart, that event *traumatized* you—you were only eight years old and you nearly watched your sister bleed to death from an attack aimed at you."

"I'm not some mewling kitten who's too afraid to go to the park," Caspin grumbled almost bitterly.

"You're not a kitten anymore but age has nothing to do with trauma." Lyra was silent for a moment before saying, "Do you want to know a secret? I'm afraid, too."

Caspin's head jerked up to meet their mama's eyes, their own wide with incredulity. "You? Afraid? Of what?"

"My heart, I almost lost everything in one awful night. If things had gone just slightly differently, you never would have been born and I would be all alone. Every time those traitors rear their despicable heads, I fear that, this time, they'll be successful in taking everything from me. When I had heard what had happened

to Catra on that day, my heart had stopped and didn't start beating again until I saw that everyone was alive.

"If that day scared me, who wasn't even there, then there's nothing wrong with it having traumatized you. Now, are you sure that you're okay with things? We can always eat breakfast here and spend the day doing other things. No one will mind."

Caspin was silent for a long moment as he chewed on his bottom lip. A part of him *really* didn't want to go to the park but they couldn't run from this fear forever. Their mama was afraid of things but she was also brave by facing those fears. If they wanted to be brave like his mama…

"We'll still go to the park," Caspin decided. "I want to be brave like you."

Lyra smiled at her child. "Alright. If it ever becomes too much, just tell one of us and we'll leave immediately, okay? There's no shame in recognizing and accepting your limits and there's no reason to push yourself too hard."

Caspin nodded. "Okay. I promise."

One of Halfmoon's Parks

Upper Residential District

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Years After Adora's Abduction

Caspin was tense the moment the park came into view and that tension only grew as they got closer. It felt like their senses were in overdrive as they scanned the area and every person in it for even the slightest hint of the possibility of an assassin.

He took a deep breath in through his nose and then out through his mouth as he forced himself to relax. He was currently standing between their parents with their sis right behind them. They also knew that Kittrina and a couple of the Royal Guard were also loitering about the area, out of sight but not so far away that they couldn't quickly intervene in case of trouble. Him and his family were in no more danger here than they were in the palace.

Caspin kept that fact playing on a loop as they focused on the idle conversation going on between their family. It wasn't much—just general catching up and idle observations—but it acted as a balm for their fraying nerves.

As they reached their spot, Caspin let himself be dragged into the conversation and soon he was chatting and laughing happily along with the rest of his family as they ate the delicious breakfast prepared by their papa.

After they ate, Cyrus roped Catra and Caspin into a game of tag which quickly devolved into some roughhousing as Lyra laughed in the background. It then changed into a cuddle pile when Caspin broke off to tackle Lyra to the ground, Cyrus and Catra not even a beat behind them.

The Royal Family laughed and played the day away before returning their things to the palace and setting out once more to go see a movie that just released. It was a comedy action film about a guy who loved martial arts suddenly being proclaimed a legendary warrior despite not knowing any martial arts and being out of shape.

It was a good movie, Caspin thought, and had a surprisingly heartfelt message about being enough exactly as you are. They made a note to pick up a copy once it went on sale for home release.

Once the movie was over, they retired back to the palace, discussing the film as they walked, before moving on to playing board and card games. Half the fun of that wasn't so much the

game itself but rather trying to catch Cyrus and Catra whenever they decided to cheat.

When the hour became late, they all bid each other a good night before making their way back to their rooms. As Caspin changed into his pajamas and went through his nightly ritual, they were glad that they had faced their fear. After all, it wouldn't be much longer now until Catra and company left Halfmoon for an unforeseeable length of time. The more time they got to spend together as a family before then, the better.

With those thoughts in mind, Caspin tucked themself into bed and drifted off into a peaceful sleep.

Chapter End Notes

Fun Fact: This originally started life as a side story and went through a couple different iterations before we settled on this one. We also decided to make it a chapter of HoH due to it being a tad too important to be relegated to side story status.

Chapter 9: A Vision of Gold

Chapter Summary

Catra is throwing herself into self-destructive anger but a vision may give her hope.

Askar's *Tenemos*

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Years After Adora's Abduction

Catra's ass hit the floor again with a *thump*. The light above the training field did not flicker, so that was something at least. Above her, Askar twirled his *kiari* and stepped back into position. He offered her a hand; she grabbed her staff and settled back into position.

"Again," she snarled. She was going to go until she could manage both perfectly. She couldn't beat Askar in a fight, but she needed to be able to hold her own against him so she could hold her own against anyone, all while keeping her spell going.

She had spent the past three days whenever she had free time dueling Askar or Papa. The battle in the tunnels had shaken her more than she liked to admit. In every battle she had ever been in before, she had Adora to protect her. Adora who trained day in and day out with Askar. So, until she was back, she would have to look after herself.

Throwing herself into fight after fight until she was too tired to stand, Askar and Papa had both told her not to burn herself out,

but she couldn’t just sit there doing nothing while Adora suffered. She drove her staff into the ground, careful not to let any sparks fly from it. Her focus was solely on keeping the light above her lit and the movement of Askar's body as he flowed from stance into stance. *How did Adora beat this?*

As she twisted her staff up into a hasty block, every muscle in her body screamed at her to use magic. A simple spell would hold the blade were it connected to the indorium of her staff or a spell to make her invisible or any number of other solutions to fighting a superior opponent. Instead, she focused on the flame lighting the arena. Her goal was to keep it lit above all else, a simple spell, but splitting her focus had almost gotten her killed on the train. She could not allow that to happen again.

She moved like a graceful warrior, just like her father had taught her, just like Askar was teaching her, just like Adora moved. It wasn’t anywhere near enough. She caught a blow to the jaw from Askar's *kiari.* Without her magic enhancing her, she couldn’t keep up.

Spitting out a gob of blood onto the sand, she twisted her staff into a defensive posture. A small gasp came from Kesi who was sitting against one corner of the room. She always hated watching Catra fight. The Princess shouldn’t be fighting, Percival had told her more than once. But here she was, slowly circling the taller Magicat general as he held himself as steady as a rock in a storm. The first time he drew blood from her, he had demanded the bout stop there. Now, he knew there was no stopping her. She was not in the right headspace for politics, or listening to anyone, she wanted to fight, to feel her body hurt from exertion, and nobody in the kingdom could test her like Askar could.

“Highness, I think that’s enough for today.” His voice echoed across the chamber.

She snarled at him, blood staining between her teeth. “We’re done when I say we’re done, General.” She lunged. He knocked aside the blow—it would have been the perfect opening for a tiny

explosion to throw her body away from his counterattack, the kind of spell she had been practicing with Mama since she was ten years old. She let the counterstroke hit her; it drove the wind from her lungs. Good, next time she wouldn't over extend.

She pushed herself to her feet again, this time swinging the staff low. He stepped aside as casually as over a loose paving stone. She tried again, and again, each one going wide. She was leaving herself open and he wasn't exploiting it.

Swinging the staff with all the strength she could muster into a blow to his throat, he didn't even react with his *kiari* instead he reached out and grabbed the tip of the staff and held it in an iron grip.

"Highness, we're done." His voice was hard as steel and cold as ice. She glared up at him for a moment, wrenching her staff free from his grip and stalking away.

He bowed to her once, in the way of a warrior of *kirith* and turned to leave the *tenemos.* Before he did, he stopped next to Kesi and held her arm gently, muttering something to her that Catra from across the room couldn't hear. Above them, the light flickered and died.

For a brief moment, the room was plunged into total darkness. She hadn't truly been in complete darkness for over a decade. Adora was afraid of it, and after she was gone, she kept the lights on at all times, just so she would be comfortable when she got back, as if she would materialize out of thin air at any moment and tell Catra it would all be alright.

But she hadn't come back. Every plan to rescue her was 'in-progress' and no one would tell her what was happening. She was on the verge of charging in herself and damning the consequences. If it weren't for Kesi being here, she would have done it. It probably would have gotten her killed, but the slimmest chance she could rescue Adora from that nightmare realm and she would take it.

The room was suddenly aglow as Kesi cast her own small spell to light the air around her; it danced with celestial magic. She smiled over at Catra, walking over to her slowly. She held out her hand towards Catra and said, "Come on, frowny, I've got chores to run, and you want to hit things instead of being a princess so lets go for a walk. I need to pick up my meds so come with me please?"

Catra took her hand, the softness of Kesi's palm over her newly forming calluses and she felt her anger fading slightly, but not disappearing. Kesi's own fears manifested very differently than Catra's: Catra got angry, Kesi got anxious. A journey through the market may be best for both of them.

She held Kesi's hand tightly, feeling the tension in her own hands mirrored in her *khai'tel,* the two of them walked from the chamber.

Behind Tathlan's Bakery

Crescent Market

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Years After Adora's Abduction

Kesi's hands barely shook anymore as she held the pack of ice up to Catra's face. The Princess was constantly throwing herself into danger as if her life no longer mattered, as if suffering herself would bring Adora back quicker. Many nights they had spent curled up together asking a simple "What if?".

What if Catra had met up with Adora earlier, what if Kesi had gone with her that day, what if Askar had taken her straight back to the palace, what if, what if, what if!

It didn’t matter; neither of them could change the past. They hadn’t been with Adora when she had needed them most and now she was trapped in her own personal hell. And worst of all, from what the Spirit Ember had shown Catra that first night, she wouldn’t even remember them.

Kesi tried desperately to cling onto hope with every ounce of her being, and she would hope enough for her and Catra, even if her Princess could not see the stars in the sky, and simply wished to rage against the night. She would hold fast for both of them until Adora returned to them both. So it was with gentle hands she pressed the crushed ice to the swelling lip that was developing. Catra had refused to allow Kesi to heal her to settle the swelling instead, wanting to feel the pain a little while longer.

She had not refused Kesi’s ministrations, nor commented on her faint admonishing glare. Instead, they had walked hand in hand through the market, picking up Kesi's medicinal moonflower and some baked treats from Tathlan’s and sat, while Kesi tended to her fading bruises, eating the slowly cooling pastries.

By that time, they had settled in a small, private booth around the back of Tathlan’s bakery, fresh tea and pastries in hand. The swelling had mostly gone down and the shaking from pain and anxiety from both of them had washed away. The two sat under a small canopy out of view of the rest of the public and the inevitable talk. While their relationship was an open secret, it was technically still a secret to the public. She had held her hand around the strong tea, with an added dash of honey from the royal stock.

They had sat in comfortable silence while she had fussed over Catra. The girl was reckless and threw herself into fights. The Queen had tried to talk to her, but when her love got into one of her moods, it was near impossible to shake her out of it. It was purely self-destructive, as if her anger at the world was all down to her failures. She had used her skills as a seamstress to keep her hands steady as she stitched up the small cut from the blow to her face.

"Done," she said, trying to smile at her *khai'tel.* "Keeping your face in one piece is becoming a full time job." She tried for a joke but her voice was far too watery.

"Kesi, I'm…" she struggled over her own words. The Princess was always so confident and brave in public, even around her family most of the time. But not with Kesi, not anymore. "I just miss her, and I don't want to be stuck here waiting for answers that might never come."

"I know, my beloved. But she's coming back to us. I know it. I don't want her to break her oath to you while she can't uphold it. So please, just slow down, if not for me, or her, for yourself. You deserve some happiness. We will wait for her but don't lose your life waiting." The words were as much to convince herself as they were for Catra.

She pulled Catra in close and began to purr; Catra could barely manage the slightest reverberation back. It was an intimate scene, everyone who knew them would not interrupt and Tathlan was paid well enough to keep prying eyes away from the garden. The tea and baked rolls were cold by the time the two broke apart. Catra's eyes went wide.

"Kesi, you're glowing." Kesi could feel it within her, the same well that Adora had awoken within her was roiling like the sea at the storm wall. She could feel it trying to pull her under. Catra's gaze was appraising; she was her heart and soul, and a sorceress trained by Lyra and having graduated from the Hall of the Lost Temple before her eighteenth birthday. Right now, she was looking at her like a curiosity.

"I… I think something's happening. I can almost feel her," Kesi was whispering, trying to make sense of what was happening. For so long, her source of celestial magic had lain undisturbed, only winking to life in brief moments without her reaching for it in the middle of the night. "She's reaching for her magic, like she knows it's there. She hasn't been like this in years."

Catra looked around, her resolve hardening across her features. “We need to go, to get my mother, or Kelara!”

The Lost Temple

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two Years after Adora’s Abduction

Gathering Kelara was easy. Lyra had said she would join them as soon as she was free from petitioners, but Kelara always had time for her great-granddaughter, especially when it came to matters of Adora. Catra had heard the talk from Kelara once when they thought the two of them were asleep, Kelara and Lyra had spoken of Adora outside Catra’s bedroom.

Kelara had faith that Adora was something different than anyone else on Etheria, not just because genetically she was different, as Lenio was quick to establish, but because her supply of celestial magic was like nothing the older Magicat had ever seen. She had heard Kelara’s belief kept away from Adora, that she was the next woman chosen to become She-Ra after a thousand years since the time of Mara, that mysterious incarnation of the hero who predated the disappearance of the stars. Adora, who had become an Acolyte of the Celestial Promise. Adora, who was so ready to fight for what she believed was right. Adora, who loved the world around her and was loved in return. Adora, who was trapped in the darkest place on Etheria.

When Kelara had heard that Kesi’s celestial magic was responding to something beyond its wielder's touch, she had come immediately to the Lost Temple, meeting the two girls en route. She had her own theories about the imprinting and the healing magics done on Kesi once having linked their pools of

magic, like a stream connecting a lake and an ocean; what happens in one may have effects on the other. Only the Spirit Ember—the RuneStone of connections—may have the answers they seek.

Catra was not in the mood for Kelara's cryptic nature today. She had dragged Kesi down here to a holy place that she treated with barely any reverence. Only her love for Kesi and Mama and begrudging respect for Kelara stopped her from outright attacking the Spirit Ember for answers.

She rested her head against the RuneStone, muttering to it, "Please, just let me see her. Please…" The tears that ran down her cheeks evaporated from the roiling heat of the RuneStone before they could fall to the ground. The Spirit Ember flared for a single moment.

Suddenly, she wasn't in the Lost temple, she was standing in a room she didn't recognise but looked identical to Askar's *tenemos.* She was standing directly behind Adora; she could smell her scent in the air. Her shoulders relaxed for the first time in years. Adora stood before her, *kiari* in her hands—but it wasn't her *kiari,* the colour was wrong, and the blade a few inches shorter. Catra had spent so many nights cuddled up to Adora who refused to let the thing go even in her sleep. She had often envied that blade.

Before her was a monster of a woman, wreathed in dark magic, Shards of the Black Garnet hanging from her.

The woman cackled something—it was like trying to listen to speech through a deep pool of water—and Adora looked like she had been struck. She could only stare wide eyed as the woman's dark magic formed into a cutting ribbon. Adora should have dodged, weaved aside from such an attack. But she just stood there… as if accepting her death.

Catra screamed out "Adora!" and she responded. Suddenly gone was the defeated and terrified look. Outwards came the

Knight of Halfmoon, her *kiari* moved in a smooth motion wreathed in golden light.

She watched in awed reverence as the Adora demonstrated to this witch why she was the warrior who would act as the hero of Halfmoon. Her blade crashed into the witch, and she watched as the woman's eyes went wide in shock, as if she could poke a dragon and not be burnt.

The woman summoned chains of magenta light to trap her *khai'tel* and behind her she could feel another presence. Kesi, too, watched on, urging her to fight. Adora, always the warrior of the three of them, roared her pain and frustration out, the chains around her breaking as if they were made of paper rather than condensed magic.

The vision began to fade as the woman was struck by Adora and fell into a pile the fizzling dark energy dissipated from the others in the room. She could see those other two other figures approaching her, one was a mustached man and the other a large Scorpioni woman. Despite her apprehension of trusting strangers especially with Adora, something in the Spirit Ember calmed her nerves. These were allies and not enemies. One of them said something and the only word she caught, and she could not say who said it her love or a stranger, was "Askar"

She awoke on the warm tiled floor of the Lost Temple, tears running down her cheeks while Kesi and her mama crowded over her. "I saw her," she kept saying. "She's alive, she's alive. She's fighting back, I don't know how but she heard me."

Kesi pulled her in close and began to purr. "I told you we will see her again; I promised it, Catra."

Chapter 10: Showdown in the Fright Zone

Chapter by Zelenal

Chapter Summary

> Events boiling in the background finally come to a head as Cyrus leads a strike team into the heart of the Fright Zone with the hopes of rescuing Adora.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Lyra and Cyrus' Rooms

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

"I still hate this plan," Lyra said apropos of nothing one night as she and Cyrus were getting ready for bed. Cyrus sighed, knowing what his wife was talking about. They'd had this conversation several times before and would likely keep having it until all was said and done.

"I know, darling," Cyrus began as he came up behind her and held her close. A gentle purr emanated from Lyra's chest causing Cyrus to purr in return even as their tails twined together. "But you know that this is the best plan we've got."

"It's the *only* plan we've got," Lyra corrected him wryly.

Cyrus chuckled slightly. "Even so," he allowed.

Lyra sighed and twisted around in her husband's arms so that way she could hold him. She buried her nose into the nape of his neck and just let herself breathe him in for a moment. As always, her *khai'tel's* familiar scent soothed her nerves and caused her purr to grow louder.

"I still wish there was a better way. I came *so close* to losing you to that place once already," Lyra said after a long moment.

"True but I was in my pajamas by myself and with only one sword last time. This time, I'll be fully geared up and have handpicked some of our greatest warriors. It's the Horde that should be afraid, not you," Cyrus said as he began petting down his wife's mane.

"I know," Lyra replied with a sigh. "I still wish you didn't have to go. I don't want to lose you." She said the last part in a small voice, one that never failed to break Cyrus' heart.

Cyrus pulled back slightly and gestured for Lyra to do the same. Once he could look into her eyes, he said, "My love, there's not a single force on this planet or beyond that could keep me from coming back to you and our children."

Rather than wait for an answer, Cyrus sealed his promise by kissing his *khai'tel* long and slow, savoring every last second. When they finally pulled apart, Lyra set about scent marking both of his cheeks so that way their scents would intermingle. It was a sort of ritual that she had started doing not long after the plan was finalized.

"You better bring our daughter back," Lyra practically ordered once she was satisfied.

Cyrus' grin was all fangs as he replied, "Darling, I may be many things but a failure is not one of them. We'll get Adora back and then we can have a nice, big 'welcome home' party."

"You promise?"

"I promise."

The War Room

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Clover went over her gear one last time as everyone gathered in the war room. Five minutes ago, the signal had gone out to everyone who was to partake in the mission to rescue Adora, notifying them that the time had finally come.

For the first time in her life, Clover was going into battle wearing armor. Since her fighting style required her to remain light on her feet, she went with lighter armor than nearly everyone else. Her cuirass was made from indorium-studded leather and she also wore vambraces, greaves, and faulds made from indorium with indorium-studded leather tassets to protect her upper legs while maintaining mobility.

While she still didn't use weapons, Clover's claws had been temporarily enchanted by a sorcerer to allow them to cut through all but the strongest metals. She was also wearing a belt, strapped to which were three grenades and an emergency blaster.

When the call had gone out from King Cyrus for volunteers for this mission, Clover had practically pounced on it. She was a damn good fighter and Adora was one of her friends, after all, but, more than that, the mere idea of the upcoming fight made her blood race with excitement. She had gotten a taste of what a true fight was like during the Cave Fever incident and now she was going to be teleporting into the heart of the Horde with a small team.

The strike force was composed of a total of twenty people: King Cyrus, General Askar, Clover, Kyril, Tigria, Elara, and a smattering of people both from the regular military and Catra's Vanguard (which was composed primarily of cave folk who had been influenced by Adora). Most notable in her absence was Catra. Not only was she not coming on this mission, she wasn't even *aware* of it since stopping her from coming would be all but impossible if she was..

The reasons for this were multitudinous. Catra was the Crown Princess of Halfmoon and thus it wouldn't do to risk her life on a mission like this no matter the goal or her connection to it. In fact, it was *because* of her connection to the mission that she couldn't come seeing as how she would be emotionally compromised. Furthermore, King Cyrus didn't want to get Catra's hopes up on the off chance that the entire mission was a failure in one way or another.

"Alright, everyone. We have approximately ten minutes until we teleport in so I want to go over the plan one last time," King, no, *General* Cyrus began from where he stood in front of the group. "We'll be teleporting into the heart of the main Horde compound. Once there, we'll cause as much havoc and pandemonium as we possibly can until we've either secured Adora or a retreat is sounded. After that, we regroup and teleport back home. Understood?"

There was a chorus of "Yes, sir"s before General Cyrus continued.

"Each of you have been placed in three-person teams. You are to stick with your team at all times. This *isn't* a suicide mission so I don't want anyone running off playing heroics. If you start to get overwhelmed, fall back. If one of your team gets injured, fall back. If any of the enemy's generals or Hordak appears, *fall back.* I want all of us to come back alive today. Am I clear?"

Another chorus of "Yes, sir"s.

"That being said, you all know the risks. For as skilled and well-equipped as everyone in this room is, we'll be teleporting into perhaps the most dangerous place on Etheria. There's a chance that not everyone in this room will make it out alive and, for that, I am sorry. Just know that you're fighting for a good cause and that anyone who you may leave behind *will* be taken good care of. You have my word.

"The Horde has taken much from us over the years but it's time that we take something back. This mission is about more than getting Adora back, it's about sending a message. It's about showing them that Halfmoon not only stands but will fight fang and claw to keep those we hold dear. Am I understood?"

"Sir, yes, sir!"

"Good. Sorcerers, prepare to teleport in five. Everyone, may the Stars Above guide us and may the Fires Below protect us."

Under a Smog-Filled Sky

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Clover blinked hard as the teleportation spell faded, the air crackled with the discharged power. She took only the briefest of moments to acknowledge the pandemonium that the base was already in before starting to move.

There was a small squad nearby, startled by the sudden appearance of twenty Magicats, so Clover started with them. She charged the nearest one down, brushing their weapon out of the way before tearing their throat out with her claws. As she was

doing this, Kyril and Tigria, her squadmates, were half a step behind her and executed two more with brutal efficiency.

By this time, the last member of the patrol managed to raise their blaster but Clover weaved out of the way before lashing out with a rising spiral kick that nearly took their right hand off. This opened the soldier up to Tigria rushing in and finishing them off with a spinning slash that cleanly removed their head.

With the immediate threat cleared, Clover wasted no time in getting a move on, trusting her partners to keep up with her. The initial task assigned to them was a simple one: the destruction of one of the fuel depots. However, the fuel depot was practically on the other side of the base from where they teleported in which was precisely why it had been assigned to her squad. The three of them had trained as extensively as they could together and were perhaps the best fighters in the strike force outside of Generals Cyrus and Askar.

Already, blaster fire was starting to saturate the air and another squad stood in their way and opened fire, forcing them to dodge and weave. Clover dropped to all fours to increase her speed and was on the lead soldier in an instant. Her enchanted claws tore through their armor like it wasn't even there, leaving a bloody gash in their side before the follow-up roundhouse kick to their jaw snapped their neck.

Kyril was the first to catch up, his blade cleanly slicing through another soldier's blaster rifle before a backfist opened them up enough to be run through.

Meanwhile, Clover grabbed the arm of another and quickly snapped it with a palm strike to the elbow before tossing them at Tigria who sliced through their head with a flash of her blade before impaling the last alongside her brother.

A group of bots were in their way next and Clover was once again the first to reach them. She managed to get close enough to take out the camera of one of them with her claws before being

forced to jump back to avoid getting shot by two more. As her squadmates caught up and began drawing fire, Clover flipped over her bot and started tearing through its back as quickly as she could before tearing out enough wiring that it shut down.

While she was doing this, Kyril and Tigria caught another bot in a pincer attack that took out its legs before engaging their own bots. The armored plating of the bots proved no match for their enchanted blades as they were summarily cut down while Clover clawed out the wiring of the one they had crippled.

Their path now clear, Kyril and Tigria sheathed their blades so that way all three of them could drop to all fours for maximum speed. They shot across the yard, dodging blaster fire and enemy combatants as they went. Their goal was to cause further havoc, not rout the enemy after all.

It didn't take them long to reach the fuel depot at their speed (they knew where it was thanks to a map that Rogelio had drawn up). Clover burst through the door and yelped as she had to immediately dip out again when several people opened fire at her. Tigria and Kyril took up positions against the wall opposite of Clover.

"What's the plan?" Kyril asked, shouting to be heard over the roar of suppressing fire. Clover glanced around the area until she spotted a window higher up near the roof of a lower building

"I go high! Once I'm in position, grenade out to force them down and I'll bust in to draw their fire! That should give you two the opening you need! Return fire until then!" Clover ordered.

"Roger!" Kyril and Tigria said as they drew their blasters. Kyril took Clover's place and the two began to return fire.

While that was going on, Clover booked it to a stack of crates near the neighboring building. She jumped and bounded off the side of them to grab a horizontal flag pole before using her

momentum to flip off of it to get enough height to grab the edge of the roof.

Clover scrambled onto the roof and took the briefest of moments to reorient herself and catch her breath before being forced to drop prone as some soldiers on the ground spotted her and opened fire. Needing to buy herself some breathing room, Clover removed one of her grenades from her belt and primed it before tossing it in their general direction. Once it exploded, she used that cover to dash forward on all fours, crossing the length of the roof in the matter of mere moments.

Once at the edge of the roof nearest the window, Clover jumped with everything she had and brought her legs up while crossing her arms over her face. “Now!” she screamed midair and the sound of Clover crashing through the glass was shortly followed by another explosion as a grenade went off.

Now on the catwalks, Clover sprinted to the nearest soldier and brushed their blaster aside before grabbing the back of their helmet and slamming their head into the railing as hard as she could. She did it twice more until blood came away. Instead of dropping the body, she pulled it in front of her to block the blaster fire from another soldier. Once it stopped, she discarded the body and rushed the other soldier down on all fours, knocking them to the ground with a flying tackle.

To their credit, the soldier didn’t let this slow them down as they tried to deck Clover in the face. It was a wasted effort, however, as Clover grabbed that hand and dug her claws into it before pulling away. The soldier screamed in pain but they didn’t suffer for long as a quick claw swipe to their throat took them out.

Clover took a moment to catch her breath and wipe the blood from her hands. Kyril and Tigria had managed to breach the fuel depot and had taken out a number of soldiers. There weren’t many left in the place now but they wouldn’t have long until reinforcements arrived. They needed to blow this place now.

"Tigria, set the charges!" Clover called out in *Aiilayra* (which everyone in the strike force was speaking in) before making her way back over to the window. She peered through it and spied two squads of troops and a group of bots making their way over. "We've got incoming!"

"Charges set!" Tigria called out while Kyril said, "There's another way out over here!"

Not wanting to waste the time it'd take to get to a ladder, Clover leaped over the railing and dug her claws into the wall to slow her descent before pushing off and landing in a roll. She then dashed over to where the brother-sister duo were waiting by a different door. Once they were through it and a bit away, Tigria triggered the detonator on the charges.

Several massive explosions tore through the air, the sound deafening to Clover's sensitive ears as she felt the shock wave pass through her. She shook her head to try and clear the ringing from her ears as they rounded the corner of another building and ran straight into more troops led by a Fishwoman wearing an eye patch.

"Looks like I'll finally get to skin one of you damn cats…"

Under a Smog-Filled Sky

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Cyrus shot across the compound like a stray bolt of lightning, his destination and mission clear. It took him no time at all to reach the Dark Temple and he activated the enchantments in his

swords to superheat the edges before slicing through the front door like a hot knife through butter. The champions in the entry hallway who had been on their way didn't fare much better.

He came out into what appeared to be a mess hall and was instantly beset by multiple champions. Cyrus snarled as he casually weaved through their attacks, slaying one after another with contemptuous ease. These may be some of the best fighters that the Horde had (or were in training to be such) but none of them could so much as touch him thanks to a combination of his superlative skill and his innate magics enhancing his speed and reaction time.

Once the last champion(in-training) was dealt with, Cyrus went down a certain hallway. While Rogelio had been unable to provide them with a detailed map of the Dark Temple, he *had* been able to draw a map of the routes leading to key places where Adora should be.

The first place that Cyrus checked was the training ground where Adora trained with some assassin that had nearly killed Hordak and Shadow Weaver a number of years back. When Cyrus came to it, the first thing he noticed was that it looked a *lot* like Askar's *tenemos.* The second thing that he noticed were the signs of fighting and spellwork that were recent. Between that and Adora's lingering scent, he was confident that his missing future daughter-in-law *had* been in here fairly recently and had been in a serious fight with a sorcerer.

The outcome of the fight was unclear, however.

While Adora's scent didn't go back that way, Cyrus went ahead and checked out the room on the opposite side. He came across a small bedroom with the remains of what might have been a trunk but Adora's scent wasn't anywhere in this room.

Turning back around, Cyrus made to leave when he was intercepted by, of all things, a Snakeman from Eternia. The Snakeman fired a glob of acid spit at him but he casually side

stepped it before rushing him down. The Snakeman tried his best to defend against Cyrus' twin blades with his four but the Snakeman soon found his blades cut cleanly in half. He then found his hands severed from his arms before his head was severed from his body.

Now that Cyrus clearly had Adora's scent, he followed it back down the twisting hallways and back into the mess hall. More champions and a number of sorcerers had congregated there again so Cyrus was forced to do battle once more. Once the room was clear once more, he focused on trying to pick Adora's scent back up. It was hard to single out Adora's scent beneath the other scents suffusing the air but Cyrus was nothing if not an expert tracker.

Cyrus followed Adora's scent back out of the Dark Temple only to come to a stop as he saw a squad of *tanks* getting into position, causing him to growl in frustration. He *wanted* to follow Adora's scent and end the mission as soon as possible but those tanks would tear through his people like wet tissue paper. While some of them could *probably* handle a tank or two, Cyrus absolutely *could* and thus he *had* to.

Cyrus charged the nearest tank and let his innate magics flare full-blast as its turret turned to get a bead on him. A stream of blaster bolts shot out at him but his twin swords became a blur as he cut each bolt that would have hit him out of the air. The tank then fired its main cannon at him but that proved to be counterproductive when Cyrus sliced the cannon shell cleanly in half, the halves shooting past him to explode chunks out of the Dark Temple.

By this point, the other tanks had come to a stop and were starting to train their guns on him but it was too late. Putting on a burst of speed, Cyrus crossed the remaining distance between him and the closest tank in an instant, his swords cutting one of the treads to pieces. He then kicked one of the pieces of the tread into the air before a spin kick sent it flying down the barrel of another tank.

Cyrus jumped on top of the tank just as its hatch was starting to open and he took out the gunner before they could so much as even blink. Before the gunner's body could even start to fall, Cyrus reached down and pressed the primer on one of the grenades on their belt before slamming the hatch closed and backflipping away only to land on top of the next tank.

Cyrus ducked behind the second tank's turret just as the first one exploded. The turret of the tank he was standing on started to move so Cyrus quickly sheathed one of his swords before cutting off the barrel of the main cannon. He then pulled out one of his own grenades and hit the primer before shoving it down the remains of the barrel and diving off of it.

He was out of place to take cover behind the third and final tank so he drew his second sword as he retreated and proceeded to cut the shrapnel out of the air once it exploded.

That left one last tank, the one he had kicked the tread into, and Cyrus couldn't help but smirk as it was *running away.* He didn't let it get far, however, as he chased it down and jumped on top of it before slicing off the hatch. He dropped down into it and quickly took out its occupants before shoving the body of the driver out of the seat and taking over the controls.

While Cyrus had never driven a Horde tank before, he figured out the controls quickly enough and proceeded to ram the thing into the front of Dark Temple at full speed. Once it was inside, he grabbed one of the soldiers' grenades and climbed out of the wreckage before priming the grenade and dropping it back in. He then booked it out of the place on all fours and let a savage grin spread across his face as the tank exploded in a truly spectacular fashion.

With the tanks (and Dark Temple) dealt with, Cyrus turned his attention back to tracking Adora. He was *going* to get Adora out of here no matter what it took. He wasn't sure if he'd be able to look Catra and Kesi in the face if he failed.

Under a Smog-Filled Sky

The Main Horde Compound

The Fright Zone

Etheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Clover snarled at the Fishwoman and her troops. This was bad. The Fishwoman had the markings of a champion and was wielding a nasty-looking whip and a serrated knife. The chances were good that the soldiers with her were among the Horde's elite and wouldn't be complete pushovers like the ones that they'd encountered thus far.

Running away wasn't an option, as much as Clover wished that it were. Several of the soldiers already had blasters trained on them and Clover wasn't in the mood to test their aim. Since running away was out, that left fighting them.

Clover went into this wanting a good fight and something told her that she was about to get one.

"You two handle the troops. Leave the Fishwoman to me," Clover ordered. Of the three, she was easily the best one-on-one fighter and the Fishwoman was almost certainly the most dangerous.

"Roger!" the brother-sister duo said before the three of them charged.

Clover dodged the first lash of the Fishwoman's whip and then the second before getting close enough to lash out with her claws. The Fishwoman was fast, however, as she brought her arm up to catch the blow before countering with a gut punch that Clover danced backward to avoid.

This gave the Fishwoman room to also back up and lash out with her whip again but Clover was ready. She held up an arm and let the whip wrap around it before grabbing. She then readied her claws to cut through it but realized her mistake a moment too late as the Fishwoman smirked and flipped a switch on the handle.

Green energy coursed through the whip and Clover couldn't suppress the scream of pain that tore out of her throat as she was electrocuted. The Fishwoman then yanked her whip forward, causing Clover to faceplant into the ground.

"That the best you got, ya damn cat⁉" the Fishwoman taunted as she pulled her whip back before lashing out again. Clover breathed through the pain and managed to roll out of the way in time, the electrified whip scoring the uncaring ground.

"Not even close," Clover returned after she steadied her breathing and kipped up. She then started to step side to side, her arms crossing her face in time with her steps.

"You wanna dance, cat? Then let's see you dance!" The Fishwoman lashed out with a lightning-fast series of strikes but Clover had gotten a read on her rhythm. She weaved between the lashes, keeping her steps light as she almost literally danced through the assault.

While Clover was currently all but untouchable, the situation was untenable. She couldn't dodge the onslaught of lashes while also closing the gap; any strides that Clover took to get closer, the Fishwoman easily countered by just stepping back. It was a war of attrition and it wasn't one that Clover thought that she could win. Even if she *could,* she didn't have the time for it.

Given that, Clover instead gave herself over to the controlled chaos of the fight and let her body twist and turn on pure instinct as she waited and watched. There were patterns that every fighter followed, forms and stances that they used. Properly utilized, these forms provided no opening with which to capitalize

on. The path to victory usually lay in breaking those forms in one way or another.

Clover had fought many people of that skill level over her life. With most of them, her unusual fighting style was usually enough to throw them off balance eventually and let her win. Against the truly skilled, however, against people like Adora and the one time she had sparred with General Cyrus, an unusual fighting style wasn't nearly sufficient. In those cases, in order to break your opponent's flow, you needed to do something that they wouldn't expect or, even better, went opposite of their expectations.

While this Fishwoman was *nowhere* near that skill level, Clover found herself in a similar position regardless. She needed something to throw the Fishwoman off of her game—

Clover's thoughts came to a screeching halt as a blaster bolt from one of the soldiers Kyril and Tigria were fighting caught her in the shoulder. While it failed to penetrate her armor, it threw her off her flow enough for the Fishwoman's whip to catch her ankle.

Clover screamed in pain as her leg gave out from under her. Her instincts were sharp enough to transition her tumble into a roll, making the whip that would have hit her head just barely graze her tail instead.

As she rolled, Clover drew the blaster from her belt and came out of her roll in a crouch. Almost without aiming, she fired off several shots and a pained smile came to her face when one caught the Fishwoman in the hand, forcing her to drop her whip.

As Clover got to her feet, taking care to not put too much weight on her bad ankle while also ignoring the stinging pain in her tail, she let her smile turn a touch vicious as she noticed the brother-sister duo finishing up the last of the random soldiers. While Clover was in no state to win this fight on her own, it was about to become a three-on-one.

"All units, retreat! I repeat: all units, retreat!" General Cyrus' voice came over the comms. Clover frowned. The General-King didn't *sound* victorious. Had the mission failed?

It didn't matter. The order had been given and all that was left was to carry it out. Clover fired off one last shot at the whip, knocking it away from the Fishwoman's grasp as Kyril ran up to her, sheathing his sword.

"I'm carrying you out," he said in a tone that would brook no argument. Clover didn't even try to fight as he picked her up in a fireman's carry. Her pride burned like hot bile at the back of her throat but Kyril would be faster carrying her than she would be trying to walk on a bad ankle and it wouldn't get her yelled at by Healer Lenio later.

Leaving the cursing Fishwoman behind, the three quickly made their way back to where they teleported in and what they saw made the order to retreat suddenly make sense.

Reinforcements had arrived, all of them bearing the insignia of Knight-Captain Lonnie Leor. The strike team had all gathered together and Clover could see that several were dead and even more were injured.

Who she *didn't* see was Adora. The mission had failed.

Once everyone was together, General Cyrus gave the order and the remaining sorcerers teleported them out of the Fright Zone and back to Halfmoon.

The War Room

Halfmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Cyrus pinched the ridge of his nose and swore quietly to himself. He wanted to scream, to yell, to take his helmet off and throw it on the ground in impotent rage but he did none of those things. He was a General and he was a King. He needed to stand as an example for his people.

Of the twenty people that had comprised the strike force, five were dead and ten were varying levels of injured, including Askar. Medics had been on stand-by to treat the wounded and carry out the dead. Most of the wounded had already been taken to the infirmary leaving only Cyrus and a few others in the war room.

Cyrus hadn't needed to say anything to let everyone know that the mission had been a failure. They were supposed to have come home with their heads held high and with Adora back where she belonged but, instead, they had been forced to retreat with their tails between their legs. The only hope that they had was that Duncan was certain that he had seen someone named Scorpia leaving on a skiff and that she wouldn't have left without Adora.

How was he supposed to face his daughter and Kesi now? Catra would be simultaneously *furious* and heartbroken. He couldn't even *begin* to predict Kesi's reaction.

He also didn't know how he was going to face *his wife.* Time and time again, Cyrus had promised to her that he'd get Adora and bring her back home but he had broken that promise.

Cyrus was many things and it seemed that "oath-breaker" had now been added to the list.

As if *that* weren't enough, Cyrus had returned to find the place in pure pandemonium. Before he had sounded the retreat, Cyrus had felt the flare of magic coming from somewhere in the Horde base but he could feel that flare here, too. Magic was heavy in the air, almost choking as it swirled about them. He couldn't even

begin to imagine what caused it but *something* must have set the Spirit Ember off.

Cyrus rushed out of the war room and through the halls of the palace, needing to get to the royal hall as soon as possible. While he was no sorcerer, even *he* could feel the magic of the ley lines overflowing, throwing raw magic into the air. Despite having no connection to the Spirit Ember, something in his gut told him that it was *angry.* But why? And at what?

Cyrus shook his head to clear it of such thoughts. Those things were beyond him. If he knew his wife (and he liked to think that he did), she was already on her down to commune with it. She'd find out what was going on and if it was something fixable.

Arriving in the royal hall, Cyrus looked to the throne and saw Caspin there along with Kesi, Percival, and Cloudfoot. There were also a fair number of Vanguard, nearly the entire Royal Guard, and twice as many of the Palace Guard as usual.

"PAPA!" Caspin shouted once they saw him, dropping on all fours to run to him. Cyrus grabbed his child and picked him up, holding him close. He could feel Caspin trembling and smell the fear on him.

"Perci, what's going on?" Cyrus asked as he approached the throne.

"We don't know, Your Majesty," Percival answered. "Her Majesty, Her Highness, and Captain Kittrina have all left for the Spirit Ember to commune with it. The city is currently on lock down in case this is an attack and Dr. Lenio went out to the Dark Lake to secure the wards there in case it's the Fishfolk's doing."

At least that explained why Lenio hadn't been with the other medics when they got back.

"It's not. At least, I don't *think* it is. Something happened to the Black Garnet a little while ago as well," Cyrus revealed as he took his seat.

“How do you know that?” Caspin asked.

Cyrus weighed the pros and cons of telling them now versus telling them later and settled on getting it at least partly over with. “Because I was in the Fright Zone just a couple minutes ago. A strike team and I went to try and rescue Adora.”

Kesi sucked in a sharp breath, her ears pinning back as her tail lashed. “Did you…?” She apparently couldn’t bring herself to voice the question.

Cyrus shook his head sadly and he cursed his failure thrice over as he watched the hope and most of the life flee Kesi’s eyes as her ears and tail drooped. Caspin wasn’t faring much better as they looked up at him with their ears pinned back and tears in his eyes.

“You didn’t save ‘Dora?” Caspin asked, his voice small.

Cyrus took a deep breath to steel himself before saying, “I didn’t. But we have reason to believe that she escaped the Fright Zone with Princess Scorpia of the Nest.” At that, Caspin broke down crying, hiding his face in their father’s neck even as Cyrus cursed himself once more.

“M-Maybe…” Kesi began haltingly. “M-Maybe… the Spirit Ember will… show Catra where she is?” It was clear that she was desperately trying to cling on to any bit of hope that she could.

“We can only pray,” Cyrus said, his tone resigned as he petted his child’s mane. “We can only pray.”

Chapter End Notes

Let it be known that we are inclusive with our writing. We gave you some husband-wife fluff to appeal to the straights.

What, exactly, happened that forced the Magicats into a retreat and resulted in the mission being a failure? You'll have to wait for Chapters 8 and 9 of KotFZ to find out. This story is

about the heroes of Halfmoon and thus the focus was on them.

Also, to make it perfectly clear here, Duncan is now in Halfmoon.

Chapter 11: Fallout

Chapter Summary

The aftermath of a failed assualt on the Fright Zone leads to new possibilities and horrible dreams.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra's Bedroom

Halfmoon Palace

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

The dream had started as so many of them did, with the two of them lying side-by-side staring into each other's eyes, the canopy of Catra's bed providing shelter from the outside world. She was giggling about something, a purr rumbling through her, like only Adora could draw it out from her.

Adora's laugh was loud and crisp in her ears, the little snort at the end made her heart skip a beat. If she buried herself close, she could smell her. Adora opened her mouth to respond to whatever she had said a moment ago—what had she said? But, instead of her normal dorky response that wasn't funny, she hacked and coughed. Catra pulled back to stare at her as blood dribbled from her lips. She coughed again and tried to say something but another gob of blood rose up her throat and splattered onto the bedroom floor.

"Stars, Adora, stop talking." She felt the bile rise in her own throat, and Adora ignored her, trying again to speak and more blood flowed, like her throat had been cut. It stained her white compression top that she wore often when training, soaking the thing to a deep scarlet colour, and still she kept speaking. "Adora, please, please stop," she begged. She reached out trying to grab Adora and shake her, maybe she could heal her if her own magic couldn't.

As her fingers went to grab onto Adora's shoulder, they passed right through, her body fading to mist, except for her eyes, piercing blue, staring at her in fear and anger. The blood which coated the floor and her own front still felt sticky and hot against her fur.

She startled upright. She wasn't in her room. Around her, the stone was replaced with deep red wood, her bed with a hammock. She had no idea where she was. Where Adora was, a handful of small motes of light danced in the air. Glancing around, the room was similar to her own, larger slightly, with a single stone wall. The motes of light moved over to that wall and playfully spun around the doorway on the wall.

She stepped out into a long corridor that felt much more familiar. This could be her home except for windows looking out not onto a cavern but a great forest with trees that blocked out the sky. Faint natural light filtered down through the canopy. She could see shapes moving below, the shadowy figure of Magicats slinking amongst the trees, but the square below that she knew should be full of people was empty.

She turned, following the wandering lights that were Adora as they headed along the great corridor. She wandered, staring at portraits on the walls, dozens of them, all familiar and forgotten. It was only when she came to a grand portrait that she stopped and stared.

Before her was an image burned into her brain since childhood. Regal and tall, the painting was unmistakably the first

Magical Queen, wearing her brother's blood soaked crown upon her head, her direct ancestor. Queen Elasha, who descended into Subtheria to bond with the Spirit Ember. She knew the legend taught to her on her mother's knee all those years ago. Of the first queen rebelling against her brother Carnivus and being led to the warrior She-Ra. The one to whom Adora and Kesi both swore allegiance and devotion.

She never truly believed in it. Hokey religions and ancient magic swords weren't as useful as a good staff at her side at beating the Horde. But the two of them truly believed and, staring up at her ancestor, she could believe, too, for just a moment. She stood above a doorway built into the roots of the ancient blood tree that the place was built around. She could only be in one place, she realized: Old Halfmoon's Palace, before the burning. The motes of light went through the doorway and down out of her sight.

She followed, stepping down on the long stairway she did recognise the path to the Spirit Ember. She was halfway down when she heard weeping. Sitting on the floor, tail wrapped around herself was Kesi, not in her usual cave culture outfit but an ill-fitting robe, one of the Celestial Promise vacant high priestess positions. Her arms were wrapped tightly around herself and she sobbed.

Catra's feet picked up speed until she was sprinting towards her, and as she ran, she could hear around her the great roaring of a fire, the screams of those who had fallen during the burning of Halfmoon and since, and a voice laughing at the destruction. Kesi's ears were flattened against the roaring fire, and she only turned her gaze at the last moment to spot Catra rushing across the tiled stones growing burning hot under her feet.

Kesi turned, her hand reaching out from the fabric, stretching against something holding her in place, a darkness that tried to snuff out her light unseen by everyone, even Catra. Only the motes of light tried to fight it off. She was in pain and terrified;

Catra was terrified for her. Their fingers touched, and the world became light and pain.

Everything around them turned into a sickly green, washed of all other colours. The world smelt of ash and char, not even each other's scents could clear it from their skin. The only sound either of them could hear was the roaring fire and a laughter, otherworldly and arrogant.

When the two of them awoke, ash still clung to their fur, staining both of them, but they were lying on a ground warped by magic in unnatural ways. She was clutching onto Kesi like her life depended on it—perhaps it did…

Magic raged around them like a storm, and the two of them were far from Halfmoon at its epicenter. The walls around her were a dull magenta metal, and at the center of the room stood the Black Garnet—her history lessons taught her about it, the RuneStone of the Empire of the Nest. The RuneStone of Change had rendered madness upon the world with the Emperor of the Nest attempting to bond with it as no man had done before. No one knew why he fell to such madness, now it was in the hands of a greater evil: the Horde, and specifically the witch Shadow Weaver. She registered all of that as a sorceress of training and skill should, but her focus was turned to follow Kesi's gaze.

On the floor, back bloody, face streaked with tears, was Adora. She wept openly. Even breathing seemed to be an agony. She did not notice them until they took a pained step towards her.

When she looked up at the two of them, her eyes were rimmed red with tears and confusion. She opened her mouth. "Why do I know you?"

The shock almost hit Catra like a hammerblow. "It's us, Adora." The blank look of pain on her face made her heart break all over again. "It's us. Your khai'tel. *We're supposed to be together until the very end."*

Kesi wrapped herself around Adora like a blanket, golden light poured around her, like the wings of a mother bird shielding her young from a terrible storm. The wounds across Adora's back began to glow.

"I don't know who you are… I'm sorry, I know…" her hands went up to her head and the sobs redoubled. "I know I love you… But I can't…"

Around her, the chamber grew dim, lights flickering out one by one. A shadow stalked the halls of the Fright Zone and was coming to rip apart their love. "Please, Adora," she heard herself begging, "if you can't remember us, please just remember to survive. Promise me you'll stay alive. I'll come find you. I swear it. I am coming to take you home."

Adora stared at her, her breath hitching. "I can't. I think I might already be…"

"No! I won't accept that! Adora, stay alive. I will fight through everything to reach you."

"It's too late; she has me. She's never letting go." The shadows drew tighter around her, dampening even Kesi's light which could only falter feebly against such strength. Kesi's mouth opened in a silent scream and she faded away like mist.

A new voice, sharp with anger. "You will become my champion; no longer will you defy me." Adora cringed back from it, fear gripping her, then she took a breath, and pushed herself to her knees. Catra rose with her, clutching her shoulders. The crash of thunder, the crackle of lightning, and the roar of fire all filled the chamber. Yet Adora was at peace, like she got when into her stance, emptied of fear.

The terrifying voice was quieted as she rose, golden light flowing around Adora like a cascade, and the Shadows fled. Another voice joined the chorus of deafening noise. Synthetic and strange.

"Etheria seeks a champion. Will you honour its call?" Adora could only nod as she pushed herself further to her feet.

"Then Rise, She-Ra, Princess of Power."

Catra's Bedroom

Halfmoon Palace

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Catra awoke to a roiling heat and the pressure from before a storm, magic roared through the air like a dragon. It was oppressive, her own connection to the RuneStone beneath her feet flared and her bedroom was aflame. Pinning her arms to her side was Kesi, the older girl was holding her wrists down as her claws flexed in the air coated in a faint layer of flame.

"Catra, please breathe." Kesi was on top of her trying to calm her down, long white hair hanging loose down over her head under the cramped confines of the bed. "Deep breaths, it's okay, we're okay, she's okay." She sounded more like she was trying to convince herself than convince Catra. Around her, the edges of the sheets crumbled from the heat emanating from Catra. She felt like she would be sick.

She took a long, shuddering breath. "I'm okay." She let go of the small spell she had unconsciously cast; it would never hurt Kesi but it did damage the room. "I'm fine." She felt Kesi let go of her wrists and she brought them up to wrap around her, burying her face into Kesi's shoulder. "She has to be okay," she whispered to her, "she has to…"

The door opened suddenly. Lyra rushed in, wearing a hastily assembled shirt and dress. She was clearly distressed, her ears

pinned back and tail lashing. Her nose wrinkled at the smell of burning silk. Her own distress was replaced by her worry for Catra, rushing to her. Kesi rolled off of her and bowed with a hasty "Your Majesty." Kesi was rarely embarrassed by her body, but with the Queen finding her and her daughter naked together in bed a blush crept up her cheeks visible under her white fur.

Lyra barely spared Kesi a glance. She would normally find such situations something to tease her daughter over, today though everything involving magic had gone wrong. The Spirit Ember burned with power unlike anything she had seen since before fathers had died. She averted her gaze for her daughter and her lover's comfort and said, "Put some clothes on, we need to leave quickly."

Catra slipped on her shirt. As Kesi helped her into her clothes, she tried to calm her rapidly beating heart. *What was that dream? Adora was in pain, she had forgotten them both? Why had she seen the old Halfmoon? What was that voice laughing in her dreams? Why did the vision mention She-Ra?* All these thoughts rattled around in her head. She wouldn't let the fear grip her, she was a sorceress of the Lost Temple, the Crown Princess of Halfmoon. She would rescue Adora no matter what happened. Once this crisis was resolved, she would petition Papa to take her back to the Fright Zone and she would burn that Shadow from her *khai'tel*.

"What's happening, Mama?" Kesi tied the lace at the back of her robe. She was going to investigate a disturbance in the Spirit Ember; she would do so as a sorceress of the Lost Temple. One of the youngest to ever graduate. "I felt the shift in the Spirit Ember in my sleep… in my dreams."

Lyra looked over her daughter, gently adjusting her robe as Kesi stepped away to get dressed herself. "I don't know." Her tail lashed in fear and anxiety, a gesture Catra recognised because she did it herself. "Your father, he went off on a dangerous mission, and I have been up all night worrying myself over it.

Then the Spirit Ember awoke with power like nothing I have seen in nearly twenty years."

Catra looked at her mama quizzically. She had only heard that the Spirit Ember had flared a few times before but not in her mama's lifetime. "When you were an infant, it did something, as if it was channeling all the magic of Etheria through it for a moment. It was the night you started sleeping under the bed instead of on it. I rushed to find you while your grandfather went down to look into it. Now we need to go and find it. Melog can come, maybe they'll know something." The cat-like creature's ears were flattened against their head like they could hear the magic coiling around them all.

Kesi returned in her normal outfit hastily thrown on, and handed Catra her staff. Feeling the comforting weight in her hands, she nodded to her mama then turned to Kesi. "You should come. We need to talk about…" she gestured to under her bed. Behind her shoulder, Lyra raised an eyebrow. Kesi's eyes shot wide open then she shook her head.

"I have to go talk to my great grandmother, she might know something. She needs to be told." She looked at Catra as if silently asking her a question. She nodded to Kesi. "About Adora and the rest of the dream. We can compare later." She leaned forwards and kissed Catra on the cheek before hurrying off.

Lyra smiled down at her and Catra felt a blush rising on her cheeks, glaring at her mama with a "Not a word" which only caused Lyra to chuckle at her and the two of them set off.

The two of them made swift work through the palace towards the secret entrance down to the Lost Temple where the Spirit Ember rested, stopped only by Percival. He pulled out his tablet and showed her something that caused everyone to stop where they were.

"Are you sure these are accurate?" she heard her mama asking. "Kesi will see it as soon as she enters. Damn it. Get Kelara

up here to explain it as soon as she's able. Then get Kesi back up here so she can explain it better than Kelara to Catra probably. When Cy gets back, he can get Adora down to the Temple quickly enough" Catra's ear perked up. Papa had gone looking for Adora… without her.

Did he not trust her? She was a Princess, she could handle the Horde; she had trained under Askar how to fight. They didn't think she could do it? She turned on her heel to stare at the two of them and Mama was already moving over to her and she pulled her into a fierce hug.

"He didn't want your heart to break if he failed," she whispered, anticipating her question, "and we both didn't want you to put yourself at greater risk. You would have tried to burn down the Fright Zone to get to her; I would, too. Your father is a man of focus, he will get the job done and nothing more." She brushed a hand through Catra's hair trying to soothe her. "He'll bring her home, he promised." She felt herself relax then. Her papa never lied about a promise.

"We should get down to the Spirit Ember," she heard herself saying. "Percival, go help Caspin, they're in command until we get back." Squaring her shoulders, she looked at Lyra, trying to muster up every bit of Princess authority she could find in her soul. "Let's find out what's happening."

The Lost Temple

Halfmoon Palace

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

The doors opened to Catra as they had done for years now; she had a theory in the pit of her stomach as to why. She-Ra, the legendary warrior goddess, a chosen one who always sacrificed everything for the sake of the world. She had grown up hearing the legends. The doors would open to a spell from one bonded to the Spirit Ember or imbued with celestial magic, but to her they opened at a word.

They had done so since her near death experience in the park so many years ago. She had wondered about it, she had even once asked Adora about it and her love had laughed and told her she didn't want to think about it. No one was laughing now.

Melog pranced through the doors towards the Spirit Ember and nestled down for a long evening of waiting. They understood the importance of ritual but had basically no patience for it. So, whenever Catra got engrossed in some spell, they would take a nice, long nap and wait for her to be done. This time, though, they kept one eye open and focused on her from where they lounged.

The Spirit Ember burned with the heat of a long lost star; the very air close to it shimmered with heat haze so great she could feel her robes begin to curl away from it even from across the room. Her connection shielded her from the worst of it, but she had no doubt that anyone else would have been cooked from the sheer presence of the RuneStone at the moment.

The two of them set about their rituals—they would connect to the RuneStone later, once it was safer. For now, there was a series of tests that could be run to determine what was causing such a powerful change within the heart of the RuneStone.

As the seconds from the scan ran into minutes, everything started to settle. The spells pinged back to her and Lyra at the same time. It was channeling huge quantities of magic somewhere on Etheria. She tried to follow the path of magic, and it led to exactly what she feared: the magic was flowing to the Fright Zone. The heat and power began to ebb away, the room

cooling to a particularly hot day in the Crimson Waste from a baking oven.

She could feel it, even if she didn't know what it was, just the passing of some sensation, as if she could reach out and grasp that fading power and it would show her something. Melog was suddenly up against her while Lyra was staring at her own readings as she transferred them onto her tablet via a crystal. Before her mama could stop her, she reached out with one hand and touched the Spirit Ember.

Heat shot through her and the last thing she saw was the ceiling of the temple and the stone statues of the winged Osirians staring down impassively at her.

She awoke in a clearing surrounded by trees. The daymoon was setting, sending the place into an eerie twilight, but the fragrant smells of burning moonleaf and other flowers filled the night air. She pushed herself to her feet and around her were clear signs of decay: plants falling at the stem, trees with rot seeped into them. She turned to look at the devastation. Etherians milled around and at the center of the clearing was a young woman with platinum blonde hair wearing next to nothing. Her hands were clasped in prayer in front of a large pink stone; she recognised it from her studies *The Hearts Blossom*. She watched as the woman continued her silent prayer and around it roots and vines grew seemingly unaffected by the blight. As she took a step closer, she found she was falling through the soft underbrush.

She landed on hard crystal flooring. She could feel the warmth was being sapped from her bones, the inverse of her own RuneStone. She looked at the great hovering shape of *The Fractal Flake*. Her breath misted in the air. Unlike the last vision, this one had only a single occupant: a young girl, barely older than Caspin, was resting on a pillar of ice, gently stroking the RuneStone like it was a stressed pet and not a shard of near infinite power. Like the last vision, she didn't seem to notice Catra or her presence. The girl was the Princess of Snows, but it would be at least half a decade before she would be old enough to bond to her

RuneStone, so why was she down here with it? A question she feared she may never get the answer for, especially if she froze to death. She turned away from the Flake.

She was standing on the deck of a boat deep into some great sea. She couldn't see the RuneStone. Instead, she saw a clear sight that made her blood run cold: a great and terrible storm raged around them, throwing the ship this way and that. She heard them before she spotted anything amiss, staring as she was at a tidal wave easily eight times the height of the boat she was on and wondering if she died in this vision would she die on the floor of the Temple. Before the wave could crash into the boat, it split down the center, allowing the ship to pass safely through it. Over her shoulder she heard a pair of voices.

"Uhhh… This was not how this was supposed to go!" the voice sounded exasperated. The answering voice she recognised instantly.

"Beloved, I wish I could control the seas to set them calm, but I am sure our hosts will understand the roughness of the weather." Sea Hawk answered. He had denied allegations of his relationship with the Princess of Salineas, but there was no one else he could be talking to.

"They better, someone there might have answers. Sorcerers from Mystacor were supposed to be in attendance and I can't just swim back. It'll ruin this dress." Catra turned to see Mermista was wearing a fine silk dress that she recognised from Lieur's tailors. Sea Hawk had asked for recommendations when last he was around and she saw no reason to deny him. She opened her mouth to laugh and another wave crashed down upon her, leaving her soaking wet and sprawled on the floor of the deck.

She was no longer on the deck. Instead, she was lying on warm marble, still shivering off the freezing wind of the Fractal Flake and the biting chill of being soaked down to the bone.

The sky above her was reaching the evening, turning a miraculous shade of pink like she had never seen. Around her was the bustle of a city that could rival Halfmoon. She was high above it all, on an enormous tower. Above her stood the *MoonStone* she could see its wielder, Queen Angella, was focusing her own magics onto it as it blazed with light. She had to close her eyes from the blinding corona yet the Queen was unaffected.

She knew this woman from stories, that she was the only Queen left on the surface of Etheria. Adora had spoken of horror stories from her childhood reframed by her time away as a monumental victory. How this one woman had beaten back the Horde so thoroughly that they had spent nearly a decade licking its wounds. She certainly looked the part: regal and powerful.

Catra stared up at Queen Angella of Bright Moon as she tried desperately to calm the raging torrent of power flowing through the MoonStone. The woman's face was an implacable mask, serenely calm amidst the storm. Around her guards stood in formation, knights of Brightmoon each proudly wearing their moondrops in open view.

The woman suddenly swooped down on her gossamer thin wings until she was standing in front of a woman standing ready with a tablet. She sighed once and Catra's fine hearing could pick up. Before the woman could say anything, another figure stepped into view which shocked Catra to her core: a magicat wearing sorcerer's robes approached the Queen and bowed deeply. Followed by a peppy looking short woman with glitter in her hair. Who didn't so much bow as shrug and stare up at the moonstone.

The Magicat spoke. "I have run every scan I know, Your Majesty. It might be time to call for my mother. She may know more." The woman's expression soured but she nodded

"Are you certain, Akrash?" When he nodded she sighed. "Call her and your sister too, as much as I am loath to admit it, I do not understand what is happening to the MoonStone and that frightens me a great deal."

The magicat bowed deeply and turned, stepping right through where Catra was standing. The Queen tilted her head slightly, staring at him as he walked away but her gaze didn't follow him, instead settling on her. She could feel her fur stand on end as the Queen began to glow with ethereal power. She had to get away before the Queen realized something was wrong and used the power of the MoonStone to trap her and discover the truth.

She turned to get away from the Queen of Bright Moon, crouching down onto all fours and sprinting away until she reached the end of the bridge and the daymoon was gone. She was standing in a wooded grove, twisting vines and writhing roots filled the clearing, the canopy above cutting off all natural light. Her Magicat eyes quickly adjusted to the dim light; there was a faint blue glow to the area.

Each time she had been brought close to a RuneStone or a Princess, but now she was in the middle of what could only be the Whispering Woods, close to where she had left but with no way of finding her way back home. Her eyes found the source of the light. A sword made of blue crystal and a golden pommel rose out of the dirt and vines wrapped around the blade, holding it upright. The weight of history could be felt, as if anyone who disturbed it would be the one to change the world forever.

What shocked her most was that she recognised the blade. She had traced the pattern of it identically along Adora's arm. The sword had meant something to Adora, to Kesi, to the Celestial Promise. She had told her about it the night after she had received the tattoo, how she had dreamt of a clearing just like this. It was as if someone had taken it from Adora's skin and dreams, forging it into metal. Her blood ran cold at its sight, confirming an impossible meaning into her very bones.

This was the Sword of Protection, the Sword of She-Ra.

She reached forward to touch it but, before her claws could touch the clear metal, she heard a voice calling her back. Melog's

voice pleaded with her to stop, to let go. It was like listening through water.

She surfaced…

The Royal Infirmary

Halfmoon Palace

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

Catra awoke to the gentle *beep beep* of a heart rate monitor, the purring of Kesi and Melog surrounding her, and a distinct appreciation for the suffering of the fried fish that made up her favourite meal. Feeling like she had been steamed alive and hit with the train heading to Catra's Cove all at once.

Melog mewed into the air, informing everyone she was awake. She opened her eyes to the bright light of the infirmary. Kesi was curled up against her on one side, Melog on the other. Sitting nearby half-asleep in a chair was Cyrus. The clock on the wall told her it was way too early to be awake; still deep into the night.

Her father stirred in his chair, his eyes still stained red and his face took on the expression she had only seen a handful of times before, when he thought he personally had failed. In her heart, she knew the next words before he even spoke. She tried to steel herself.

"I'm sorry, Kit. I couldn't save her." His words ended in a choked sob. Even knowing what was coming, knowing that he had failed, that Adora was still out there, knowing she had a destiny before her. It still hit her like a punch in the gut. She tried to stop it but the sob that escaped her woke Kesi, who wrapped herself

around her, pulling her close. Melog crawled into her lap, shrinking down. Both of them knew she had slept through Cyrus' return.

She pulled Melog tight against her chest as they tried to calm her fraying nerves. "Papa, what happened?" She needed answers, not just her best guess, and she needed to hear it from him. "Where is Adora?"

He was shaken—he had clearly been sobbing at one point. Her father always seemed so collected, full of energy. She had never in her life seen him defeated like this. Even after Adora was taken, he was full of energy to get her back. But he had failed.

He drew in a deep breath. "We didn't want to risk you. Either of you." He looked up at her and Kesi, still bleary eyed on the bed. "We got word from one of the agents in the Fright Zone of a brief chance to get in and get out, to rescue Adora—it would last only a few minutes. Your mother wanted to come, but we settled on as few as needed. I only wish with hindsight we'd brought more." He was staring down at his hands, he clenched them suddenly and she saw tiny droplets of blood form in his palms were the claws bit into flesh.

"I don't think it would have made a difference. Please, Catra, don't think about what you would have done. It was an impossible situation. We arrived and split up into teams. I left a team behind to protect the evacuation point, Askar took a team to scour the area around where she should have been, Clover and Lynn took their own teams to do damage to the Horde. Lynn and her team didn't make it back, neither did Askar's team. He's a few rooms over being treated for his injuries."

The Horde had managed to injure Askar, implaccable Askar? The general was an immovable rock against which the Horde broke, not someone to be laid up in hospital being fussed over by Lenio and the nurses.

"Adora had been taken to something called the Black Garnet chamber. We found her second *Ahran*, Askar's old training partner

—a man called Duncan—who was the prisoner of Shadow Weaver. He knows something about Adora but I don't know what. He told us that she had been taken, and he had fought to give time for Princess Scorpia to reach and free her. He trusts her with his life. I went to go after her, when the RuneStones started to go crazy. Our own sorcerers said that it would be too dangerous to try and teleport if we waited too long. Askar was too injured to keep fighting and we were split up." He took a long breath then looked up to meet his daughter's eyes; there were tears leaking from the edges of her vision, his gaze was full of pain. "I gave the order to retreat."

The words landed like a leaden weight between them. "I pray that Scorpia managed to get her out. She'll know to come back to us now that she's free. I have to believe it." His grimace showed he was trying desperately to convince himself. But all Catra could hear was that they had left her behind, left her in the one place she feared so completely. How could this Scorpia get her out of the Horde if the greatest warriors of Halfmoon had failed. Lynn, for all her faults, had been a great warrior, and like an older sister to Adora, treating her like an annoying younger sibling who one day could beat you. She would keep an eye on their escapades when she didn't have her holy duties. She was dead, trying to rescue Adora.

Catra wanted to be sick. Melog mewed again loudly, projecting the anguish into her mind, that the pain of missing her would fade, that she would escape. Melog could not tell the future, but knew Adora through Catra's memories of her, unfiltered and they believed completely that Adora would succeed. She had not seen the Black Garnet in her vision—did that mean something? She had so few answers.

Her voice trembled "I wish you'd told me. I don't want to live without hope, Papa." She tightened her grip around Melog who purred against her chest, trying to soothe her. "Stars Above, I miss her. I could have done—"

Cyrus was suddenly cradling her head in his arms, shushing her like he hadn't done since she was a small child scared of traitors around every corner. A deep purr rumbling up from him to soothe her further. "I'm sorry, I didn't want this to crush you. I thought I could do it. I thought I could bring her home. I don't think if we all went—me, you, and your mother—I don't think we could have gotten her out safely. I'm sorry, Catra. So sorry." She felt his tears in her hair, Kesi pulled herself up to sit slightly to one side sadly staring at her.

Grand Chamber

The High Temple

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

It took a few weeks for Catra to recover enough to leave the infirmary, just in time for the funeral of those lost on the mission, some but not all of the details of which had been made public. The few successes had been celebrated, but everyone could feel the sombre atmosphere of failure.

Kelara had presided over the funerals each in turn, the families each getting the chance to talk to King Cyrus who offered his apologies, commented on their bravery, and their dedication to Halfmoon. When it came time for the final funeral, the number of attendees had dwindled down to almost none. Lynn had few friends and no family beyond the Temple.

Kesi had known her, as had Adora. Constantly as a child Adora, had pestered her to teach her to fight, long before she was apprenticed to Askar. She had often taken her free time to follow after the blonde haired girl who liked to play pranks on others. A silent guardian over their shoulder.

Her body was never recovered and the funeral was held in silence; Catra heard but never quite registered all the prayers. Instead, she sat there staring at the space Adora would have taken up. Did she know how many had died to try and free her? Was she amongst the casualties? Tears streaked down Catra's cheek.

As the ceremony came to a close, Kelara took Kesi to one side and had a conversation with her. She sat in her wheelchair waiting, Caspin sitting to her, left squirming slightly with a desire to move, and behind her, Lyra and Cyrus stood, expressions well controlled.

After a few minutes, Kesi emerged and approached the royals, taking her place at Catra's side. As they turned to leave, Kelara called out, "Your Highness?" They all turned to look at her. She gestured at Catra. "A word, please?" Lyra's hands on the back of her wheelchair tightened.

She looked up into the calm storm that was her mothers face and whispered, "It's okay, Mama. I'll talk to her." She gently pushed her own wheelchair forward.

The old priestess leaned against her staff as Catra approached her. "Your Highness, I have refrained from asking for as long as I can manage. My great-granddaughter approached me shortly after the madness with the RuneStone that you had a strange dream involving Adora?" She leaned forwards. "About her imprisonment, and the magics used upon her. Kesi has told me as much as she is willing to, though it is distressing for her so I have not pushed, but she said you stayed in the dream longer." Catra hesitated for a moment so the old woman continued. "Anything you know that might help us to find her, or to discover what happened. I told some of what Kesi was willing to share to sorcerers of the Temple far more learned than I; you yourself may have theories. But anything relating to Adora may help us save her."

Catra took a deep breath. “What was discussed between me and my *khai’tel* in the privacy of my dream is between me and them. I don’t take kindly to people looking into my life, even with Kesi’s permission.” She stared up at the old priestess as if in challenge; the older woman was always one to push her luck too far. “I can tell you one thing only after Kesi left the dream. It may mean nothing, I hope it is simply wishful thinking, but when Kesi awoke, a voice called out. Unlike anything I had ever heard, almost synthetic like a machine speaking.”

The priestess stared at her wide eyed. “What did it say?”

“It called out, I think to Adora. It asked her if she was willing to fight for the honour of something skull and, when Adora agreed, it asked her to rise as She-Ra.”

The old woman fell backwards onto the steps of the Temple as if struck by a mighty blow. “Are… Are you certain?”

“I would not lie to you, Kelara.” She may not particularly like the old woman, but Adora loved her like the only family she had, and Kesi was still kind to her great-grandmother. “It called her She-Ra, your legendary warrior. It asked her to rise and defend Etheria. After that, I awoke to the madness of the Spirit Ember going wild, and apparently every RuneStone on Etheria doing the same.”

“It is as the prophecy proclaimed” the woman was muttering under her breath. “Oh poor Adora. Sweet child, I should have prepared you better.”

“What are you blathering about?” Catra wanted to scream. Kelara always did this to her, managed to dig into her insecurities and put pressure on open wounds. Adora was likely dead, and if she wasn’t then she had been replaced by She-Ra. Did that change her? Would the weight of the world crush her till she wasn’t that girl who laughed at her choosing clothes all while wearing something that could barely be called a scrap of fabric with a belt? Did destiny care about someone who’s laugh always

ended with them almost snorting water up their nose or would the world take the love of her life and reshape her into something monstrous that can save the world?

The world was a violent and cruel place, ruled by monsters that lurk in the shadows and the powers of the Princesses and Queens are not for the faint of heart, and while Adora was always brave, she was kind and kindness had no place in slaying beasts. She was loving and love has no place in defending the realm, and she was of Halfmoon, and She-Ra everyone agreed was of the world. She would not be able to stay. She would go and leave her behind all over again, through no choice of her own. Because the world decided it was her.

The old woman finished her muttered prayer and looked at her with tears swelling in her eyes. "I never thought…" she wiped them away with her palm. "I am sorry, Your Highness. If what you say is true, and I do not doubt it, then I have failed in my role. I thought as we all did that we would have more time."

She felt a sudden surge of anger at the implication "You knew!" she snarled out. "You knew she was She-Ra!" Her claws flexed outwards without thought. She kept a careful lead on her magic but her physical body reacted instinctively. Kelara raised a placating hand.

"I had my suspicions but nothing I could confirm," she looked over Catra's shoulder to where the rest of the royal family waited, "and I said it would wait until her eighteenth birthday before I brought it up, despite her protests about magic number theories at me. Her destiny is one chosen, and a child cannot and should not be asked to choose. My suspicions may have been wrong; I know now they were not." She sighed, pulling herself to her feet using the staff as leverage. "Yet it was all for naught. Adora was taken. The King was unable to free her, but now I have comfort that it was not through his own failure but the acts of destiny. Adora was meant to remain for only there could she be set on the path to choose her future: to become She-Ra or to return home."

Catra wanted to spit at that. She should come home, fuck becoming She-Ra, she needed to come back home. "She is my *khai'tel.* I know what she will choose." She filled the words with as much acid as she could muster.

"Do you?" The words were whispered.

She wheeled away back to her family, the question burning in the back of her mind.

Royal Meeting Hall

Hallmoon Castle

Halfmoon

Subtheria

Two-and-a-Half Years After Adora's Abduction

It took several more weeks before Catra was allowed out of her wheelchair, during which time the Horde's attacks had become more aggressive, the Fishfolk had begun to make bold faced threats against Halfmoon proper, and the Goblin tribes were growing restless, many of them allying with the Horde.

Halfmoon, it seemed, was surrounded by enemies on all sides, but despite everything, the city continued on. Life went on as normal, the day Catra was finally medically discharged from her attempt to demand knowledge from the RuneStone had the first major change in Halfmoon for many months.

Sea Hawk had returned, another shipment of desired goods to buy and a hold full of shipments from various vendors across Halfmoon to deliver. He alone came with the ship each time, leaving the crew at Catra's Cove, which had grown slightly to become a small town with its own inn. For the first time in generations there were Magicats living close enough to see the

moons as they rose for the day and when they drifted off to sleep. None of the crew commented on the sheer number of Magicats in the village, trusting their captain's word.

When he arrived, he met with Haverisk early. The Minister of Finance had a vested interest in keeping the pirate a wealthy man in exchange for access to the best deals Salineas and other kingdoms could offer. But once he had disentangled himself from the old Magicat and had gotten nearly all of the supplies carefully within a warehouse that his clients could pick up their goods from, he had made his way to the Castle.

Lyra always had time for the scoundrel; he was a master of bribery in the forms of exotic tea and honey. An expert storyteller that could keep Caspin entertained, and he often brought news from outside of Halfmoon—perhaps his most valuable commodity.

While Catra longed to stretch her legs, go down into the marketplace and meet with some of Kesi’s friends and unwind. She instead found herself seated on a plush chair as the pirate spoke of some grandiose tale of adventure against some giant sea serpent to entertain the Princeps. She wanted to snap at him when the doorway opened admitting Lyra and Cyrus. Percival followed shortly after carrying several steaming cups of a new tea blend that Sea Hawk had thought to bring along with him.

“A story to finish later, young Princeps.” He smiled a broad grin then dropped into a deep bow as Lyra sat. “My beautiful Queen, you grow more fierce and regal by the day.” Behind her, Cyrus let out a low growl. “And my good King, your ferocity is matched only by your ever so handsome features; the additional scars make your visage only more dashing.”

“Cut it, Sea Hawk,” Cyrus’ voice was exhausted. He ran his fingers over a very faint new scar on his check where a Horde bot exploding had managed to wing him slightly on the exit. It was little more than a scratch and he had hardly noticed it until a few hours after the escape but it scarred over. The kind of details

someone less observant might miss easily. “You would only talk to all of us at once if you have something big.”

The pirate nodded. “Indeed, I do.” He took a seat and a cup of tea, taking a sip to pause for dramatic effect. “King Mercia has retired the throne, leaving it to his daughter and my dearest friend Princess Mermista.” Dearest Friend Mermista; everyone knew that Sea Hawk was madly in love with the Princess and, for all his flirting with seemingly anyone willing to either listen or be flustered by it. Sea Hawk had eyes only for the Princess of Salineas.

Lyra nodded, matters of succession were dramatic news, and Sea Hawk’s previous times in the city had brought similar updates of every major kingdom on Etheria. “Congratulations to her,” Cyrus said.

Sea Hawk chuckled again. “She has mentioned a few times the fine dresses that I always seem to procure for her that are so different to all the other dress makers in Salineas. I have mentioned to her,” he nodded to Catra as a clear part of her plan to expand Halfmoon, “that the designers of such fashion and other goods I bring to market that are unknown to her have not escaped her notice. So, she has requested a chance to meet this community.”

“A diplomatic meeting!” Catra stood immediately; this was exactly what she had hoped for. Lyra held up her hand to try and calm Catra down.

“I doubt the Council will agree to it.” Lyra sounded exhausted as she took several sips of her tea. Cyrus fidgeted with his tail in his lap before looking up.

“Then we don’t leave it up to the Council.” Every head turned to look at him as Sea Hawk’s face broke into a grin. “If it’s declared as an act of defense against the Fishmen as part of the royal decree that led to the opening of the cove in the first place, like some of Imoh’s lot are pushing for with their aggression, we

can declare it a diplomatic mission to obtain allies. Haverisk will agree to the plan regardless. The traditionalists may complain but when don't they. If we can get Cloudfoot on our side," he glanced over at Percival's impassive features, "then we can swing the Council anyway. But to rescue Adora, I'd say it's an emergency." Seahawk looked confused at the last bit but was nodding along to the plan aside from that.

Lyra nodded wearily, then turned to Catra "Sea Hawk can remain here for a week or so. Once he leaves, I'll make sure you're able to go with him. Kesi will almost certainly join you. Pick out some guards and staff. I will make sure you are able to leave, secure us a treaty with Salineas, then find Adora. In that order please, my heart. I will make sure the Council understands the importance of this mission even if I have to string Imoh up by his ears to do it." She sounded like she was trying desperately not to hope for anything.

It took all of Catra's strength not to launch at Mama and wrap her up in a hug. This would be her chance to get to the surface, to finally experience Etheria's moons. To find Adora and bring her back home.

So, several days later, her diplomatic convoy was gathered on the docks awaiting a train to take them out of Halfmoon and out to the sea aboard the *Heart of Halfmoon,* officially the only ship in the employ of Halfmoon. The crew consisted of: herself, Kesi—who refused to be left behind and she would never leave her anyway—Kittrina—the Captain of the Royal Guard refused to let the Crown Princess wander on the surface without protection—Tigria and Tyril—the two twins had served Kittrina for long enough that they were officially part of Catra's permanent guard duty—and Elara—the old scout had been on the surface more than anyone else and had little ties left to Halfmoon after the loss of her wife. Plus a half dozen more members of the royal household staff, several guardsmen, and a pair of cave culture folk who Kesi vouched for.

The train rattled on through the underground chasms and to a future hopefully full of brightness, but as Sea Hawk had said to her at least once, even the calmest and brightest of days can turn into a sudden storm swifter than the wind. She would guide Halfmoon to victory regardless of the storm that lay ahead of them.

Chapter End Notes

TP9829: Absolutely mad how much this has spiraled out. I have had an absolute blast writing this fic series and we have many more to come. This marks the end of effectively act 2ish or 1.5. Soon we'll see whats happening with Adora and spend a lot more time with the Spellas. Thank you everyone for reading and commenting.

Zelenal: And, with that, *Heroes of Halfmoon*, as well as Act 2 Part 1, is now complete! It's crazy to think that this AU has gotten so far and is over 200k words. As a reminder, the very first entry in this sum'bitch was a glorified shitpost. You have tp to thank for that, especially since she's written the majority of this AU when going by word count.

Some sad news: we won't be seeing Catra and co for a while. We know so little about Salineas in *Defiance* so we have to wait for the story to get there first. That being said, we do have a surprise coming up eventually.

Next up, we'll be back with Adora, Scorpia, and the Bright Moon gang for *Birth of the Golden Lion*. It's She-Ra time, baby!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!